

WHILE YOU LIVE · BOOK 3

355

Andrew F. Young



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Everybody Was Lying

I hung the coat up on the Thursday night, as soon as I got home.

It was the green one. Long wool, a hood that folded into the collar, pockets deep enough for two notebooks and a recorder. I had bought it the winter I was working on the Carrow House story, and taken it out of the closet again in March, because he had told me to bring a warmer coat, and for nine Thursdays I had worn it up and down his porch steps while he told me about the North Atlantic. The button that had hung by a thread all spring was back where it belonged. I'd sewn it on myself, at the kitchen table, one night at the end of April, while Freda typed beside me. The moth hole in the sleeve was still there. I left it.

You won't need the coat for this one, he had said, from the top of the steps, in his shirtsleeves. *It was summer. And everybody was lying.*

I put it at the back of the hall closet, behind the vacuum cleaner, and shut the door on it. Then I stood in the hall for a moment with my hand on the knob, because it felt like shutting a door on more than a coat, and I'm not a sentimental person, and I didn't like it.



If you don't know me, here is the short version.

My name is Iola Barnett. I used to be a reporter. Six years ago I broke a story about forged letters being sold as genuine at Carrow House, the old auction house downtown, and three days after it ran, the man who gave me the story disappeared. I called him Bookbinder, in my notebook, and nowhere else. Without him nobody believed a word I'd written. The paper printed a correc-

tion and let me go. Since then I've written whatever people pay me to write: gutter guards, dentists, houses that need to sound bigger than they are.

Last October a law firm wrote to me on behalf of a client who wouldn't give his name. The client wanted me to drive north every Thursday, to a small house on a gravel road in Adams County, Pennsylvania, and record the memories of an old man who lived there alone with a great many books. His name, as far as anybody knew, was Tom Hale. He told me, the first day, that he had been in Washington the night Lincoln was shot. He didn't mean he'd read about it. He meant he had been there, in another body, with his own mind, and that it had happened to him a great many times, in a great many places, and that he didn't know why.

I didn't believe him. I want to be clear about that. I spent the winter not believing him and checking everything he said, and finding that everything I could check, checked out. Then a card came from the client, in a shaking hand, asking about a ship called the *Carpathia*, and I spent the spring the same way, only worse, because by then I liked him.

The client pays six thousand dollars a session. Twice now, when a part of the story was over, he has sent a great deal more. My daughter types the transcripts for fifteen dollars an hour. Her father, who left when she was seven, is back in her life on terms we agreed at this kitchen table, written on the back of a gas bill. He fixed the kitchen tap last weekend. It doesn't drip. I have checked.

That's where we were, the first week of May. And then the next card came.



Please ask him about New York. 1780.

Freda had asked me, the night it came, what happened in New York in 1780, and I had said I didn't know. It was true. I knew there had been a war. I knew roughly who won it. I'd been to Yorktown on a school trip and remembered the gift shop better than the battlefield.

So on the Thursday night, with the coat in the closet and Freda at the kitchen table typing the porch tape, I opened the laptop at the other end of the table and looked it up, the way anybody would.

New York in 1780, it turned out, was a British city. They had taken it in the summer of 1776, a few weeks after the Declaration, and held it for seven years, until the very end of the war. Washington's army sat out in the hills of New Jersey and up the Hudson, looking at it. The British sat in it, looking back. Most of what happened between them in 1780 happened in the dark.

"He said he was on the losing side," I said.

Freda took one side of her headphones off. "What?"

"Tom. He said he was on the other side of it. The British." I scrolled. "In 1780 they were in New York. The whole city. And he said he spent two years there hunting a spy."

"So he's a spy now."

"He said he was hunting one."

"Same thing." She pulled her chair round the corner of the table so she could see my screen, which she has done since she was four, and which I have never once managed to stop. "Which spy?"

I typed *spy New York 1780* and the internet, which had been waiting all its life for that question, told me.

There was a ring of them. Washington's own spies, inside British New York, sending him letters across Long Island and over the water in whaleboats. Written in invisible ink, some of them. Coded with numbers. They had a name, the Culper Ring, and a television show, and a great many websites with a great many exclamation marks. And on almost every one of those websites, somewhere near the top, there was a woman.

"Agent 355," Freda read, over my shoulder. "A female spy whose real identity has never been discovered." She sat back. "Okay. That's actually cool."

"It says she was arrested."

"It says she died on a prison ship." Freda leaned in again. "Having a baby. Oh, that's so sad. Wait." She pointed. "That one says nobody knows if she was arrested at all. And that one says she might not have been a spy, she might have just been, like, somebody's friend." She frowned at the screen. "They can't all be right."

"No," I said. "They can't."

It is a very particular feeling, reading a story online that everybody tells and nobody has checked. I used to get it in the newsroom, about once a week. The same quote passed from site to site with the same commas in it. The same date, wrong in the same way. Somebody, somewhere, a long time ago, had said a thing, and everybody since had been too pleased with it to look.

I wrote 355 in my notebook, and next to it, *check*. Then I underlined *check*, which I don't usually do.



The other name was easier. Everybody knew the other name.

Benedict Arnold had been an American general, one of the best they had, a hero. In the summer of 1780 he was given command of West Point, a fortress on the Hudson that both armies thought of as the key to the river. And he had been writing to the British for more than a year, in code, offering to sell it to them.

The man he wrote to was a young British officer called John André. In September of 1780 André went up the river to meet Arnold in the night and settle the price. On the way back he was stopped on a country road by militiamen, three of them in the usual telling, and they searched him, and found the plans of West Point in his boots. Arnold got away, to the British, and lived a long time, rich and despised. André was hanged.

"He was thirty," Freda said, reading. "The British guy." She scrolled down. "Everybody liked him. Even Washington's people. It says some of Washington's own officers cried." She was quiet for a moment. "That's weird. Why would you cry over the enemy?"

"Maybe he was very likeable."

"That's what everybody says about Mr. Hale," Freda said, "and you still check everything he tells you."

I looked at her. She was sixteen, and her father's height, and she had found her father by herself, last fall, with nothing to go on but a postmark and a staff page on a hardware store's website, and not told me for seven months. She checked things too. She had learned it somewhere.

"Summer," I said. "He said it was summer."

“In 1780?”

“When he said I wouldn’t need the coat. He said, *it was summer, and everybody was lying.*”

Freda looked at the screen. Arnold, writing his letters. André, going up the river in the dark. The ring in the city with their invisible ink and their numbers. A woman nobody could name.

“Well,” she said. “He wasn’t wrong.”

She put her headphones back on and pulled her chair back round to her own end of the table, and went on typing him. On the porch tape, through the tinny leak of her headphones, I could hear his voice, small and warm and very far away, telling her about a boy who carried bags in a hotel in Manhattan in 1912 and sent his wages home to Liverpool.



I didn’t sleep much.

It wasn’t the war. I went to bed thinking about the war, and Arnold, and a hanged man the enemy cried over, and I suppose I did think, as I lay there, that it would be strange to hear Tom tell it from the British side, after a winter of hearing him tell Lincoln from the wrong side of that one too. He had a habit, I was beginning to see, of having been where he shouldn’t.

But that wasn’t what kept me up. What kept me up was my own notebook, on the kitchen table, under the lamp, where I’d left it open.

I had written a name in it on Wednesday, in the car, at the bottom of a cul-de-sac in Frederick. Not my source’s name. I have never written his name down, not once in eight months of reporting and not in the years since. Another name, a man in a bow tie in the front of an auction catalog, smiling, with his arm around my source’s shoulders. Gerald Whitcombe. Director of Conservation and Manuscripts at Carrow House for forty years. My source’s teacher. Seventy-nine now, a widower, retired to a stone house on forty acres in the hunt country of Virginia, an hour and a half west of my kitchen table.

On the morning my source disappeared, six years ago, a woman on the floor below him heard somebody knock on his door, and heard him let them in, and heard a man laugh on the stairs. A big laugh. Too big. She wrote it down in a

composition book, because she wrote everything down. And an hour before I wrote that name, in her son's house, with her eyes closed and her small cold hands folded on that composition book, she had listened to Gerald Whitcombe laugh in a video of a talk he gave every spring to a historical society. She said, *That's him.*

It wasn't proof. It was a laugh. An old woman's memory of a laugh, through a ceiling, six years ago. No lawyer alive would let me print it, and I knew it, and so did Tom. He hadn't said a word about it on the porch except the only thing that mattered.

That morning, the woman downstairs had heard two people go down the stairs with something heavy, twice. She had heard a car in the alley, and its engine running, a long time, and the doors. Two car doors. Not three.

Somebody had stayed in the car. Somebody had sat in that alley with the engine running for twenty-seven minutes while two men carried my source's life down the stairs, and then driven them away.

At one in the morning I got up and went into the kitchen in my socks. Freda's laptop was shut. The house ticked. Out on the street a car went by slowly, the way they do at that hour, and its lights moved across the ceiling and were gone.

I sat down at the table, under the lamp, and turned to the page with the name on it, and under *Gerald Whitcombe*, in pencil, I wrote it again, the thing I'd said to Tom on the porch and he had said back to me, smiling.

Who was driving?

Then I sat and looked at it for a long time, in the quiet, in a warm kitchen in May, with the window open a crack and the first moths of the year bumping softly at the screen.

The Side That Let Me In

The hay was down in the long field when I drove up on the Thursday, cut and lying in rows to dry, and the whole valley smelled of it with the windows open. I had never been up there in hay weather. In the fall it had been leaves and woodsmoke, and in the spring it had been mud, and now it was this, sweet and heavy and a little like tea, and for the last mile of the gravel road I drove slowly so it would last.

He was on the porch bench, in his shirtsleeves again, with the cardigan folded beside him out of habit. He didn't need it. It was eighty degrees at eleven in the morning. When he saw the car he raised one hand off the rail, the way he had the week before, and I came up the steps and sat in my chair, and put the two recorders on the little table between us, and he watched me do it with the look he had for small rituals.

"You found the coat a good home," he said.

"Back of the closet. Behind the vacuum."

"Good." He looked out at the field.

I started both recorders. The red lights came on. "Session twenty-nine," I said to them. "Thursday, the thirteenth of May."

"You said it was summer," I said.

"It was."

"I looked it up. You said you spent two years in New York hunting a spy. I found the spies. And I found Benedict Arnold, and Major André, and a lot of websites about a woman called Agent 355."

He turned his head and looked at me, and something happened at the corner of his mouth that wasn't quite a smile.

"Did you," he said.

"They don't agree about her. Some of them say she was arrested and died on a prison ship. Some of them say she had a baby on it. One of them says nobody knows anything about her at all."

"That one's right."

"So she was real."

"There was no Agent 355," he said. "Nobody in that war was ever called that. It was made up a long time afterward, by people who liked the sound of it." He settled back against the porch wall. "Washington's spies wrote to each other in a little code. They had a book of numbers, each number a word, so a letter that fell into the wrong hands would read like a page out of an almanac. Seven hundred and eleven was Washington. Seven hundred and twenty-seven was New York. Three hundred and fifty-five," he said, "was the word *lady*."

I wrote that down. I wrote it down exactly, and the number, and then I looked at it.

"Just lady," I said.

"Just lady. One of them used it once, in one letter, in August of my first summer there. He wrote that he meant to go into New York, past the men searching everybody at the ferry, *by the assistance of a lady of my acquaintance*. That's the whole of her. One line. A word in a code book. Everything else people have said about her since, they made up because one line wasn't enough for them."

"Was she real?" I said. "The lady."

He didn't answer straight away. Down in the field a pair of crows had come down on the hay rows and were walking along them like men inspecting a fence.

"Oh, yes," he said. "She was real."

And then he didn't say anything else about her at all, and I knew him well enough by then to know that he wasn't going to, not that day, and that I'd be a fool to push. He'd done it to me all winter and all spring, set something down on the table between us and left it there. I'd never marked those places. That

day I did. I drew a small circle in the margin next to *lady*, so I'd know where to come back to. It seemed like the year to start.



"Why the British?" I said.

I'd been carrying it since the porch the week before, and I'd meant to come to it slowly. It came out instead, the way questions do when you've practiced them too much in the car.

"I asked you, in the winter, why the Confederate side," I said. "You said you didn't choose. You woke up in a body that was already wearing the uniform. Is that what happened again?"

"No," he said. "Not this time. This time I chose."

"Why?"

"Because they let me in."

I waited. He looked at me, and I saw him decide something, the way I had seen him decide things all winter: not whether to tell me, I think, but how much it was going to cost to say it plainly, and whether I was going to be worth the cost. Then he folded his hands on his knee.

"My name that time was Caesar," he said. "I woke up in him in the winter of 1778, in the dark, in a loft over a barn in Westchester County, north of New York, under a horse blanket, with two other men breathing next to me. He was about twenty-nine years old. He was strong, and he'd been worked hard all his life, and he belonged to a man called Reynolds, who had a farm with good bottom land and a captain's commission in the rebel militia." He paused. "He was owned, Ms. Barnett. That body was owned. That's how I came into that war."

I didn't say anything. I don't think there was anything to say. In the field the crows went up all at once, for no reason I could see, and came down again further along.

"You don't have to make a face," he said, gently. "You're thinking of the winter. Of the Keene farm in Maryland, and Damon, who worked it twenty years for nothing and read in secret, fast, when nobody was looking. And now me, here, on the other end of the same thing."

"Something like that."

“It’s the same thing,” he said. “It’s exactly the same thing, eighty-five years earlier and two hundred miles north. Slavery wasn’t a Southern word yet, in 1778. There were more enslaved people in New York City than in any city in the North. It was everywhere. It was normal. The men who signed the Declaration of Independence owned people while they signed it, some of them, and the men I’d be fighting the next two years were fighting for liberty with their own property waiting at home to bring in the hay.” He looked at the field. “Captain Reynolds was a decent man by the measure of his neighbors. He went to church. He didn’t beat anybody that I saw. He believed every word of the Declaration. He just didn’t think it meant me.”



“I want to tell you how it felt,” he said, after a while, “so that you understand the rest. Not because it’s the interesting part. It’s not the interesting part. But I’d be lying to you about the whole two years if I skipped it.”

“All right.”

“I’ve woken up in a great many bodies,” he said. “I told you that, the first day. Some of them were rich. Some of them were sick. Some of them were children, which is its own kind of prison. But I had never once, in all of it, woken up as property. As a thing on a list, between the plow and the cow, with a value written next to me in a man’s account book.” He was quiet a moment. “The first morning, I went out to the barn with the other two men in the dark, and I did the work, because the body knew how, and I watched my own hands do it. And around noon, Reynolds came out of the house with his account book under his arm, to count the hay, and he looked straight at me, and I understood that he wasn’t seeing anybody. He was seeing a pair of arms he’d paid for. And I had been, in that life and a hundred others, a man people listened to.”

“What did you do?”

“I did the work,” he said. “For six months. I didn’t have a choice. The roads were watched by both armies, and by men who weren’t in either one, who’d sell a runaway back to his owner for a reward or to somebody else for more. There was nowhere to go. I’d have been dead or sold before I reached the river.” He turned one hand over on his knee and looked at the palm. “So I learned. That

body knew every road in that county, and every ford, and every farm, and which dogs bit. It knew horses better than I've ever known them in any life since. It knew how to read the ice on a pond from a hundred yards away. Those were his, not mine. He'd learned them from being sent everywhere, all his life, to fetch and carry. And I learned the rest. Who was on which side. Which neighbor was a rebel and which one was only pretending to be, for safety. Where the British lines were, down at Kingsbridge, and how the men who crossed them did it."

"And then you crossed."

"In June of 1779," he said. "Because of two pieces of paper."



He told me about the two pieces of paper the way he'd told me about the knots and the coal in the Carpathia's stokehold, in March: slowly, with numbers, as if he wanted me to be able to check every one of them later. Which I did.

The first was older, and it wasn't even New York's. In November of 1775, at the very beginning of the war, the British governor of Virginia, Lord Dunmore, had promised freedom to any enslaved man who belonged to a rebel and could carry a gun for the King. Only rebels' men, only men who could fight, only in Virginia. But word of it went everywhere. It went up and down the coast in a few weeks, in the way that news goes when the people carrying it can't read and can't be stopped from talking.

"Every enslaved man in Westchester knew about Dunmore," he said, "years before I got there. They'd talked about nothing else. And they knew what happened to most of the men who went: they died of smallpox in camps on the Virginia shore. The other two in that loft could tell you the whole story of it, and they did, at night, over and over. It was the only story they had that went anywhere."

The second paper was the one that mattered. In June of 1779, the British commander in New York, Sir Henry Clinton, issued a proclamation from a place called Philipsburg, up the Hudson. He said that any enslaved person who ran away from a rebel master to the British lines would be given full security, inside those lines, to follow any occupation he thought proper.

“Full security,” Tom said. “To follow any occupation which he shall think proper. I can still say it. I read it over a hundred times, because I wanted to find the word that wasn’t in it.”

“Which word?”

“*Free*,” he said. “It isn’t there. It never once says free. It says you’ll be safe and you can work, which isn’t the same thing at all, and a man who reads the way I read could see exactly how much room the King’s lawyers had left themselves. It said nothing about Loyalists’ people. A man who belonged to a Loyalist could run to the British and be handed straight back. And it said that any Black man taken in arms in the rebel army would be bought from whoever caught him, at a fixed price, like a horse.” He shook his head slightly. “It was a careful piece of paper. It was written by men who wanted the rebels’ farms emptied of workers, and didn’t want to frighten their own side, and didn’t much mind what happened to anybody in between.”

“So why go?”

“Because of the other one.” He held up one finger. “A few weeks before Clinton’s proclamation, the commandant of New York City, a general called Daniel Jones, issued an order to his own officers, plainer than anything his commander ever signed. One line. *All Negroes that fly from the Enemy’s Country are Free.*” He let it sit a moment. “Free. Capital F. In a general order, in New York, in June of 1779. That one made it up to the farms in about a week, the same way Dunmore had.”

I wrote *Gen. Daniel Jones, June 1779, “Free”* in my notebook and drew a box round it. I could see him watching me do it.

“Check it,” he said. “People get his name wrong. Somebody misprinted it once, in a good history people trust, as David. It was Daniel.”



He went in at noon and came out with lunch on a tray: cold chicken, a loaf of the bread from the bakery in town, which had opened again, and a jar of iced tea with mint in it from the bed by the back step. We ate on the porch with the plates on our knees and the recorders running between us. He ate more than I’d

seen him eat in weeks. I noticed it, and I wrote it down, small, at the bottom of the page, the way I write down everything.

“How did you get away?” I said. “In June.”

“I walked.” He tore a piece of bread in half. “Reynolds sent me to a mill on the Croton with a wagon of grain, on a Saturday, alone, because I’d been there a dozen times and always come back. I left the wagon at the mill, with the grain still in it and the horses fed and watered, so nobody could say I’d stolen a single thing from him. And I walked south. Two nights, through the Neutral Ground. That’s what they called the country between the armies, thirty miles of it, where neither side could keep order and both sides’ bandits did as they liked. I slept in the day in a hollow by a creek. I knew every road, so I didn’t use any of them.” He chewed. “The second night I came down to the British lines at Kingsbridge, at the top of Manhattan Island, and walked up to a picket of Hessians with my hands open, and said, in English, that I was come in on the General’s proclamation. They didn’t understand a word. They sent for somebody who did.”

“And they let you in.”

“They let me in.” He set the bread down. “I’ve been asked, more than once, in more than one century, how I could have served the King against a country being born. That’s how. I knocked on a door, and one side opened it, and the other side owned me.” He looked at me. “I don’t say the British were good. They weren’t, particularly. Their officers used men like me exactly as long as we were useful, and their Loyalist friends in the city spat at us in the street. Half the men who came in on those proclamations died of fever in the camps. Some of them were sold to the West Indies by the very officers who’d promised them security. The British were the side that wanted something from me. That’s all. But they were the side that let me in.”

“You said last week,” I said, carefully, “that you’d never decided how you felt about it. About losing. About there being a country, partly because you lost.”

“I haven’t.”

“Because of this.”

“Because of this,” he said. “Britain passed the law ending slavery in its empire in 1833. In this country it took another thirty years, and a war that killed

more than six hundred thousand. If the side I was on that summer had won..." He stopped himself, and shook his head. "No. That's the kind of sum I don't do. You can't run history backward and pick out the parts you like. A different war is a different everything. Maybe it ends sooner. Maybe it never ends at all. I don't know. Nobody knows." He looked out at the field. "I only know that I've lived in this country a long time, since. I've loved it. I still do. And that the first time I ever saw it, it was a man in a militia coat counting me with his hay."



We didn't do any more 1780 that day. I think we both knew we wouldn't. At half past two he said he'd start properly next Thursday, at the beginning, at Kingsbridge, if I'd bring a fresh notebook, and I said I always did.

I put the recorders in my bag. Then I stopped, on the top step, because there was a question I'd forgotten I had, and it had come back to me with the hay smell, the way things come back.

"What was his name?" I said. "Caesar what?"

He had picked up the cardigan, out of habit, though he didn't need it. He held it in both hands.

"He didn't have one," he said. "Not when I woke up in him. He was Reynolds's Caesar, the way the gray mare was Reynolds's gray mare. That's how they wrote him down." He folded the cardigan over his arm. "The British wanted a surname, for their books. The officer at Kingsbridge asked me for one, that first night, with his pen over the page. A lot of men who came in that year took their master's name, because it was the only one they'd ever been called. I wasn't going to do that."

"What did you tell him?"

"Freeman," he said. "Caesar Freeman. It was the first thing I'd owned in that body. I chose it myself, with a Hessian holding a lantern over me, and I watched him write it down." He smiled, very slightly. "He spelled it right. I checked."

I went down the steps and across the gravel to the car. When I looked back, he had gone in, and the door was open behind him, and through it I could see the mantel and the empty frame, and the hay smell came across the yard on the

heat, and somewhere in the field the crows were still walking up and down the rows, counting.

Kingsbridge

He'd made the tea before I got there, and it was already on the kitchen table in the brown pot. I set out the recorders and said the date into them. *Session thirty, Thursday, May twentieth.*

"Kingsbridge," he said. "June. The middle of the night."

June 1779

The Hessian who found me that night was about nineteen, and frightened, and trying very hard not to look it, and I liked him at once.

He was standing in the road at the top of the Kingsbridge lines with his musket across his body and a lantern on a pole stuck in the ditch beside him, which is the worst place a picket can put his lantern, because it shows the enemy exactly where he is and blinds him to everything outside its circle. I had watched him from the trees for half an hour. He had not looked into the dark once. He had looked at the lantern, mostly, the way you look at a fire.

So I came out of the trees slowly, into the edge of the light, with my hands open in front of me so he could see they were empty, and I said, in English, clearly, as I'd practiced it on the walk down, "I am come in on the General's proclamation."

He pointed his musket at my stomach and shouted something in German. Then he shouted it again, louder, as men do with foreigners, and backed up two steps into the lantern pole and nearly knocked it into the ditch.

I didn't move. I said it again, the same words, the same tone. *I am come in on the General's proclamation.* Then I said it in German, as well as I could, which wasn't very well. I hadn't spoken German in that life, or for a long time before

it, and the body's mouth had never made those sounds. It came out like a man talking with stones in his cheeks. But he understood the word *General*, and he understood that I wasn't running, and after a while he stopped shouting and shouted instead, over his shoulder, for somebody called Friedrich.

Friedrich was older and had a lantern of his own and a pipe in his mouth, and he looked at me for a long time without saying anything. Then he took the pipe out and said, in English nearly as bad as my German, "Run from rebel?"

"Yes."

"Which rebel?"

"Captain Joseph Reynolds," I said. "Of the Westchester militia."

That mattered more than anything else I'd say that night, and I knew it. The proclamation covered a man who ran from a rebel. It didn't cover a man who ran from a Loyalist. If my master had been a friend to the King, the King's soldiers would have tied my hands and walked me back up the road to him in the morning, and been paid for it. Everything turned on Reynolds being what he was. I was ready to prove it six ways if they asked: his company, his lieutenant's name, the house where they mustered, the tavern where they drank afterward. They didn't ask. Friedrich only nodded, as if he'd heard all of it before, which I suppose he had, many times that month, and jerked his head toward the dark behind the lines.

"Come," he said.



They kept me that night in a barn at the back of the post, with two other men who'd come in the same week. One was from New Jersey, a big quiet man who had come across the Hudson in a stolen boat and didn't want to talk about it. The other was a boy of fifteen or so from somewhere near Tarrytown, who wanted to talk about nothing else and couldn't stop. He'd been there four days. He had a blanket, and he shared it, and he told me everything he knew about what happened next, most of which was wrong.

In the morning an English officer came out with a book under his arm.

It was the book I'd been waiting for, though I didn't know that's what it would look like. A long ledger, bound in brown calf, half full already, with col-

umns ruled down each page in red ink. The officer was a lieutenant, young and sunburned, with a cold, and he sat on an upturned bucket in the barn door and opened the ledger on his knee and dipped his pen and asked us, one at a time, our names.

I've told you about that already. *Caesar*. And what else? *Freeman*. He wrote it, and spelled it right, and I read it upside down from four feet away while he blotted it, and in that moment I had it, the whole page, every name above mine. Twenty-two of them. Where each man came from. Whom he had belonged to. Which ones could drive a team or swing an axe or handle a boat. And a note in the margin by one name from the week before, in a different hand: *Returned to owner, a loyal subject*.

It was the first time I understood what that body could do.



I should tell you about it properly, because it's the reason for everything that happened to me over the next two years, and I didn't understand it myself for a long time.

Caesar's body had a memory such as I've never had before or since, in any life. I don't mean a good memory. I've had good memories. I mean that anything his eyes fell on stayed, as it was, as long as I lived in him. A page, a face, a list of numbers, the pattern of a quilt on a bed I walked past once. I didn't have to try. It went in like light into a room. And afterward, if I wanted it, I could go back and stand in front of it and read it off again, as if I were holding the paper.

Caesar himself had never known. How could he? He couldn't read. Nobody had ever let him. All his life he'd had the most remarkable eyes in the county and nothing to point them at but fields and cattle and the roads he was sent down. He'd known every road, and every farm, and every horse he'd ever handled, better than any man alive, and everybody thought him slow, because he didn't say much, and because he was owned, and people find it very easy to think slowly of anyone they own.

I could read. I'd been reading for two thousand years. Put my reading behind his eyes, and the two of us together could take in a page at a glance and keep it.

It was a gift, Ms. Barnett. It was also the most dangerous thing about me, and I knew that by the second day.



Because I couldn't let a soul know I could read.

You have to understand how a Black man reading looked in 1779, in British New York, to the people who held the power over him. The British officers didn't much care, one way or the other, as long as you were useful. But the British officers weren't the city. The city was full of Loyalists, men who'd lost their farms and their businesses to the rebels and run to New York with nothing, and a good many of them had brought their own enslaved people with them, or meant to get them back. To them a reading Black man was a man who could forge a pass. He could read a newspaper and learn the war was going badly. He could write a letter to a rebel. He was the worst thing they could imagine.

And a Black man suspected of anything, in that city, had nobody. No court. The city was under the army, and the army's justice ran up a chain of officers who might hear him or might not, depending on their dinner. I watched a man taken off the street outside a tavern in Queen Street, that first summer, because a Loyalist merchant said he'd seen him reading a handbill on a wall. He was a free man, born free on Long Island. He had his papers in his coat. It took him six weeks to get out of the Provost, and he came out with his papers gone.

So I learned to look at a page without looking at it. A glance, while I was doing something else. Holding a horse beside a man reading a letter. Carrying a candle past a desk. Standing behind a chair. One look, and I'd have it, and then I'd look away and never look back. The glance was all I ever got, all those two years. It was all I ever needed.



They took me to Colonel Robinson on the third day.

Beverley Robinson was a Virginian by birth, which nobody ever let you forget, and a New Yorker by marriage. He'd married a Philipse, one of the great land families of the Hudson, and before the war he had owned a great part of

the Highlands, up the river, and lived in a fine house there among his tenants like a duke. The rebels took the house and the land when he wouldn't swear to them. He came down to New York, raised a regiment of Loyalists at his own expense, and spent the rest of the war trying to get his country back, and, I think, his house.

He was nearly sixty then, heavy and gray and courteous, with a gentleman's soft voice and the patience of a man who has spent his life collecting rents. And he collected information the way he'd collected rents: steadily, from everybody, without ever seeming to ask. Every man who came in through the lines from Westchester was sent to him sooner or later, because Westchester was his country, and nobody knew it better.

Until I came.

He saw me in a farmhouse behind the lines that his officers used, in a room with a table and two chairs and a map of the county on the wall, painted, very fine, with the farms marked in tiny red squares and the names written beside them in a careful copperplate hand. He sat in one chair. He didn't offer me the other, and I didn't expect it. A clerk sat in the corner with a writing board on his knee.

"You're Reynolds's man," he said. "From Bedford."

"I was, sir."

"I knew Reynolds's father." He looked at me for a while, pleasantly. "Tell me how you came down."

So I told him. The mill on the Croton, the wagon left with the grain still in it. The two nights. The hollow by the creek where I slept in the day. And because I could see the map on the wall behind him, and because I could see, as I talked, that it was wrong, I told him that too, without seeming to.

"I didn't come by the Post Road, sir," I said. "There's a picket at the Hammond place now, since the spring. They moved it from the crossroads." His map had it at the crossroads. "And I didn't come by the Saw Mill road, because the bridge over the river at Odell's is down. It went in the April flood."

His clerk stopped writing. Robinson didn't turn round to look at his map. He didn't have to. He knew perfectly well what was on it.

"The bridge at Odell's," he said.

“Yes, sir. Half of it. You can still get a man across. Not a horse.”

He looked at me with a different sort of attention then. Not suspicion, exactly. More the look a man gives a field he has driven past for years, when he notices for the first time that it's better land than he thought.

“Tell me the rest,” he said. “Everything you passed. Every house, and who's in it now.”

It took me two hours. I gave him every farm between Bedford and Kingsbridge, all of them, the way Caesar had known them from twenty years of being sent down those roads, and everything I had added to it myself in the six months I'd been in him. Who'd gone over to the rebels and who was only pretending, for safety. Which houses had men in them who'd been out with the militia and which had men hiding in the cellar from it. Where the rebel guard boats lay up on the river, and which widow on the Sawmill River took in their wounded. The clerk filled six sheets. Robinson listened to all of it without interrupting, and at the end he sat for a moment, quite still, and then stood up and took a quill and went to his own map on the wall, and moved the picket from the crossroads to the Hammond place, and drew a small neat line through the bridge at Odell's.

“You'll guide for us,” he said, with his back to me. “There's a fee. The Quartermaster General keeps the guides on his books. You'll be paid by the day when we use you and not when we don't, and you'll come when you're sent for, day or night.” He turned round. “Can you ride?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Can you read?”

He said it in exactly the same voice. Pleasantly. As if it were the next question on a list. I suppose it was. Behind him on the table, under his hand, there was a letter he'd been reading when I came in, face up, and I had read it, all of it, at a glance, through the door, before I'd taken my second step into the room. A report from one of his agents in the Highlands. Eight lines about the rebels' boats at Peekskill.

“No, sir,” I said.

He looked at me a moment longer. Then he nodded, and sat down, and folded the letter in half, without hurrying, and put it in his coat.



That was how it started. A guide, on the books, at a fee by the day.

They gave me a paper with Robinson's name on it, to show any sentry who stopped me, and a place to sleep in a long wooden shed by the North River, near the Commons, with other men who'd come in the same way and worked for the army: wagoners, axemen, men who drove cattle and men who dug. The army fed us, some days, and paid us, most weeks. The shed leaked. The man in the next place along was a carpenter from Virginia who'd come all the way up with Dunmore's people in '76 and lived through the smallpox camp, and had the marks of it all over his face, and he could build anything, and nobody would let him, because they only wanted him to dig. His name was Prince. I've thought about him a great deal, since.

And in July, Robinson sent for me in the middle of the night, and I went, the way he'd said, and he put me on a horse with a troop of Loyalist horse going up into the Neutral Ground after a rebel who'd been seen at a farmhouse near Eastchester. I took them round by the back of the farm, by the creek, and we came in quietly and the man was asleep in his bed and his boots by the fire, and he came back with us to the lines with his hands tied, swearing. He wasn't a spy. He was a rebel militia lieutenant who'd come home to see his wife. They exchanged him a month later for a Loyalist captain.

It was a small thing. The officer in charge thanked me, at the end, and gave me a shilling of his own, and said Robinson had told him I knew the country, and that Robinson was right. I don't think he thought of me again.

But Robinson did. And so, before very long, did somebody else.



He stopped and looked down at his hands. We were in the kitchen that day, because the porch had been in full sun since eleven, and he'd brought the tea in from the stove and forgotten it, and it had gone cold in the pot.

"Did he know?" I said. "Robinson. That you'd read his letter."

"I've wondered that for two hundred and forty-eight years." He reached for the pot, found it cold, and poured himself a cup anyway, and drank it. "I think

he knew there was something. He couldn't have said what. He was the kind of man who notices that his dog is cleverer than other people's dogs, and doesn't like to think too hard about why." He set the cup down. "He folded that letter very carefully, after I said no. And he never once left another one on the table when I was in the room. Not in two years."

"Did anyone ever find out?" I said. "That you could read."

He looked at me over the cup for a long moment.

"Once," he said.

Then he looked at the clock on the wall over the stove, which said a quarter to two, and got up to put the kettle on again, and didn't say who. I wrote it in my notebook, under the date, the way I always do: *Once*. And the recorders ran on in the warm kitchen with the window open and the hay smell coming in, and the kettle began, very quietly, to tick.

The Ferry

• RECORDING · JULY 1779

I should tell you what the city was like, because you won't find it in the pictures. The pictures are all of the harbor, with the ships in it, and the church spires, and little figures in good coats walking about on the Battery. That was there. It wasn't the city.

The city was half burned.

Three years before, in September of '76, a few days after the British marched in, a fire had started near the Whitehall slip in the middle of the night and run up the west side of the island with the wind behind it. It took Trinity Church and something like a quarter of the town. Then in '78 another fire took more. Nobody had rebuilt any of it. There was no money, and no lumber to spare, and no one sure enough of the future to build on it. So for two blocks either side of Broadway, all the way up past the ruins of Trinity, there were only cellars. Black holes in the ground where houses had been, with chimneys standing up out of them like gravestones.

And people lived in them. That was Canvas Town. They'd stretched old sails and tarpaulins over the cellars, and propped them up with spars from wrecked ships, and lived underneath, whole families, with their cooking fires smoking through holes in the canvas. Sailors' women. Refugees from the country with nowhere else to go. Deserters from both armies. And a good many people like me, who'd come in on a promise and found that the promise didn't include a roof. In the summer it stank. In the winter it froze. The

officers' wives held their handkerchiefs to their noses and took the long way round to church.

Everybody in that city had come there from somewhere else, running from something. Loyalist farmers whose farms the rebels had taken. Rich men who'd lost their money and poor men who'd lost their nerve. Soldiers of three nations, the British and the Hessians and the Loyalist regiments, and sailors of a dozen more. Thirty thousand people, maybe, in a town built for half that, on an island they were cutting down for firewood a tree at a time. Everybody watched everybody. Everybody was afraid of somebody. Nobody said what they meant, if they could help it.

That's what I meant, when I told you everybody was lying. It wasn't wickedness. It was the weather in that town. You breathed it.



The British had a letter.

That was the thing everybody in Robinson's rooms was talking about, that July, in low voices, the way men talk about a thing they're pleased with and not supposed to mention.

At the beginning of July, a British cavalry raid under a young colonel called Tarleton had hit a rebel cavalry camp up at Pound Ridge, in the north of the county, and caught it so badly by surprise that one of the officers there, a major, left his horse behind. In the saddlebags of the horse there was money, and there were papers, and among the papers there was a letter from General Washington himself.

Robinson had a copy of it. I saw it once, in the third week of July, for about the time it takes to put a candle on a table and take your hand away again. Robinson was reading it to another officer at the table, under the window, and he had asked me to bring the light. I brought the light. I put it down. And it was mine.

It was a short letter, and most of it was about money. Washington was telling his officer, a major called Tallmadge, how to pay for the intelligence he was getting from New York. There was a man who wrote to them from inside the city. The letter called him *C—r*, with a long dash in the middle, the

way people wrote a name they didn't want to write. And it said that this man might need a new way to send his letters, and it named somebody who might carry them: *a man on York Island, living on or near the North River*, called George Higday.

They took Higday within the week. He was a farmer, on the island, up toward the top, as the letter said. He swore he knew nothing, and I think he was mostly telling the truth. He had been asked. He hadn't yet said yes. They tried to turn him, too, and I don't think they found much in him worth turning.

But the other name they couldn't find. *C—r*. A man in the city who wrote to Washington, through Tallmadge, for guineas. That was all they had. It wasn't nothing. Before Pound Ridge, they hadn't even known he existed.

"Culper," the other officer said, that night, to Robinson. "Some of the men say Culper. It'd fit."

"It might fit a great many things," Robinson said. He folded the letter. "A name with six letters in it is no name at all."



I want to be honest with you about where my mind was, that summer.

It wasn't on Culper. Culper was Robinson's business, and Major André's, up at headquarters. I'd seen André twice by then, at a distance, coming down Robinson's steps: a slim young man in a beautiful coat, laughing at something, with a sketchbook under his arm. He was Sir Henry Clinton's favorite, everybody said, and he ran the secret correspondence for the whole army, the agents and the codes and the money. He didn't look at me, either time. Why would he? I was holding somebody's horse.

My mind was on staying alive, and on being useful enough to stay alive, and on the men in the shed.

That's the truth. I was a guide on the Quartermaster's books, paid by the day when I was used. Most days I wasn't. The rest of the time I worked where I could, for whoever paid: unloading at the docks, cutting wood, carrying for the Engineers. I ate what the army gave us and what Prince could talk out of the cooks at the Engineers' yard. I kept my head down and my eyes open. I

learned the city: every street, every slip, every sentry post and the hour it changed, every tavern where the officers drank and every one where the sailors did. I couldn't help learning it. Everything I looked at stayed.

And I learned the ferry.



The Brooklyn ferry ran from the city across the East River to the Long Island shore, all day, in all weathers, so long as the river wasn't full of ice. It was the only road between the city and the whole of Long Island. Everything that came into New York from the east came across it: cattle and hay and firewood, farmers with butter and eggs and cheese for the markets, officers going out to their regiments on the Island and coming back, letters, newspapers, women visiting their sisters, men visiting other men's sisters. Twenty crossings a day, maybe more.

I crossed it often. The army had cattle grazing on Long Island, and forage stacked there, and Robinson's people had business out there too, and somebody had to guide the parties to the right farms and back. So I knew the ferry well. The flat boats with their big sweeps, and the boatmen who swore at the tide. The stairs down to the water on the city side, slimy with weed at the bottom. The crowd at the top of the stairs waiting for the next boat, with their baskets and their bundles and their complaints. The carts selling things to the crowd: hot cakes, cider, oysters in season. A widow selling eggs and butter from a handcart, with her eggs set out on top in a shallow basket, in two neat rows of six on a fold of white cloth, so a buyer could see they were clean. I bought from her twice a week for a year and a half and could not then have described to you if you'd held a pistol to my head, which tells you how good she was.

I could describe her to you now. But I'll come to that.



On the fourteenth of August the *Royal Gazette* announced that a gentleman called Mr. John Hill had been appointed inspector at the Brooklyn ferry, and

that from now on every person crossing would be examined.

I had something to do with that. Not much. I want to be careful not to make it bigger than it was.

Some weeks before, in July, Robinson had asked me, as he sometimes did, what the country was saying. Not the rebels. The farmers. The people who came over the ferry with their butter. I told him what I'd heard, and then I told him something I hadn't heard, but seen. That there were more letters coming across that ferry than there ought to be. Farmers who couldn't write, as far as anybody knew, carrying sealed letters to cousins in the city they'd never mentioned before. A young man, three times in a month, who came over with nothing to sell and went back with nothing he'd bought. I'd noticed because I noticed everything. I couldn't help it.

"Washington's letter," I said, "talks about a way for this Culper to send what he writes. If he's in the city, and his letters go to Tallmadge, and Tallmadge is in Connecticut, they have to go out somehow. Not north. The country north is ours and the rebels' both, and it's full of thieves. Out by the east, across Long Island, is quieter."

Robinson looked at me for a long time.

"That's a long sentence for a guide," he said.

"Yes, sir."

He didn't say anything else. But by the middle of August there was Mr. Hill, with two soldiers and a table at the Brooklyn landing, where the boats came in from the city, opening every letter and turning out every basket and making grown men take off their boots.

I learned afterward, a long time afterward, from people who could read the other side's letters, what it did. One of their couriers was coming back from the city with a letter that very week. When he saw the table at the landing, he destroyed it before they could find it on him, and went home with nothing. Their man in Setauket wrote to Tallmadge, the next day: *Every letter is opened at the entrance of New York, and every man is searched.* And he wrote, *They have some knowledge of the route our letters take.*

We did. A little. Because of me.

It was the first round of the game, and I didn't even know that I'd won it. I didn't know there was a game. I only knew that I'd noticed something, and said it, and that within the month grown men were standing in their stockings on the Brooklyn landing, swearing at Mr. Hill.



I watched that table a good deal, the rest of that summer. Sometimes, when I'd crossed with a party, I stood near it on purpose while I waited for the boat back, and I watched Hill work.

He wasn't good at it. He was a clerk, not a hunter. He opened the letters and read them, and found nothing in them, because the letters said nothing, because anybody clever enough to be worth catching wasn't going to put anything in a letter that a clerk at a ferry table could read. He turned out baskets. He made men take off their boots. He never once looked at the women.

I saw a young man searched very hard there, one morning in September. Thin, pale, sweating, with a satchel. Hill had him empty it on the table, and turned every paper over twice, and held the letters up to the light, and found nothing, and let him go. The young man went off up the Brooklyn road without looking back, and I watched him all the way down, and I thought, *that is a man who has just been very lucky*. I never saw him again. I don't know his name. I've often thought I'd like to.

And I saw a farmer and his wife go through, one morning in late August, coming off the boat from the city. I'm only telling you because I remember everything, and I can't leave it out. He was about thirty, thin, anxious, in a brown coat, with the look of a man who's never been anywhere and doesn't like it. She was on his arm, a little older than him, in a gray cloak and a plain cap, scolding him the whole way up to the table about what he'd paid in the city for a pound of tea. Hill opened their basket, and found tea and a loaf of sugar and a bolt of calico, and the wife told him what she thought of men who put their hands in other people's sugar, at some length. Hill was glad to see them go. So was everybody in the line. I laughed, I think. Most people did.



In October, André was made Adjutant General of the whole army, at twenty-nine, over the heads of men twice his age. The officers in Robinson's rooms were furious and delighted in about equal parts. In November and December the talk was all about the South. Clinton was going to take an army down by sea and attack Charleston, in South Carolina, and finish the war in the southern colonies, where there were more Loyalists. Everybody knew it. It was meant to be a secret. In that city nothing was.

On the twenty-sixth of December, the day after Christmas, the fleet sailed. Ninety ships, the sailors said, and eight thousand men. Clinton went, and André went with him, with his sketchbook, and a good part of the army. The city was left to the old Hessian general Knyphausen, who'd commanded at the Brandywine and had very little English, and to his aide, a sharp young British captain called Beckwith, who took over André's secret business while André was away.

I was on the Battery the morning they sailed, with half the town, to watch them go. It was very cold. The wind came straight down the river from the north with nothing in the way of it, and there was ice already along the edges of the slips, thin and gray, and pieces of it turning in the current out in the stream, the size of cart wheels.

The old men on the Battery said they'd never seen ice in the harbor so early.

They were right. They'd never seen anything like what came next. Nobody alive had.



He stopped. It was very hot in the kitchen, the hottest day yet, and he had the door open to the porch and a fan going on the counter that pushed the warm air round without doing anything about it. I had my sleeves pushed up past my elbows. There was a glass of iced tea by my notebook, sweating a ring onto the page.

“Next week,” he said, “you’ll want the coat.”

I looked up. “You said I wouldn’t need the coat for this one.”

“I said it was summer.” He smiled. “It was. When I got there.”

I wrote that down. I’m not sure why. Then I turned back a page and looked at what I’d written while he was talking about the ferry, and I saw that somewhere in the middle of it I’d drawn, without meaning to, a little cart, with two wheels and a handle, in the margin, next to the words *eggs and butter*.

I didn’t remember drawing it. I left it there.

The Hard Winter

I brought the coat.

It was eighty-eight degrees the next Thursday, the last one in May, and I drove up with the air conditioning on full and the green wool coat folded on the back seat like a passenger. When I came up the porch steps I had it over my arm. He was on the bench in the shade with a glass of water, and he looked at the coat, and then at me, and then he laughed, properly, the laugh that made him hold the rail.

“I was told to,” I said.

“You were.” He wiped his eyes. “Put it on the chair. It can listen.”

I put it over the back of the other chair, and set the recorders on the little table, and said the date into them, *session thirty-one, Thursday, May twenty-seventh*, and he looked at the coat for a while, hanging there in the heat, as if it really were going to listen.

“Good,” he said. “Now. Cold.”



• RECORDING • JANUARY 1780

You won't believe me about the cold. Nobody does, now. You've never had a winter like it, and nobody alive has. It was the worst winter anyone on this coast had ever written down.

It began before Christmas, with the ice in the slips. By the third week of December the floes in the North River were so thick the boats from the Jersey shore couldn't get through them, and the farmers who brought wood

and food across stopped coming. Then, in the first days of January, the snow came. It snowed for three days. In the hills of Jersey, where Washington's army was in its huts, it lay four and five and six feet deep, and drifted over the huts so the men had to dig their way out in the morning. In the city it was less, but it didn't matter. It didn't melt. It didn't melt for two months.

And then the rivers froze.

Not the edges. All of it. The North River, which is a mile wide at the city and has the whole tide of the ocean pushing in and out of it twice a day, froze from shore to shore, solid. The bay froze. The water between the city and Staten Island, which is five miles of open harbor, froze hard enough to walk on, and then hard enough to ride on, and then hard enough to drive a sleigh full of firewood across, and then, about the middle of January, hard enough to drag the army's heaviest cannon across it, which nobody in the history of the place had ever seen or imagined.

New York was an island. That's all it had been for three years, a fortress on an island, safe behind its water, with the King's navy all round it. In the second week of January it stopped being an island. You could walk to it from New Jersey. You could walk to it from anywhere.



The city ran out of wood.

That's the thing I remember most, of that winter, and I remember all of it. Not the snow. Not the ice, though the ice was a wonder. The wood. A town of thirty thousand people needs a great deal of firewood to get through a winter, and in an ordinary year it came in by water, from Long Island and Jersey and up the river, every day, boatload after boatload. That year nothing came. The water was stone.

They burned everything. The army cut down every tree left standing on the island, the old orchards and the shade trees on the Bowery lanes, the trees in the gentlemen's gardens with the gentlemen watching from their windows. They pulled down empty houses and burned them. They bought up old ships and broken hulks lying in the slips and broke them up for firewood, and the bits of old ships burned blue and green in the grates from the copper

and the salt. The soldiers' fuel was cut, and cut again. Gentlemen burned their furniture. I saw a man on Queen Street burning a harpsichord.

The officers at headquarters said the city needed six hundred cords of wood a week. I know because I heard Beckwith say it, more than once, in the way a man repeats a number that's frightening him. Some weeks there were seventy cords in all the army's yards.

And in Canvas Town, under the sails, over the burnt cellars, people froze to death.



I'm going to tell you about one of them, because I have to tell somebody. I'll be short.

There was a family in a cellar on the west side of Broadway, near where Trinity had been. A man and his wife and three children, sailors' people, from somewhere in the West Country of England. I passed them most days, that winter, on my way down to the river. The man had been pressed off a merchant ship and then dismissed from the navy sick, and he had no work and no way home. They'd made a sort of room down in their cellar, with a canvas roof and an old door for a wall, and a little fire in the corner of what had been somebody's kitchen hearth. The youngest child was about four. A girl, with very fair hair and a red woolen scarf that went round her neck three times. She used to sit at the top of the cellar steps in the mornings when it was sunny, with the scarf up to her eyes, and watch the people go by.

On the eleventh of January there was no smoke coming out of the hole in their canvas. I noticed it on my way down to the river. On my way back, at dusk, there was still none, and two men from the Barrack Master's office were carrying them up the cellar steps, one at a time, wrapped in their own blankets.

The red scarf was round the smallest one. They'd left it on her.

That's all. It happened in a hundred cellars that month. The Chief Justice of the province wrote in his diary, that winter, that they often heard of the deaths of the poor, frozen in their houses. He was a decent man, and I believe it upset him, and he was writing in a warm room.

I've told you about Caesar's eyes, how anything they fell on stayed. I've told you it was a gift. This is the other side of it. I have that cellar, Ms. Barnett. I have the steps, and the old door, and the color of the scarf, and the way the second man held the child, under the knees and the shoulders, as if she might still mind being carried badly. I've had it for two hundred and forty-seven years. I lost Caesar's eyes when I lost him, in the end, and everything I saw after that I've remembered the way anyone remembers, which is to say badly, with the edges worn off. But the things I saw with his eyes I still have the way he saw them. As if I were holding the page.

I wouldn't give them back. I want you to understand that. Even the cellar. Somebody ought to keep it.



He stopped. Across the field, at the far edge, the line of trees had gone blue in the heat haze, and a tractor was turning the hay in long slow rows, very small and far away, and the sound of it came to us a little after we saw it move.

I didn't say anything. There wasn't anything to say that wouldn't have been for my sake rather than his. He drank some of his water. The green coat hung over the chair beside me, in the heat, absurd and patient.

"All right," he said, after a while. "That's that one."



• RECORDING · JANUARY 1780

Beckwith sent for me in the second week of January.

I'd never spoken to him. I knew him by sight, as I knew everybody: a young man, younger than André, quick and thin and pale, with a sharp nose and sharp eyes, the kind of officer who reads every paper put in front of him twice and trusts none of them. With André and the General gone south, the whole secret business of the army in New York had landed on his desk. The agents. The letters. The deserters coming in over the ice, more every day, with stories, some true. And the rebels, sitting out there in the Jersey hills four and five miles off, looking at a city that wasn't an island anymore.

He saw me in a cold little office at the back of the Commandant's house, with his greatcoat on and a candle on the table and his breath showing. He had a paper in front of him, Robinson's paper about me. He didn't ask me to sit down either. But he looked up at me when I came in, straight up, the way Robinson had looked at me the second time, and not the first.

"Colonel Robinson says you see things," he said.

"I try to, sir."

"He says you notice what people carry, and where they go, and who they talk to, and that you never forget a face." He tapped the paper. "He says that's why the rebels' letters stopped coming over the Brooklyn ferry in the summer. Because you noticed them."

"They didn't stop, sir. They went another way."

He looked at me a moment longer. Then he smiled, which surprised me. It was a thin, quick smile, and it went as fast as it came.

"Yes," he said. "That's exactly what I'd have said. Good." He leaned back. "Here is my difficulty. You may have noticed that the harbor has frozen."

"Yes, sir."

"We've been sitting behind our water for three years. Now we have no water. Washington has an army in the hills at Morristown, thirty miles off, starving and freezing and very angry, and every day the ice gets thicker, and every night I lie awake thinking about what an angry general does when somebody builds him a road." He put both hands flat on the table. "I have deserters coming in who tell me he's coming. I have agents who tell me he isn't. I have Loyalists on Staten Island who see rebels behind every snowdrift. What I don't have is anybody who can stand on that ice in the dark and tell me what's really out there."

"The ice talks, sir," I said.

He raised his eyebrows.

"At night," I said. "When it's very cold and there's no wind. A sound will carry across it for miles. You can hear a dog bark on the Jersey shore from the middle of the bay, as if it were on the next street. You can hear men talking at Elizabethtown Point from the Staten Island side, if they're careless. You can hear sleighs." I paused. "Caesar learned it on the ponds up in Westchester, as

a boy. Sent out to cut ice. Any man who's worked on ice knows it. The officers don't, because they've never had to."

He was very still.

"Sleighs," he said.

"If anybody's coming across from Jersey to you, sir, they'll come by sleigh. There's nothing else that'll carry men and guns over that much ice at night. And you can hear a sleigh on the ice, on a still night, a long way off. The runners sing. And the horses' bells, if they're fools enough to leave them on."

Beckwith picked up his pen and wrote something on Robinson's paper, very small, in the margin. I read it, of course, upside down. *Staten Island. Nights.*

"You'll go over tomorrow," he said. "There's a sleigh going across with the wood party at first light. Report to General Stirling's people at the watering place. Not the American Stirling," he added, dryly. "Ours. We have one each."



I want to tell you one more thing about that week, and then we'll go out on the ice.

The ferry to Brooklyn wasn't running. The East River was jammed with ice, great broken slabs of it heaved up against each other the full width of the water, grinding and groaning with every tide, too rough to walk across and too thick for any boat. But people still came down to the ferry stairs every morning out of habit, the way you go and look at a shop you know is shut. And the carts still came. There was nowhere better to sell to a crowd of people with nothing to do.

I went down there the morning before I went across to Staten Island, to look at the ice on the East River before I trusted myself to the bay. It was very early, and so cold that the air hurt the inside of your nose. The sun was just up, red, over the Brooklyn shore. The ice in the river was pink with it.

The widow was at the top of the stairs with her cart. She had a little iron pot of coals on a tray underneath it, to keep the butter from freezing hard, and she'd wrapped her hands in strips of old blanket so that only the tips of

her fingers showed. She was looking at the ice too. And she was humming, very quietly, to herself, under her breath, the way people do on a cold morning to keep themselves company.

I couldn't hear what. The ice was too loud. Every time the tide moved, the whole river creaked and cracked and boomed, like a great house settling. I caught a turn of something, under it. Up, and a little turn, and down. And then a slab of ice somewhere out in the stream gave way with a noise like a cannon, and everybody on the stairs jumped, and when I looked back, she had stopped, and was rubbing her hands over the little pot of coals, and the tune was gone.

I bought two eggs from her. I remember them still, the weight of them, warm from the coals, in my hand. I put them inside my shirt for later. She didn't look at me any more than I looked at her.

I've wondered since what she was humming. I've wondered it for two hundred and forty-seven years.



He stopped there and looked over at the coat on the chair, and so did I.

"Why does that matter?" I said. "What she was humming."

He didn't answer for a moment. On the far side of the field the tractor had reached the end of its row and was turning, slowly, to come back.

"Because I remember everything else about that morning," he said. "Every face on those stairs. The color of the ice. The number of eggs in her basket, which was eleven, before I bought two." He turned his glass of water slowly on the little table, a quarter turn, and another. "And the one thing I didn't catch is the one thing I'd give the rest of it for. That's how it goes, I find. You notice everything, and then the river makes a noise." He looked at me. "Write down that it was eleven. You'll want it later."

I wrote it down. *Eleven eggs*. I didn't ask why. I'd learned by then that he'd tell me, and that he'd tell me when it would do the most good, and that asking only made him wait longer.

Then he picked up his glass and stood, with his hand on the rail, and said we'd go out onto the ice after lunch, and went in to see about the lunch. And I

sat on the porch in the heat with the green coat beside me, and found, when I looked down, that I had my hand on its sleeve.

Five Deserters

• RECORDING · JANUARY 1780

You've never walked on the sea. I had, by then, once or twice, in other lives, on the Baltic in a bad year. It doesn't get easier. Every part of you knows that there's forty feet of black water under your boots, moving, and that the only thing between you and it is something that was water itself last week. The body doesn't believe the ice. It never does. It walks on it the way you'd walk on the back of a sleeping animal.

The wood sleigh took me across from the city at first light, behind two horses with sacking tied over their hooves for grip. Five miles of white, flat as a table, with the sun coming up red on the left and the Jersey hills on the right, and the little black shape of Staten Island ahead of us getting bigger very slowly. The driver was a Loyalist from Long Island who talked the whole way about his cousin, who'd fallen through near Bedloe's Island the week before and been pulled out by his hair. Every so often the ice under us made a noise. Not a crack. A long, low, singing note, like somebody running a wet finger round the rim of a glass the size of the harbor, that started somewhere far off and ran toward us and under us and away. The horses flattened their ears every time. So did I.

"Tide," the driver said, the first time. "Just the tide, lifting it." He said it every time after that too. I think he said it for himself.



The British held Staten Island under a brigadier called Thomas Stirling, a Scotsman, a good plain soldier who'd been in America since the beginning and didn't trust anything he hadn't seen. Most of his men were Loyalists: New Jersey Volunteers, Skinner's men, who'd been run off their own farms across the water by the rebels and who could look across the ice, on a clear day, at the steeples of the towns they came from. They hated the rebels the way only neighbors can. They had built a line of small forts, redoubts, along the heights above the watering place on the north shore, with log walls and earth and ditches full of snow.

I spent four nights on that ice.

I'd go out after dark, alone, a few hundred yards from the shore, where the snow on the ice had been blown thin, and lie down flat on a horse blanket with another one over me, and listen. If you've never done it, you can't imagine how loud the world is on a still night on the ice. The cold makes the air heavy and holds the sound down low, the way a lid holds steam, and it carries along the flat for miles. I could hear dogs on the Jersey shore. I could hear a door bang at Elizabethtown Point, two miles off, and a man swear at it. I could hear the ice itself, every few minutes, singing its long note across the bay. And under all of it, I could hear the rebels.

Not much, the first two nights. Sentries calling. A cart. Somebody chopping wood. The ordinary noise of a cold, hungry army's outposts trying to stay alive till morning.

On the third night, the thirteenth, it changed.

There were sleighs. Many sleighs, on the roads behind the Point, coming down out of the hills from the direction of Morristown, one after another, and stopping, and more coming behind. The runners sang on the packed snow of the roads the way they sing on ice, a high hissing whine, and the horses blew, and men talked to the horses, low. Some of the sleighs still had their bells on. Somebody in charge of them didn't know about ice, or didn't think it mattered. I lay there on my blanket with my cheek on the cold and counted. I counted until two in the morning. I stopped counting at three hundred, because after that it was one long noise and I couldn't separate the sleighs in it anymore.

Three hundred sleighs. More. Gathering behind Elizabethtown Point, in the night, in the coldest winter in living memory, where there was nothing on earth for a sleigh to do except cross the ice to Staten Island.



I went back to the redoubts before dawn and asked for the officer of the guard, and he was a captain of the Jersey Volunteers, a big red-faced man called Rudd with frost in his eyebrows, and he didn't believe a word I said.

I don't blame him, now. Look at it from where he stood. It was four in the morning. He'd been on his feet all night in a log hut that was colder inside than out. And here was a Black man he'd never seen, in a horse blanket, with frost on his face, telling him that he'd lain on the ice and listened and counted three hundred sleighs in the dark, on the other side of two miles of frozen sea. He laughed at me. Then he got angry, because I didn't go away. Then he told me that if I'd been listening to the rebels all night, it was a wonder I hadn't gone over and joined them, and that if I didn't take myself off, he'd have me in the guardhouse for a spy.

I showed him Robinson's paper, with Beckwith's note on it. He held it to the fire to read it. Then he handed it back and said that Captain Beckwith was in New York, and he was here, and he'd send my report up in the morning with the others. And I knew he would. I knew exactly where it would go: into a pile on a table, under a stone, with all the other reports from all the other people who'd seen rebels behind snowdrifts that week. Rudd wasn't a fool. He'd just been told the rebels were coming every night for a fortnight, by every frightened Loyalist on the island, and none of them had come.

I went out of the redoubt and stood in the snow, and thought.

A report from me wasn't going to move anybody. I was nobody. A pair of ears on a horse blanket. What would move them was something they could see.



So I went back out on the ice, in the gray before sunrise, and I walked toward Jersey.

Not all the way. A mile, or a little more, until I could see the smoke of the outposts on the far shore against the brightening sky. And then I lay down again on my blanket and waited, because I was fairly sure, by then, of what I was waiting for.

You have to think about that army. Washington's men at Morristown. I knew a good deal about them, because deserters had been coming in all winter, and I'd seen them at the lines. They were starving. That isn't a figure of speech. That January the army at Morristown went days at a time without bread or meat, and the snow had cut the roads, and the men were eating bark and boiling their shoes. They had no coats, a lot of them. They'd built their huts in the snow and they were dying in them. And somebody had just ordered three thousand of them to get into sleighs and ride across two miles of ice in the dark, in the coldest night of the coldest winter there had ever been, to attack a line of forts.

Some of them were going to decide they'd rather not.

And a man who deserted that night wouldn't run back up into the hills, into the snow, toward the officers who'd hang him. He'd go the only way left. Across the ice, to us. Tonight, while there was still time to be worth something when he got there. And he'd come out on the ice exactly where I was lying, because it was the shortest way across, and because the ice was thickest there, and because a man running for his life over the sea goes the way the ice tells him to.

They came about an hour after sunrise. Five of them.

I saw them first as black specks against the white, a long way off, moving in a bunch, stopping, moving again. They stopped a great deal. As they came closer I saw why. Three of them had no shoes. They'd wrapped their feet in rags and old blanket tied on with string, and the rags had frozen, and they walked like old men. One had a coat, a real one, blue, with the facings torn off. The others had blankets round their shoulders like women's shawls. They were young. They were all young. The oldest might have been twenty-five.

When they were close enough I stood up, slowly, with my hands open, as I'd stood up in front of the Hessian at Kingsbridge. They stopped dead. One of them made a sound, not a word. For a moment I thought they'd run, back the way they'd come. But there was nowhere to run. They'd used up their running.

"You're coming in?" I said.

The one in the blue coat nodded. His lips were cracked through. He couldn't make them say anything.

"Then you'll want to tell somebody what's coming behind you," I said. "Tonight. Before it comes. That's what'll make them glad to see you." I looked at each of them. "Is it tonight?"

The one in the coat looked at the others. Then he found his voice. It came out cracked and very young.

"Tonight," he said. "All of us. Lord Stirling's taking the whole lot over. Three thousand men. Five hundred sleighs. They told us at evening parade. Tonight, and take the forts in the dark before they know." He swallowed. "We're not going. We're not dying on the ice for a fort."

I believed him. I'd have believed him without the words. I looked at his feet in their frozen rags, and his hands, cracked across the knuckles from cutting logs for huts, and the bones of his face. A man sent over to deceive us would have been fed first, and given shoes. You don't send a liar across the sea barefoot. You need him to get there.

"Come with me," I said. "Walk where I walk. Don't stop. I'll take you to a fire."



I didn't take them to Rudd.

I took them straight past the redoubt where he was, along the shore, half a mile, to the house above the watering place where the brigadier had his quarters, and I walked them up to the sentry at the door, five starving rebels in frozen rags and me in my horse blanket, and I said, very loudly, so that it would carry into the house through the window that had a light in it, that these five men had deserted from Lord Stirling's army that morning, and that

they'd come to tell General Stirling that three thousand men in five hundred sleighs were coming across the ice to attack him that night.

The window opened. A man put his head out. Gray hair, nightcap, no wig, his breath smoking in the cold. Thomas Stirling, brigadier general, in his shirt.

He looked down at the five of them, standing in the snow with their rag feet. He looked at them for a long time. He didn't look at me at all. Then he said, "Bring them in to the fire. Give them something hot. Send for my brigade major," and shut the window.

And by noon every man on Staten Island was inside the redoubts, with the gates shut and the guns loaded and the ditches swept, and sentries doubled all along the heights, and a boat had gone off as far as the ice would let it toward the city to beg for help. Rudd among them. He passed me in the afternoon, carrying cartridges, and looked at me, and I looked at him, and neither of us said a word about it. I've always rather liked him for that.



They came after dark. Exactly as the boy in the blue coat had said.

I watched from the wall of the biggest redoubt. You could see them coming for the last mile, black on the white under the stars, the sleighs in long dark lines, like ink running across paper. And you could hear them. You could hear them the whole way. The runners singing, and the bells, and the horses, and the men. Three thousand men, coming at what they thought was a sleeping fort in the dark, and you could hear them from the far shore, every one.

They landed and found every gate shut and every gun manned. Lord Stirling looked at the forts from the snow below, and saw what he'd have had to do to take them, and wouldn't. He was a brave man, but he wasn't a murderer. So his three thousand men spent the night in the open, on the hills above the watering place, in the snow, without tents, without fires, most of them, in the coldest night of that whole winter. We watched them from the walls. Nobody fired. There wasn't any point.

They stayed all the next day, looking at us, and another night after it. By then five hundred of them had frostbite. Some of them never walked right again. And on the morning after that they loaded the sleighs with whatever they, and the Jersey farmers who'd followed them over, could steal from the Loyalist farms on the island, which was a good deal, and went back across the ice to Jersey. And the boats that New York sent out to help us all came back, because they couldn't get through.

Almost nobody died. That's the thing I want you to write down, Ms. Barnett. Three thousand men came across the ice to fight, and the fight never happened, and almost nobody on either side died of it. Not a single one of the five boys who came across barefoot that morning. Not a single one of Rudd's men. Not, as far as I ever heard, a single one of Lord Stirling's, though some of them lost their toes.

It's the cleanest win I ever had. In that life or any other.



He stopped and sat back against the porch wall, and closed his eyes for a moment, in the heat, with his face turned up.

It was late in the afternoon. The tractor had gone from the field and the hay lay in long, combed rows all the way to the trees, and the shadows of the rows were getting long. The green coat was still on the chair beside me. At some point while he was talking about the ice, I'd taken it off the chair and put it across my knees. I didn't remember doing that either.

"What happened to them?" I said. "The five."

He opened his eyes.

"They were fed, and given shoes, and questioned for a week," he said. "Then two of them enlisted with Skinner's men and fought for the King for the rest of the war. One went to sea. The boy in the blue coat went to work for a baker in Hanover Square and married the baker's daughter." He smiled. "And one walked back across the ice in February, when it was still hard enough, and re-joined his regiment in Jersey, and told them he'd been lost in a snowstorm for a month. And they believed him. Or they were so short of men by then that they decided to."

“You know all that?”

“I kept track,” he said. “I kept track of all five.” He picked up his water glass, found it empty, and set it down again. “I’ve done a great many things in a great many lives that I’m not proud of, Ms. Barnett. You’ll hear about some of them, if you keep driving up here. But I’ve never once regretted those five boys on the ice.” He looked out at the hay. “I’d like you to have one like that. Before the rest of it.”

I wrote it down. *Session 31. The five. Nobody died.* I underlined *nobody*, which I don’t usually do either.

Then I folded the coat over my arm and put the recorders in my bag, and he walked me as far as the top of the steps, slowly, with his hand on the rail, and stood there in the long light while I went down. When I got to the car, I looked back. He was still standing there, looking out over the field toward the east, toward the sea, a hundred and fifty miles away, and I knew without asking that he was hearing the ice.

The Person Who Wasn't Laughing

I spent that week on Gerald Whitcombe, and I did it the way I used to, in the newsroom, when I still had a desk and a phone with my name on it. Records first. People later. People last of all, if you can manage it, because a person can only be asked a question once for the first time.

It's surprising how much of a life is public, if you know which counter to stand at.

The stone house outside Middleburg was in his name, and had been for thirty-one years. Forty-two acres, not forty, the county said, with a barn and a run-in shed and a pond, assessed at a figure that made me put my pen down for a moment. He'd bought it the year he became head of conservation at Carrow House. He owned no other property in Virginia or the District or Maryland. He'd never been sued, never been arrested, never been in a newspaper for anything but his talks and his retirement and a letter to the editor of the Middleburg paper, nine years ago, about a proposal to widen a road. He was against it. The road had not been widened.

He'd been married for forty-four years to a woman called Margaret, who taught piano and died eleven years ago, of a stroke, in the spring. Her obituary was still up on the funeral home's website, with a photograph of a gray-haired woman at a piano laughing at somebody off to one side. It said that she was survived by her husband, Gerald, *her partner in all things*, and by their daughter, Claire, of Loudoun County, and two grandsons. It said that in lieu of flowers the family asked for donations to a horse rescue in Purcellville.

I read it twice. I made a note of the daughter, because I make a note of everybody. Then I moved on to the board of the historical society and the library foundation, and his talk, every spring, on the enemies of paper. Light. Damp. Acid. The human hand.

By Wednesday night I had six pages on Gerald Whitcombe and I still had exactly what I'd had on Monday, which was an old woman's memory of a laugh.



He made eggs, that Thursday.

It was cooler, the first cool morning in two weeks, with rain in the night and the yard still dripping, and he'd lit the stove more for comfort than for need. He made the eggs the way he'd made them in the spring, when the bakery in town was shut and we'd had nothing else: scrambled very slowly in a pan with a lot of butter, stirred with the back of a fork, and toast from the bakery bread, and the tea in the brown pot. I said the date into the recorders. *Session thirty-two, Thursday, June third.* Then he put a plate in front of me and sat down across the kitchen table with his own, and looked at me, and waited.

He always knew when I had something. I've never worked out how. I've watched my own face in the car mirror afterward and it doesn't look like anything.

"I've got a laugh," I said. "And nothing else."

"Tell me."

So I told him. The six pages. The house, the acres, the road he didn't want widened. The talk every spring. The way the audience laughed at his jokes. And Mrs. Dunleavy, in her son's front room in Frederick, with her eyes closed and her hands on the composition book, saying *That's him* before the laugh was even finished.

"I believe her," I said. "I think she's right. But I can't print a laugh. I can't take a laugh to a lawyer. I can't even take it to Whitcombe, because if I drive out to Middleburg and knock on his door and say, *Mr. Whitcombe, a woman heard you laugh on a staircase six years ago*, he's going to laugh at me, the same laugh, and close the door, and call Carrow House's lawyers, who I already know, all of

them, by their first names. And then the one thing I've got that he doesn't know I've got, I won't have anymore."

He ate some of his eggs. He took his time over it.

"You're right not to go," he said.

"I know I'm right. That's not the problem."

"No." He put his fork down. "Tell me about the laugh."

"I just did."

"No. You told me about Mrs. Dunleavy. Tell me about the laugh. The one in the video."

I thought about it. I'd watched that video eleven times. I'd watched the laugh at thirty-one minutes more often than that.

"It's big," I said. "Too big for the room. He puts his head back. It's the kind of laugh that tells everybody else in the room that they can laugh now too. And they do." I hesitated. "It's a laugh that's used to people laughing with it."

"Yes," he said. "A man who laughs like that is used to being believed." He picked up his tea. "Don't give him the chance to be."

"Meaning what?"

"Meaning you're right. Leave him alone. He's the strongest thing in your whole story. He's been standing at lecterns for forty years with people laughing in the right places. He'll be very good at your questions, because he's very good at everybody's questions. You'll come home with nothing but the sound of him being charming, and so will anybody you send." He set the cup down. "So don't go to the man who was laughing, Ms. Barnett. Find the one who wasn't."



I didn't understand him for a moment. Then I did, and I felt it go down my arms, the way it used to in the newsroom.

"The car," I said.

"The car."

"Somebody waited in the car."

"Somebody sat in an alley behind a dry cleaner's for twenty-seven minutes," he said, "with the engine running, on a Wednesday morning, while two men went up and down the stairs of a building with a woman on the second floor

who wrote down every footstep. They didn't get out. They didn't help carry anything. They sat there." He turned his cup a quarter turn on the table. "Think about those twenty-seven minutes from inside the car. It's the longest half hour of that person's life. They can hear nothing. They can see the back door and the alley mouth and nothing else. Every car that goes past the end of the alley is the police. Every minute the door doesn't open is a minute something's gone wrong upstairs." He looked at me. "The man upstairs was laughing. The person in the car wasn't. I'd bet you your coat on it."

"You'd lose the coat. I'd keep you on the bet just to win it."

"That's a yes," he said, and went back to his eggs.

I sat there with my fork in my hand.

"Whoever it was," I said slowly, "is the weak place. Not him. He's done this sort of thing all his life, probably, a version of it. Talking. Making people comfortable. Whoever was in that car isn't like that, or they'd have been upstairs carrying boxes. They were the one he trusted not to talk, and not to ask, and to sit still." I thought about it. "And they've been carrying those twenty-seven minutes ever since."

"Six years," he said. "Every time they hear an engine idle." He spread butter on a piece of toast, right to the edges, the way he did everything. "And when you find them, don't ask them what they did. They've told themselves what they did a thousand times, at night, and they've got it smooth. Ask them how long they waited."

"Why?"

"Because nobody's ever asked them that. And they know the answer to the minute."



I wrote it all down. Then I sat and looked at the page.

"I don't know who it was," I said. "That's the trouble. I've got six pages and there's nobody in them. A dead wife. A historical society. The man's never even had a parking ticket."

"Who drives a man into the city?" he said.

I looked at him.

"I'm not going to do it for you," he said, mildly. "I've had my turn this year. Just ask yourself the question properly. Not who would help him. Lots of people would help him. Who'd drive him? Who'd sit in a car for him, in an alley, and not ask?" He finished the toast. "How old was he? Six years ago?"

"Seventy-three."

"And he lives an hour and a half out, in the country, on forty acres. Does a man of seventy-three who lives on forty acres in the hunt country drive himself into the middle of Washington on a weekday morning?"

I didn't answer. He didn't need me to.

"Eat your eggs," he said. "They're getting cold, and I don't make them for everybody."



He took me back out onto the ice after that, in the afternoon. I'll come to it. But that night, at home, I did something I hadn't done all week.

I didn't look at Gerald Whitcombe.

I sat at the kitchen table with my six pages and a highlighter, and I went through them again, and I highlighted every other person in them. Every single one. The road-widening people. The president of the historical society. His late wife, Margaret, who taught piano. The funeral home. The horse rescue in Purcellville. The daughter, Claire, of Loudoun County. Two grandsons, no names. A neighbor who'd sold him six acres of pasture in the nineties. A man from the library foundation who'd introduced him at the talk.

Fourteen names. I wrote them in a column on a fresh page. Then I sat and looked at them, and I couldn't make any of them get into a car.

Freda came in at ten from her father's, where she went on Thursdays now, by agreement, from four until nine, and he drove her home and waited at the curb until she was inside and the porch light had gone off and on again, which had been his own idea, and which I'd been more touched by than I'd let him see. She dropped her bag by the door and came and stood behind my chair, as she always does, and read my column over my shoulder, as she always does.

"Who are they?"

"People who know Gerald Whitcombe."

“The laugh guy.” She leaned on the back of my chair. “Why?”

“Because one of them might have been in the car.”

I told her what Tom had said. Not all of it. The person who wasn’t laughing. The twenty-seven minutes. Who drives a man of seventy-three into the city. She listened with her chin on the top of my head, which she hasn’t been tall enough to do for very long, and which she does now whenever she can, because she knows I can’t stop her.

“That’s a really good question,” she said, when I’d finished.

“I know. I can’t answer it.”

“Can I see the video again?”

“You’ve seen it.”

“I saw the laugh,” Freda said. “We were all watching for the laugh. Mrs. Dunleavy had her eyes shut.” She came round the table and pulled her laptop out of her bag. “I want to watch the whole thing. All forty minutes. The beginning and the questions and the end.” She opened it. “Everybody always leaves off the end. That’s where the people are.”

I looked at her.

“What people?”

“I don’t know yet,” Freda said. “That’s why I want to watch it.” She put her big white headphones on, and found the video, and dragged the little slider all the way back to the beginning, and hit play.

I watched her watch it for a while. Then I went and put the kettle on, and when I came back with the tea she had her elbows on the table and her chin in her hands, and on the screen a white-haired man in a bow tie was standing at a lectern in front of a slide of a water-stained letter, and she wasn’t watching him at all. She was watching the edges.

Over the Ice

• RECORDING · JANUARY 1780

I said I'd give you one clean one first, and I have. The next two aren't clean. I'm going to tell them anyway, and I'm going to tell you exactly what my part in them was, no more and no less, and you can decide what you think. That's the bargain.

After the night of the five deserters, Beckwith sent for me again. He'd had General Stirling's report by then. He didn't say anything about it. He didn't need to. He looked at me across his cold little table for a while, the way he'd looked at me the first time, and then he unrolled a map.

"They came to us across the ice," he said. "Now we go to them."



You have to understand the mood in the city that week. It wasn't relief. It was rage.

The Loyalists on Staten Island had watched three thousand rebels, their own neighbors from across the water, sit on the hills above their farms for two days, and then strip those farms on the way home: the cattle, the grain, the blankets off the beds. Jersey farmers had followed the soldiers across the ice with empty sleighs, on purpose, to fill them. Men had come back to their houses on the island and found the doors off and the furniture gone. And every one of those Loyalists knew some of the faces that had done it.

The army wanted to answer. The Loyalist regiments wanted to answer more. And for once there was a road to answer on. Elizabethtown was just

across the water from the island, on the Jersey shore, where Lord Stirling's sleighs had gathered. There was a rebel guard in the town, and stores, and officers in billets. And for a few more weeks, maybe days, there was a road of ice straight to it.

The question was how to get there without being heard. Lord Stirling had come across the ice like a brass band. Everybody in the city knew it by then, from the deserters and from me.

"You heard them," Beckwith said. "Could they hear us?"

"If you go the way they came, sir, yes. Straight across from the watering place to the Point. It's the shortest way and the thickest ice and they'll be listening for it every night now."

"Then how?"

I showed him. South, along the island's own shore, close in, where the snow lay thick on the ice and swallowed the sound. Then across the narrow water at the south end of the bay, not to the Point but below it, to a place called Trembly's Point, where the marsh came down to the shore and nobody kept a guard because nobody could imagine an army landing in a salt marsh. No sleighs. Men on foot, and the cavalry walking their horses, with sacking on the hooves. No bells. No torches. No talking. Then up through the marsh to the town in the last hour before light, and take the guard in their beds, and the officers with them, and come away by the same road before the country woke.

It was a good plan. I want to say that plainly. It was the best plan anybody made that winter, on either side. It went right to the end. It was what happened at the end that wasn't mine.



They went on the night of the twenty-fifth. About four hundred men, mostly Jersey Volunteers, under their lieutenant colonel, Abraham Van Buskirk, a Dutch doctor from Bergen County who'd raised a battalion of his own neighbors for the King, and a troop of the Seventeenth Light Dragoons. I went with them as the guide.

We went down the island's shore in the dark, close in, on the soft snow. It worked. It was like walking on wool. Four hundred men, and the loudest thing on the bay was the ice singing its long note under us now and then, and the breath of the horses. We crossed at the narrows below Trembly's Point and came up through the frozen marsh with the reeds crackling round our knees, and nobody heard us. At four in the morning we were in the streets of Elizabethtown, and the guard was in its beds, and the officers were in theirs.

They took about fifty prisoners. Some officers, some militiamen, and a few men who were only in the wrong house. Almost nobody fired a shot. The rebel guard came out of the houses with their hands up and their breeches in their hands. It was over in twenty minutes. It was everything Beckwith had wanted.

And then somebody set fire to the church.



I'll tell you what I saw. I've thought about it for two hundred and forty-seven years and I can't make it more than what it was.

There was a Presbyterian meeting house in the middle of the town. A big wooden building with a tall steeple, the finest building in Elizabethtown. The rebels had used it as a barracks, and before that, the Loyalists said, its minister had preached rebellion from the pulpit every Sunday since '75 and rung its bell to call out the militia. The Loyalists hated it more than any building in Jersey. Some of them had sat in its pews as boys.

When the prisoners were being collected in the street, a party of men came down the street with torches. They weren't Van Buskirk's regulars, the Volunteers. They were Loyalist militia from the island who'd come along on their own account, the way the Jersey farmers had followed Lord Stirling, men whose farms had been stripped the week before. And they went into the meeting house, and a few minutes later there was light in the windows, and then there was light coming out of the windows, and then the steeple was burning like a candle against the dark.

Van Buskirk came running. I heard him. He was shouting at them to put it out, in Dutch and English both, that he hadn't ordered it, that they were to

put it out at once. Nobody did. Nobody could have, by then, with buckets and snow. And while he was shouting at them, somebody else set fire to the courthouse across the green.

I stood in the street and watched them burn. There was nothing I could do. I was a Black man with a guide's paper in a town full of armed white men with their blood up. If I'd so much as touched one of those torches they'd have thrown me in after it.

We went back across the ice in the gray light with fifty prisoners and both buildings still burning behind us, and you could see the glow of them from the middle of the bay, from Staten Island, from the Battery in the city, the people told me afterward. The rebels said it all over Jersey for the rest of the war: that the King's men had come across the ice in the night and burned a house of God. They were right. They had.



He stopped. We were back on the porch by then; the rain had cleared and the boards were drying in patches. He'd brought his tea out with him, and he set it down on the rail.

"You said it wasn't yours," I said. "The end."

"It wasn't. I didn't light it. I didn't order it. The man who did order the raid tried to stop it, and couldn't." He looked at me. "And the road those men walked to the church that night, across the ice, through the marsh, in the dark, so quietly that nobody heard them coming, was mine. I made it. I was very proud of it." He was quiet. "I'm not asking you to forgive anybody. I'm telling you what happened. You can do something useful with a road, Ms. Barnett, and somebody else will always be waiting at the end of it with a torch. I learned that in Elizabethtown, and I've never once been able to unlearn it."

"Was there another one?" I said. "That night."

"There was. Not mine." He picked up the tea again. "The same night, another column went over the ice from the city itself, across the North River in sleighs to Paulus Hook, and then by road up to Newark. They burned the academy there. And they pulled a magistrate called Hedden out of his bed in his nightshirt and marched him off barefoot in the snow, and his wife tried to stop

them, and one of them ran her through with a bayonet.” He said it plainly, the way he’d said everything about that night. “Nobody I knew. Nobody I’d have trusted with a road. I only mention it because if I left it out, you’d find it, and you’d think I’d hidden it.”

“I would have found it.”

“I know,” he said. “That’s why I like you.”



● RECORDING · FEBRUARY 1780

The other one was Young’s House, a week later, and that one was mine from beginning to end.

I’ll tell it quickly. There was a farmhouse up in Westchester, in the middle of the Neutral Ground, at a crossroads near the Saw Mill River, called Young’s, after the family. The rebels had made it an outpost, the most forward post they had on that side of the river, with a few hundred men, Continentals and militia, in and around the house. It was a thorn. Every foraging party the King’s army sent up into the county that winter got news of it sent ahead by Young’s, and every Loyalist farm within ten miles got visited.

I knew the house. I knew every house up there. It was eleven miles from Captain Reynolds’s farm.

On the second of February, in the evening, a strong column left the old fort at the top of the island, the one the British had renamed Fort Knyphausen: a battalion of the Guards, Hessians, and the Westchester refugee horse, DeLancey’s men, who knew that country nearly as well as I did and hated everybody in it, under a lieutenant colonel of the Guards called Norton. And sleighs, to carry the foot, and two small field guns. The snow in Westchester was two feet deep on the level and more in the drifts. The roads were gone. You couldn’t see where they’d been.

But I knew where they’d been. Caesar’s body knew. It had driven those roads under snow every winter of its life.

I sat on the front of the first sleigh, next to the driver, all that night, and I told him where the road was. Left here, where the stone wall comes down to

the drift. Now straight, between the two big oaks; the road runs between them. Mind the brook; it's under there; keep to the right of the willow. Twenty miles, in the dark, in two feet of snow, with a column of men behind me who'd have been lost in the first hour without somebody who knew where the ground was under all that white.

We came out of the woods above Young's crossroads a little before nine in the morning, with the sun on the snow so bright it hurt your eyes, and the rebels at the house were cooking their breakfast.



It was over in about a quarter of an hour.

They fought. I want you to know that. They came out of the house and the barns and stood in the snow and fought, and some of them fought very well, but they had no guns that could answer ours, and DeLancey's horse came round behind them through the orchard. In a quarter of an hour fourteen of them were dead and thirty-seven wounded and more than seventy were standing in the yard with their hands up.

I have the fourteen. All of them. Where each one lay. The colors of their coats against the snow, and the snow under them. I didn't kill any of them. I'd never fired a shot. I'd only told a sleigh driver where the road was under the drifts.

And I have the seventy-six in the yard. I went down to the yard afterward, because Norton wanted somebody who knew the county to tell him who the prisoners were. Which were Continentals, which were militia, which were the local men who'd hang if the Loyalists got hold of them on their own. I walked along the line of them in the snow, slowly, with Norton's adjutant beside me writing down names.

And the ninth man in the line was Captain Joseph Reynolds.



He'd been at the house with a company of his militia. He was standing in the snow in his good blue coat with no hat, with his hands tied in front of him,

and blood on his cheek from a cut over the eye, and he looked older than I remembered, and smaller, and very cold.

He knew me at once. I saw him know me. I watched it go across his face, all of it: surprise, and then disbelief, and then something I think was nearly fear, and then, last, the thing I'd seen on the first morning I woke up in that body, at noon, in his barnyard, with his account book under his arm. He was looking at his property. Six months gone, and turned up in the wrong army, with a British officer at its elbow.

"Caesar," he said.

The adjutant looked up from his paper. At me, and then at Reynolds.

"You know this man?"

Everything I had was in that moment, Ms. Barnett. I want you to see it. I could have said anything. Norton's adjutant would have written it down. *This man is a militia captain and a committeeman, sir, and he hanged a Loyalist neighbor in '77.* It wasn't true, but it would have been believed, and DeLancey's men were standing ten feet away, listening, and some of them had neighbors who'd been hanged. I could have ended him with a sentence. And he knew it. I watched him know that too.

"Yes, sir," I said. "His name is Joseph Reynolds. He's a captain of the Westchester militia, from Bedford. He farms there. He's a decent man to his neighbors." I looked at Reynolds. "He'll do for exchange. He's no use to anybody dead."

The adjutant wrote it down. *Reynolds, Jos., Capt., militia, Bedford. Exchange.*

And Reynolds looked at me, there in the snow, as if he'd never seen me before in his life. Which, I suppose, he hadn't.

"Caesar," he said again. Quieter.

"Freeman," I said. "It's Freeman now, Captain."

I walked on down the line. I didn't look back. I heard later that he was exchanged in the spring, for a Loyalist lieutenant, and went home to Bedford, to his bottom land and his account book, and lived a long time. I don't know if he ever told anyone about the man in the yard at Young's. I don't know if he ever thought of it again. I've thought of it a great deal.



It was nearly four. The sun had come right round onto the porch, and the boards had dried, and steam came off the rail where it was still wet in the shade.

I'd stopped writing a while back. I realized it when I looked down and saw that my pen had been lying across the page, on the word *Reynolds*, for I didn't know how long.

"Why?" I said. "He owned you. You could have..." I stopped.

"I could have," he said. "Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

He thought about it, honestly, the way he thinks about everything I ask him, as if it's the first time anyone's ever asked.

"Because I'd spent six months being something he'd paid for," he said. "And I'd walked thirty miles in the dark so that I'd never have to be that again. And the moment that man in the yard was in my power, I found I didn't want to be the kind of thing that does what it likes with a man in its power." He picked up his cup, which was empty, and looked into it. "It wasn't goodness. I'd like to say it was. It was pride. I wanted him to know, for the rest of his life, that I'd had him in my hand and opened it." He set the cup down. "Write down that it was pride. You'll make it something nicer if you don't."

I wrote it down. *Pride*. And then, because I'm a reporter and not a saint, and because I couldn't help it, I wrote underneath it, very small, where he couldn't read it from his side of the table:

Not only.

Five Rockets

Freda watched the lecture four times that week, all forty minutes, start to finish, and found nothing.

She watched the beginning, where a man from the library foundation came to the lectern and read a very long introduction off a card. She watched the slides. She watched the questions at the end, all six of them, and the faces of the people asking them, as far as the camera showed them, which wasn't far. She watched the last ninety seconds, after the applause, where the camera stayed on for no reason and people stood up and put on their coats and a woman in the second row dropped her program. She made notes, in a document on her laptop with a title I wasn't allowed to see. On Wednesday night she shut the laptop and said, in a voice I knew from her chemistry homework, that it was a stupid video and the camera person was an idiot and she was going to bed.

I didn't say anything. I'd watched it eleven times myself.



On the Thursday it rained again, a long gray rain that came in sideways across the field and drummed on the porch roof, and we sat in the kitchen with the door shut and the stove going and the window streaming. I said the date into the recorders, *session thirty-three, Thursday, June tenth*, and he poured the tea, and looked at the rain on the window, and smiled.

"Good," he said. "That's about right for this one. Only colder."



Beckwith wanted Washington.

He didn't put it like that, the first time he spoke to me about it. He put it as a question about roads, the way he always did. But I knew what he meant before he'd finished the sentence, and so did he, and he watched me know it, and that was the first time I saw him nervous.

It was the week after Young's House. The ice was still hard. And Washington was sitting in a house in Morristown, in Jersey, thirty miles off, in the middle of a starving army in its huts, with a guard of a few hundred men round him, in the worst winter in living memory, when nobody in his army could imagine anything coming at them across the snow except more snow.

"A troop of horse," Beckwith said. "Three hundred, perhaps. Over the ice, at night, and across Jersey before light, by roads nobody's watching. Into the town. Out again with him in a sleigh, before his army knows he's gone." He had a map of Jersey on the table between us. His finger kept going back to one place on it. "What would they do, without him? That army? It's held together with string as it is. Take him away and the string goes."

"You'd have to get there, sir."

"That's what I'm asking you." He looked up. "Can it be done?"

I thought about it for a long time. I want you to know that I thought about it honestly, with everything I had, the way I'd have thought about it if it had been my own idea. Because there was a part of me, I'll admit it, that wanted to see it done. To be the man who brought George Washington across the ice to New York in a sleigh, and set him down in front of Knyphausen like a parcel. It would have been the greatest stroke of the whole war, from that side. It might have ended it.

And I didn't know how it would come out. I want you to understand that, because people always assume I must have. I don't know the future of any life I'm in, Ms. Barnett. I only know the ones I've finished. In February of 1780 Washington was a tired man in a farmhouse in Jersey, and for all I knew he'd be in New York by the end of the week, in a sleigh, and the war

would be over, and I'd have done it. I wanted it, a little. And I was afraid of it, a little more, though I couldn't have told you why.

So I didn't tell Beckwith it couldn't be done. I told him the truth about the roads.

"It can be done, sir," I said. "In good snow. Not this snow."



He wanted to know why, and I told him.

The snow in Jersey was deep and soft that week, after the storms of January, too deep for horses to go fast. That was bad, but it wasn't the worst of it. The worst of it was the weather that was coming. I could smell it, the way Caesar's body had smelled it every winter of its life. A warm wind from the south, and rain on top of the snow, and then the cold coming back behind the rain, hard, overnight. When that happens, the top of the snow melts and freezes again, into a crust. A hard crust, like a pie, an inch thick, with soft snow underneath.

"A man can walk on a crust like that, sir, mostly, if he's careful," I said. "A horse can't. A horse goes through it at every step. Down through the crust into the soft snow, and up again, and down. And every time it goes through, the edge of the crust is like the edge of a knife, round the leg, just above the hoof, where there's no meat at all." I touched my own ankle. "Three miles of that and you'll have horses bleeding from all four legs. Six miles and they'll stop. They won't go on. No rider alive can make them."

"How do you know the rain's coming?"

"I don't know, sir. I'm telling you what the wind smells like."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked at the map. His finger was on Morristown again.

"Thank you," he said. "That'll be all."



He went to Knyphausen with the plan on the seventh of February, and the old general approved it. On the eighth, the rain came. Snow first, then rain,

all day, warm and gray, just as I'd said. They put it off.

And then, on the night of the tenth, the cold came back hard, and froze the whole country over again, crust on top of snow, just as I'd said, and they went anyway.

I wasn't with them. Jersey wasn't my country, and they had Jersey Loyalists for guides who'd been born on those roads. About three hundred horse: the hussars of the Queen's Rangers, and the Seventeenth Dragoons, under their lieutenant colonel, a man called Birch, a good cavalry officer, quiet, who looked after his horses. And at the same time, to keep the rebels looking the wrong way, parties of foot went over from Staten Island under Simcoe and General Skinner, to make a noise along the shore.

Beckwith sent me to the Jersey shore that night, to the British post at Paulus Hook, across the river from the city, to listen. That was my whole part. To lie on the ice in the dark at the edge of Jersey and tell him in the morning what I'd heard.

I heard them go. A long way off, inland, the sound of horses moving fast on hard snow, and then not fast, and then hardly at all. I heard, very faintly, a horse screaming. Then another. If you've never heard a horse scream you won't know what I mean, and I hope you never do.

And at about two in the morning, I saw the rockets.



Five of them. One after another, going up out of the dark country to the west, very small at that distance, little threads of red fire climbing into the sky and bursting, one, two, three, four, five. Then nothing.

It was the signal for every party to turn back. Birch had got five miles, perhaps six, with his horses bleeding from every leg on the crust exactly as I'd told Beckwith they would, and he'd looked at the country still ahead of him, twenty-odd miles of it, and at his horses, and he'd done the only thing a good cavalry officer could do. He'd sent up the rockets and turned round.

I lay there on the ice and watched the last one fade, and I'll tell you honestly what I felt. I felt two things at once, and I've never been able to separate them, not in two hundred and forty-seven years. I felt sorry. For Beckwith,

who'd wanted it so much, and for Birch's horses, and a little, God help me, for myself, who'd been one road away from being the man who caught Washington. And under that, lower down, I felt something I didn't have a name for, that was very much like relief.

Because I hadn't had to choose. I'd told the truth about the snow, and the truth hadn't been enough, and the weather had decided it instead of me. Whatever came of that war now, I hadn't been the man who carried Washington across the ice in a sack.

Hugh Gaine, the printer, wrote in his journal the next day that the troops had gone out to surprise General Washington at Morristown. That's very nearly all anybody wrote. That's all it ever was, in the record. A night ride that came to nothing.

I don't know that Washington ever knew how close it came. I've never found that he did.



He stopped, and got up, and stood at the window with his back to me, looking at the rain. It had settled in for the afternoon. The field was gray with it, and the hay rows had gone dark and flat.

"You were right," I said. "About the crust."

"I was right about the crust," he said, to the window. "Remember that, later. You'll need it." He came back and sat down. "That's twice now I've been right and been thanked and sent away. The first time it didn't matter. It didn't matter at all." He picked up his tea. "Let's do something smaller. I could do with something smaller."



• RECORDING · FEBRUARY 1780

The thaw came at the end of February. The ice in the harbor went gray, and then soft, and then it began to break up at the edges, with great groans and cracks you could hear all over the city at night, and the first boats tried the

river again and got through. Everybody in the city was glad. The wood boats came back. The firewood came back. People stopped dying in their cellars.

And everybody who wanted to leave the city without being seen knew that they had about a week left.

There was a soldier in one of the British regiments in the city, a corporal, whose name I won't give you, because he has descendants, and he was a fool rather than a villain, and he's been punished enough. He'd decided to desert to the rebels. Lots of men did, from both sides, every week of that war. But he'd decided to take something with him, so that the rebels would be glad to see him. He'd made a drawing. All the posts on the north end of the island, the guns at each, the number of men, the hours the guard changed. He'd done it well. He'd been a draughtsman's apprentice in Bristol before the army got him.

Prince found out about it first. He was building a gun platform at one of those posts, and he'd watched the corporal pacing out distances with his lips moving, and drawing in a little book when he thought nobody was looking. Nobody ever thinks a carpenter is looking.

Prince told me, in the shed, at night. He wasn't sure what to do with it. A Black workman accusing a British corporal of anything, in that city, with nothing but his own eyes to show for it, was likely to end up with his back laid open for insolence, and the corporal free.

"Then we don't accuse him," I said. "We wait till he goes. And we bring him back with the book in his pocket. Nobody argues with a book."



There was a third man with us. A wagoner called Isaac, who'd come in from Jersey the year before, a big slow good-tempered man who could lift the back of a cart off the ground by himself. We needed him for that. We didn't need anything clever. We needed somebody the corporal couldn't argue with.

I worked out where the corporal would go. It wasn't hard. The ice was going everywhere except in one place, at the top of the island, in the narrow water by Kingsbridge, where it still held, just, in the cold mornings. And I worked out when: the first night the guard on that post was men from another

er regiment, who didn't know his face. It took him four nights to find one. We waited all four, the three of us, in the cold, in a cowshed above the shore. Prince sang hymns under his breath. Isaac slept. I watched.

On the fourth night he came down to the shore in the dark with a bundle, and stepped out onto the ice, and we stepped out behind him.

He ran, of course. They always run. He got about forty yards out, and then the ice under him made the long low singing sound it made when it was thinking about going, and he stopped dead, as anybody would, and Isaac walked out behind him, quite calmly, on the thicker ice I showed him, and picked him up round the waist like a sack of meal and carried him back to the shore.

The book was in his coat. Prince found it. He held it up in the starlight so the corporal could see it, and didn't say a word.

We walked him to the guard at Kingsbridge, the three of us, with his hands tied with Isaac's belt, and handed him and his little book to the officer of the guard. The officer read the book by his lantern for a long time, turning the pages, and then he looked at the three of us standing in the snow, and he looked at the corporal, and he didn't say thank you. He said, "Wait there," and went in, and wrote something, and came out again, and gave each of us a shilling, and told us to go home.



"That's it?" I said. "A shilling?"

"A shilling each." He smiled. "Isaac bought a hat with his. A good one. He wore it till he died."

"What happened to the corporal?"

"They didn't hang him. They should have, by their own rules. But he'd been caught before he got anywhere, by three men nobody was ever going to call as witnesses at a court martial, and so it was easier to flog him and send him to the West Indies, where the fever would very likely do it for them." He was quiet. "It did, I think. A year later."

"And you three?"

“We went back to the shed.” He looked at the rain. “But that one’s in the record, Ms. Barnett. I’ve always rather liked that. It’s the only time I’m in the record that whole war, under any name at all. In Clinton’s papers, somewhere, there’s a line. The officer wrote it up, that night, and it went to headquarters with the corporal’s book, and it’s still there, as far as I know, in a box in a library.” He turned his cup. “It doesn’t say Caesar Freeman. It doesn’t say Prince, or Isaac. It says the corporal was caught and brought in by three Black men. That’s all. Three of them, no names, in a line on a page.” He looked at me. “But it’s true. It’s the truest line anybody ever wrote about me.”

I wrote down the words exactly as he’d said them. *A deserter, caught and brought in by three Black men.* And under it, *Clinton’s papers.* And under that, *Find it.* Then I underlined *Find it* twice, which I really don’t do, and he watched me do it from across the table, with the rain behind him, and didn’t say anything at all, and I saw that he was pleased.

The Woman at the Edge of the Frame

It was the last week of school, and Freda had stopped pretending to care about it.

She had two exams left and a locker to empty and a chemistry teacher who had given up teaching and was showing films. She came home at two every day instead of four. On the Friday after the rain, I came back from the grocery store at three and found her at the kitchen table with the laptop and the big white headphones and a bowl of dry cereal she was eating with her fingers, one piece at a time, without looking at it.

“I said it was a stupid video,” she said, without taking the headphones off. “I was right. It is.”

“I know.”

“So I stopped watching it.” She pulled one side of the headphones away from her ear. “He does it every year. The talk. You said.”

“Every spring. The enemies of paper.”

“So there’s more than one video.” She turned the laptop round so I could see. It was the historical society’s page, the plain blue one I’d found in the spring, with the link to the talk. Only she’d gone past the link, to a page I hadn’t known was there, a list. *Annual Spring Lecture, Archive*. Five years of them, each with its own little gray thumbnail of a man in a bow tie at a lectern. “They put them all up. Nobody’s watched most of them. One of them has nine views. I’m like four of them.”

I put the groceries down on the counter.

“You watched all five.”

“Not all of all five. That would be over three hours of a man talking about mold.” She ate a piece of cereal. “Just the ends. The last five minutes of each one. After everybody claps.”

“Why the ends?”

“Because that’s when the camera person forgets the camera’s on,” Freda said. “In every single one of them, they forget. They just leave it running on the stage, and he picks up his notes, and people come up and talk to him, and the camera just sits there and watches. Like that one at the end of the first video where the woman drops her program.” She tapped the screen. “That’s where the people are. I said.”

“You did say.”

“So.” She dragged the cursor to the third thumbnail on the list. *Spring Lecture, Three Years Ago*. “Watch this. It’s at thirty-eight forty.”

She took the headphones off and unplugged them, and turned the sound up, and pressed play.



It was a different room from the one in the video I knew. A smaller one, with a low ceiling and folding chairs and a portrait of a man in a wig on the wall behind the lectern. The same bow tie. A different color. He was saying thank you for coming, and the audience was clapping, the thin, dutiful clapping of fifty people in a library on a Sunday afternoon in March.

Then he stepped back from the lectern and began gathering his notes, and the clapping died away, and the camera stayed on him, exactly as Freda had said, with nobody at all thinking about it.

There was a step down from the little stage at the front of the room. One step. Six inches, perhaps, carpeted. He came to the edge of it with his notes in one hand, and stopped, and looked down at it, and you could see him decide it was further than it looked.

And a woman came into the frame from the right.

She came quickly, the way you come for someone you’ve come for a hundred times before. Fifty or so. Tall, with gray coming into short dark hair, in jeans and a fleece vest over a flannel shirt and the kind of boots people wear for

actual mud. She didn't make anything of it. She just put her hand under his elbow as he stepped down, not taking his weight, just there, and he leaned on it for exactly as long as the step took and no longer, and didn't look at her, and she didn't look at him either. They'd done it before. You could tell from how little either of them did.

She said something to him. The microphone on the lectern was still live, a little way off, and it caught her, just.

Dad, I'm in a loading zone. Don't let them keep you.

He laughed. Not the big laugh. A small one, for her. And said something I couldn't hear. And she put her other hand in her vest pocket and took it out with her keys, and stood there jingling them, impatient and patient at once, while a man in a cardigan came up and shook his hand and began to tell him something at length.

Freda reached past me and paused it.

"Look at her keys," she said.

I looked. Car keys, two of them, and a little bunch of smaller ones, and a key ring. A brass key ring in the shape of a horse's head. And on the fleece vest, on the left side, over her heart, an embroidered patch, too small to read at that size.

"I made it bigger," Freda said, and clicked to another window on her laptop, where she'd taken a screenshot of that frame and blown it up until it went to squares. The squares were enough. A horse, in outline, jumping. And a name in an arc over it, and under it a smaller word.

PURCELLVILLE.



I didn't say anything for a long moment. Then I went and got my bag off the hook in the hall and came back and took out my notebook, and opened it at the page with my fourteen names on it in a column, and put it on the table in front of her, next to the laptop. And I put my finger on one of them.

Claire (daughter), Loudoun Co.

And then on the line I'd written next to Margaret Whitcombe's name, from her obituary, the week before, because I make a note of everything.

In lieu of flowers, horse rescue, Purcellville.

Freda looked at it. Then at the squares on her screen. Then at me.

"Oh my God," she said.

"Yes."

"His daughter."

"His daughter drives him," I said. "Three years ago she drove him to a library on a Sunday afternoon and parked in a loading zone and came in and stood at the side of the room for forty minutes so she could put her hand under his elbow for one step." I could hear my own voice, and it didn't sound like mine. "She's done it a hundred times. You can see she has. Tom asked me who drives a man of seventy-three into the city. That's who. That's exactly who."

"The person who wasn't laughing," Freda said.

"Maybe. It's not proof."

"I know it's not proof." She looked offended. "I'm not stupid. It's a fleece." She looked at the frozen frame, at the woman with her hand still half out of her pocket with the keys. "But she's somebody you'd sit in a car for. If you were her. You'd sit there in the car for him for half an hour and not even ask, because he's your dad and he's old and he asked you." She stopped. Then she said, in a different voice, quieter, "I'd do it for mine."

I looked at her. She was looking at the screen.

"I know you would," I said.



That night I did what I should have done a week before, and looked up the daughter.

It was easy, now I knew where to stand. Claire Whitcombe had kept her name. She was a veterinarian, a large-animal vet, with a practice of her own outside Purcellville, horses mostly, and a page on the practice's website with a photograph of her in a barn, in the same kind of fleece vest, with her hand on a horse's neck, not smiling for the camera, looking at the horse. She was on the board of the horse rescue her mother's obituary had named. She'd written an article for a county horse magazine about laminitis that I read all the way through without understanding a word of it. She'd been divorced for nine years. Two sons, both in college. She lived twenty minutes from her father.

She had no record of anything. Of course she didn't. She'd been the one who stayed in the car.

I wrote it all down on a fresh page under her name, and then I sat with my hand flat on it for a long time, the way I'd sat in the reading room with my hand over the foreword.

"You should go," Freda said from the couch. She was supposed to be asleep. "Tomorrow. Before she finds out."

"Finds out what?"

"That somebody's looking. People always find out. Maddie's mom found out about me and Maddie's lab in like a day."

"She won't find out," I said. "I'm not going tomorrow."

"Why not?"

Because of what he'd said. Because the man who was laughing was used to being believed, and the woman who wasn't laughing had been telling herself the same story every night for six years until it was smooth as a stone. Because a person can be asked a question for the first time exactly once, and I'd get one chance at her, at the most, before she called her father, and her father called Carrow House, and the door shut for good.

"Because I want to get it right," I said. "I'm going to ask Tom first."

Freda was quiet on the couch for a while. Then she said, into the dark, "Can I tell him? In my letter. That it was me that found her."

She'd been writing to him since the spring. Short letters, on lined paper, folded in thirds. He wrote back. I'd never read either side, and I wasn't going to.

"Yes," I said. "You should tell him it was you."

"It was me," Freda said, to the ceiling, with enormous satisfaction, and turned over, and was asleep, I think, in about a minute.



I stayed at the table.

Before I went to bed I watched the end of that video once more, by myself, with the sound low. The step. The hand under the elbow. *Dad, I'm in a loading zone.* The keys.

And then something else, that I hadn't seen the first time because I'd been looking at the keys. As the man in the cardigan talked, and her father listened and nodded and was charming, the daughter stopped jingling her keys and looked away from them both, toward the back of the room, toward the door, toward wherever the car was waiting in its loading zone. Just for a second. Not impatient. Something else.

I've seen that look on a great many faces, in a great many parking lots, in the old days. It's the look of a person who is listening for an engine.

How the Letters Leave

He had Freda's letter on the kitchen table when I came in, under the sugar bowl, folded in thirds the way she folds them. He didn't mention it. He made the tea and put the cups down and sat, and I said the date into the recorders, *session thirty-four, Thursday, June seventeenth*, and then he looked at me over the top of his cup with an expression I'd never seen on him before, and it took me a moment to understand that it was pride.

"I had a letter," he said.

"I know."

"She says it was her."

"It was her."

"She says," he said, and unfolded it, and read off it, though I'm certain he knew it by heart, *"It was at the end of the video from three years ago, because that is when the camera person forgets, which I said. Mom says to tell you it is not proof. I know it is not proof. It is a fleece."* He folded it up again, carefully, and put it back under the sugar bowl. "She'll do," he said. "She'll more than do."

"She's been unbearable all week."

"Good. She's earned a week." He drank some tea. "And you haven't gone."

"No. I wanted to ask you how."

He thought about it. Outside it was the first real summer day, clear and hot and very still, and the bees were loud in the clover at the edge of the yard.

"Go where she works," he said. "Not where she lives. People are braver at their work. Their hands know what they're doing, even when the rest of them doesn't. And don't go as a reporter. Go as a woman who wants to ask her one

question.” He set his cup down. “And not this week. Let her have one more week of not knowing anybody’s looking. You’ll need her to have had it.”

I didn’t understand that. I wrote it down anyway.

“Now,” he said. “Spring. Beckwith had lost his ice, and he wanted something to show for it.”



• RECORDING · MARCH 1780

When the ice went out of the harbor, the letters started moving again. We knew because the deserters told us.

Not in so many words. But every deserter who came in from Jersey that spring was questioned at headquarters, and some of them had been servants to rebel officers, and grooms and cooks, and they’d heard things at their officers’ tables. And what they’d heard, more than once, was that General Washington knew what was happening in New York. Which regiments had gone south with Clinton and which were still in the city. How many cords of wood were left in the yards. When a fleet was fitting out. Not quickly. Weeks late, sometimes. But he knew.

Beckwith had me in his office in the second week of March, with the window open for the first time since December and the noise of the slips coming in with the smell of the river, and he was angry. Not with me. He was angry the way a man is when he’s done everything right and it hasn’t worked.

“Hill finds nothing,” he said. “Eight months at that table. He’s opened four thousand letters. He’s turned out every basket on Long Island. He’s made half the farmers in Kings County stand in their stockings. Nothing.” He pushed a paper across the table at me, face down; I suppose he’d forgotten I couldn’t read. “We’ve had the letters held to the fire. We’ve had them washed with every acid the surgeons have got. Nothing comes up. They’re letters about butter. About cousins. About the price of salt. And Washington is still getting his news.”

“Then it isn’t in the letters, sir.”

“I’ve thought of that,” he said, sharply.

“Yes, sir. I meant something else.” I thought about how to say it. “Mr. Hill looks at what a man’s carrying. He opens it and reads it. If it says nothing, he gives it back. So whatever’s carrying the news has got to be something a man can carry openly, that Mr. Hill will look at and give straight back. Something that says nothing, on its face.” I paused. “There’s nothing that says less than a blank sheet of paper.”

Beckwith looked at me.

“You’ve had letters held to the fire, sir,” I said, “and nothing came up. So it’s an ink that doesn’t answer to fire. Or to the surgeons’ acids. Only to its own key. A man would need to carry a little bottle of the key with him, wherever the letter was going. And he’d need to write on paper that didn’t look written on.” I stopped. “If I were doing it, I’d write on a clean sheet, and put the sheet in the middle of a quire of clean sheets, and carry the quire to the country as if I’d bought it for somebody, in a basket, with the tea and sugar. And Mr. Hill would riffle through it and see twenty-four sheets of good paper, and put it back in the basket.”

There was a long silence. Somewhere down at the slips a man was shouting at a horse.

“And how,” Beckwith said, slowly, “would the man at the other end know which of the twenty-four?”

“He’d know because they’d agreed it. The fourth sheet. The one with a pinprick in the corner. The one folded a certain way.” I shrugged. “Or he wouldn’t, and he’d have to try every sheet with his bottle. Which would waste a great deal of his bottle.”

I didn’t know then, of course, how right that was. I’ve read their letters since. A good many of them, Ms. Barnett, are two frightened men complaining to each other that they’ve run out of the key, and can’t read what’s been sent, and can’t get more. One of them wrote, once, that he’d sent three blank sheets instead of one, for fear of sending the wrong one. I laughed out loud in a library when I read that. A librarian asked me to leave.



So I went looking for paper.

It's a strange thing to hunt, a sheet of blank paper. But paper wasn't cheap in New York in 1780. Most of it came from England, across the sea, in war time, and it cost a good deal, and people who bought it were people who wrote. Merchants. Clerks. Officers. Lawyers. Not farmers. Not carters. A Long Island farmer might buy a few sheets in a year, to write to a cousin or settle a debt. He didn't buy it by the quire.

There were perhaps a dozen shops in the city that sold good writing paper. Stationers. Printers. A few dry goods merchants who kept it among the cloth and the tea. I couldn't go into any of them and ask who'd been buying paper, of course. A Black man asking a merchant about his customers would have been thrown out at best, and reported at worst, and the man I was looking for would have heard about it by supper. But I didn't need to ask. I only needed to stand outside, at the right hour, holding somebody's horse, or carrying somebody's parcel, or sitting on the step of the next house with my hat over my eyes. Nobody looks at a Black man sitting on a step in New York. I'd learned that much.

I watched what came out of those shops, and where it went, for three weeks.

And I watched the ferry. That was the end of every road east. Everything that went to Long Island went over the ferry, and everything that went over the ferry went past me, sooner or later, if I stood at the top of the stairs long enough. I stood there a great deal, that March. The widow had her cart back at the top of the stairs as soon as the ice was gone, with her eggs and her butter and her little iron pot of coals for the cold mornings. I bought eggs from her twice a week, as I had before, and put them inside my shirt, and stood and watched the people waiting for the boat. She had eleven, one of those mornings. I remember thinking she'd had a slow week. I didn't buy any that day. I had enough.



The carter came on a Tuesday.

He wasn't anybody. That was what caught me. A Long Island man, about thirty, broad and quiet, with a good wagon and a good gray horse, who cart-

ed goods between the city and the north shore of the Island for anybody who'd pay him, every week or two. Butter and cheese and firewood in. Rum and sugar and nutmeg and cloth out. There were twenty men doing the same thing. He was a carpenter by trade, the boatmen said, a joiner, and cart work paid better in a war. I'd seen him a dozen times and never once thought about him.

But that Tuesday I'd seen him come out of a dry goods shop, the week before, with his hands full, and put a parcel in his wagon. And the parcel was the right size and the right shape and the right weight for a quire of good paper, wrapped in brown paper and tied with string. And now here he was at the ferry with his wagon, and the parcel was in among the sugar, and when Hill's men turned his load over at the Brooklyn landing, they found the parcel and opened it, and riffled through twenty-four sheets of good clean writing paper, and asked him what a carter wanted with all that, and he said it was for a gentleman in Setauket who'd asked him to get it, and had paid for it, and would want it.

And they gave it back to him. Of course they did. It was paper.

Setauket. A village of a few hundred people on the north shore of Long Island, fifty-five miles from the city, a long day's ride, with a harbor that faced straight across the Sound at Connecticut. Where, as it happened, the rebels had a whaleboat officer called Brewster who came over in the dark with armed crews to raid the Loyalist farms and carry off whatever he could, and who'd been born there, and was known to every soul in the place.

It wasn't proof. It was a parcel. But I'd watched the ferry for eight months by then, and I knew every carter on that road, and none of the others had ever carried paper out to the country. Not once.



I went to Beckwith with it. Not with the carter's face. With the road.

I drew it for him on his own map with my finger, since I couldn't be seen to write. A man in the city, a man of business, who could buy good paper without anyone wondering, writes his news in an ink that only answers to its own key, on one sheet of a quire. A carter takes the quire out with his load,

over the ferry, past Mr. Hill, along the north shore, fifty-five miles, to Setauket. Somebody in Setauket opens it, and finds the right sheet, and reads it, and adds his own news of the Island. And on an agreed night a whaleboat comes over from Connecticut, twenty miles, in the dark, and takes it back across the Sound, and a dragoon rides it to Washington.

"Five men," I said. "Perhaps six. The man in the city. The carter. The man in Setauket. The boat. The officer in Connecticut who gets it at the other end. And the man in the city has never once set foot outside it, so far as anyone knows. He's not on the road. He's never searched. He's a gentleman. He goes about his business. He keeps a shop, or a counting house, or a desk, and he listens, and he writes it down at night."

Beckwith was silent for a long time, looking at my finger on his map.

"And his name?" he said, at last.

"I don't know it, sir."

"The carter's?"

I'd known the question was coming. I'd thought about it, walking up from the slips, all the way to his door. If I gave him the carter's face, he'd have the carter taken at the ferry the next time he came over, and searched to the skin, and the quire held to every flame in the city, and nothing would come up, because the ink only answered to its own key. And the carter would say the paper was for a gentleman in Setauket, which was true. And they'd let him go, eventually, or hang him on suspicion, and the man in the city would hear of it before the day was out, and cut the road, and start another one I didn't know about.

You don't pull up the first root you find, Ms. Barnett. You find out where it goes.

"I'd know his horse anywhere, sir," I said. "I don't know his name. And I don't think you want him yet. If you take him, they'll only find another carter. I think you want the road to feel watched. Every mile of it." I took my finger off the map. "I think you want them frightened."

He looked up at me then, the long cool look, and I saw him think about all the reasons a man in my position might not want to give him a name.

Then I saw him decide that the one I'd given was the true one, which it was. Mostly.

"Frightened," Beckwith said. He picked up his pen. "Yes. I think I can frighten Setauket."



He stopped and looked out of the window. The bees were still going in the clover. A car went by on the gravel road, slowly, raising a long plume of white dust that hung in the still air and drifted across the field and settled.

"Mostly?" I said.

He turned back.

"You said it was the true reason. Mostly."

He smiled a little.

"I didn't want to give anybody a face," he said. "Not yet. I'd seen what happened to faces in that city. I'd given Robinson one at Young's House, the year's only face, and it had been the man who owned me, and I'd spent it on getting him exchanged." He turned his cup on the table, a quarter turn. "The carter whistled when he drove, and he gave his horse half his bread. I wanted to be sure. That's all. I wanted to be quite sure, before I gave anybody a face."

"And were you? Sure?"

"Oh, yes," he said. "He was one of them. He rode that road for them for two more years. Nobody ever took him." He looked at me. "And I never gave anybody his face, Ms. Barnett. Not that spring and not ever. You can write that down too. Next week I'll tell you what I did instead."

I wrote it. *Never gave the carter's face*. And then I sat looking at what I'd written, and at the word *frightened* a few lines above it, and I understood, or thought I did, that the hunt he was about to tell me about wasn't going to be the kind where somebody gets caught.

Shutting the Road

The week he'd told me to wait was the longest week of the summer.

I didn't go to Purcellville. I didn't drive past the practice, which I'd found on the map, a long low barn with green trim on a road outside town, with a gravel lot and a sign with a jumping horse on it. I didn't call. I didn't look at the horse rescue's website more than twice a day. I wrote nine hundred words about a dentist's new chair and a thousand about seamless gutters, and I took Freda to buy a dress for her friend's sister's wedding, and I didn't sleep very well.

On the Thursday it was ninety-one degrees by eleven, and the porch was in full sun, and he'd moved us to the kitchen with the fan going and the shades half down. I said the date into the recorders, *session thirty-five, Thursday, June twenty-fourth*, and he said, before I could ask, "Next week. Go next week," and I let out a breath I hadn't known I was holding.

"Now," he said. "Frightening Setauket."



• RECORDING • APRIL 1780

It's easy to frighten people in a war. Anybody can do it. You burn a barn, you hang a man at a crossroads, you send a troop of horse galloping through a village at midnight. People are frightened. And then they get used to it, the way people get used to anything, and in a month they're doing exactly what they were doing before, only angrier.

That wasn't the kind of frightened I meant.

I wanted them frightened the way you're frightened when you realize somebody's been reading your letters. Not by noise. By quiet. By the sense, slowly, at every step of the road, that somebody had been there first, and was being very polite about it.

So we did small things. Beckwith did most of them. He had the authority and the men, and he was cleverer at this than he looked, once he understood what I meant. I just told him where.



The first thing was the paper.

An officer from the Commandant's office, a polite young lieutenant with a clipboard and a cold, went round the shops in the city that sold good writing paper. All of them. Stationers, printers, the dry goods men who kept a few quires among the cloth. He told each of them the same thing, pleasantly. That because of the war, and the shortage of paper, and certain irregularities that had come to the notice of headquarters, the Commandant would be grateful to know, from now on, the name of anybody who bought writing paper by the quire or the ream to carry out of the city. Purely for the record. Nothing more. He wrote the shopkeeper's name on his clipboard, thanked him, and left.

That was all. He didn't search anything. He didn't threaten anybody. He went to fourteen shops in two days, and in every one of them, he left behind a man who now knew that the army had begun to wonder about paper.

In one of them, I knew, he'd left behind a man who'd gone very white indeed after the door closed. I didn't know which one. I've worked it out since.



The second thing was the road.

Fifty-five miles from the ferry to Setauket, along the north shore of the Island, through Jamaica and Flushing and Hempstead, through a dozen villages, past a hundred farms. Most of that country was quartered with the King's troops that spring, one regiment or another, Loyalists mostly, in win-

ter quarters. And the men who rode that road with anything to hide knew every post on it. Which taverns the officers drank in. Which bridges had a guard. Where you could ride through a village at dusk and nobody would look up.

Beckwith changed it. Not much. A sentry where there hadn't been one, at a bridge near Huntington. A picket moved half a mile down the road from where everybody knew it was. A troop of the Seventeenth Dragoons riding out along the north shore on an exercise, through Setauket and out the other side, and back again three days later, for no reason anybody could see. A deserter's story, let slip on purpose in a Jamaica tavern by one of Beckwith's men, that headquarters had a list of names on the north shore. There was no list. There didn't need to be.

And a rumor. That was the best of them, and it was mine. That two whole regiments were to be put into winter quarters in Setauket itself, next season. Two regiments, in a village of a few hundred people. Every house with soldiers in the kitchen. Every barn with an officer's horse in it. Every cove on the harbor with a sentry. It wasn't decided. Nobody had decided it. But a quartermaster's clerk on the north shore was asked to look into the forage there, and how many cords of wood the village could furnish, and he asked about it, loudly, at every farm, and the farmers asked each other, and by the beginning of March everybody in Setauket was certain it was coming.

I read the letter, a long time afterward, that their man in Setauket wrote in the middle of March. Two regiments, he told Tallmadge, were to be stationed there. And then: *If it should take place it will I fear entirely ruin our correspondence.*

I can't tell you how I felt when I read that. Two hundred years later, in a library, in a reading room, with my gloves on. I'd made that sentence happen. I'd sat in a cold office with my finger on a map and made a frightened farmer in Setauket write it down.



The third thing was the carter.

I never gave him to anybody. I told you that. But I didn't leave him alone either.

On a morning in April I was at the Brooklyn landing, on the far side of the ferry, by Hill's table, when his wagon came off the boat from the city with his good gray horse in the shafts. Hill's men turned his load over, as they did everybody's: sugar, a cask of rum, a bolt of blue cloth, the usual. No paper, that morning. And while they did it, I went and stood at the gray horse's head.

I didn't say anything to the carter. I didn't look at him. I looked at the horse. I put my hand on its neck and stroked it, slowly, the way Caesar had stroked horses all his life, and the horse leaned into my hand the way horses always leaned into Caesar's. And I said, to the horse, not loudly, "Good horse. You go to Setauket a great deal, don't you? Every week or two. Good long road, that."

Then I took my hand away and went back to Hill's table and stood there with my arms folded, watching the boat go back across the river.

The carter didn't move for a long moment. Then he got up on his wagon and drove off up the Brooklyn road, not fast, not slow, whistling, like any man on any morning. But I'd watched his hands on the reins while I stroked his horse, and they'd gone white at the knuckles. And he wasn't whistling a tune. He was whistling one note, over and over, the way a man does when he's forgotten what tune he meant to whistle.

He came back over the ferry eleven days later. No paper. And the next time, three weeks after that, no paper. And the next.



The paper stopped in the middle of April.

I didn't know why. I didn't know anything then except what I could see from the ferry: that the carter still came, with his rum and his sugar and his nutmeg, but never again that spring with a parcel the shape of a quire. That the rumors about Setauket went round the north shore and came back to us bigger. That the dragoons rode out and rode back. That the polite lieu-

tenant's clipboard had fourteen names on it and not one purchase of paper by the quire.

And that the widow at the top of the ferry stairs on the city side had a full dozen eggs in her two rows every morning I passed that May. Every one of them. I noticed it, as I noticed everything. I remember thinking her business must be very bad, and buying an extra two, once or twice, because I felt sorry for her.

That's what I could see. Here is what I couldn't, which I learned a long time afterward, reading their own letters, in that library, with my gloves on.

The man in the city stopped writing. Their man in Setauket went into New York in the middle of April, as he'd planned, to see him, and found him frightened, and begged him to go on, and got nothing but what he called *his utter denial*. In May he wrote to Tallmadge that the man in the city *declines serving any longer*. He'd still talk, if somebody came, he said. But he wouldn't put another word on paper.

And on the nineteenth of May, at his headquarters in Jersey, George Washington sat down and wrote to Tallmadge that since the man in the city had *totally declined*, and the man in Setauket *seems to wish to do it*, he thought *the intercourse may be dropped*.

Dropped. Washington's own word. His best spies in New York, his only real eyes inside the city, dropped. For two months, from the middle of April to the middle of July, nothing came out of New York to Washington by that road. Not a word. In the spring of 1780, while Clinton was taking Charleston and the war was going worse for the rebels than it ever had or would again.

Nobody was hanged. Nobody was arrested. Nobody was searched to the skin or held to a flame. Nobody ever knew who'd done it, on either side. A polite lieutenant had gone round some shops with a clipboard, and a troop of horse had ridden through a village and back, and a clerk had asked about firewood, and a Black man had stroked a horse at a ferry landing. And Washington's best spies had stopped writing to him.

That was the best work I did in that war, Ms. Barnett. Better than the ice. Better than any of it. I've never been prouder of anything than of the things

in that war that nobody ever knew happened.



He stopped, and got up, and went to the window, and lifted the shade an inch with one finger and looked out at the glare.

I didn't say anything for a while. The fan ticked round on the counter. I had written *the intercourse may be dropped* in my notebook and drawn a box round it, and I sat looking at the box.

"Washington got other news," I said finally. "Didn't he? From somewhere."

"He did." He let the shade fall. "He opened another road, through Staten Island, with other people. It was slower, and it was worse, and it didn't see what the man in the city saw." He came back to the table. "I'm not going to tell you I won the war that spring. I won a road. That's all. For two months." He sat down. "But I won it without a single person in that whole chain coming to harm. And I'd never managed that before, in any life. Not once. I'd always had to break something."

"And the eggs," I said.

He looked at me.

"Twelve," I said. "Every time you passed, in May. You said she always had eleven, the morning in January, and the morning in March, and now in May it was twelve. A full dozen." I tapped my notebook, where I'd written it, each time, because he'd told me to. "You told me to write down eleven. You said I'd want it later."

He was quiet for a long time. The fan went round.

"Did I," he said at last. And then, very gently, "Keep writing them down, Ms. Barnett. Every time I tell you. That's all I'll say."

I kept looking at him. He kept looking back. And then he smiled, and got up to make more tea, and wouldn't say another word about eggs for the rest of the afternoon, though I gave him four separate chances.

Claire

I went on the Tuesday, at the end of June, in the morning, because he'd said people were braver at their work, and vets work mornings.

It was an hour and a quarter west of my kitchen, out past Leesburg, where the suburbs give up and the country starts all at once, between one traffic light and the next. Rolling fields, white board fences, stone walls, big trees standing alone in pastures with horses in their shade. The kind of country where the mailboxes have names on them instead of numbers. The road to the practice was gravel for the last half mile. The sign at the gate had a jumping horse on it, the same horse as the patch on the fleece, and under it, *Catoctin Equine, C. Whitcombe, DVM*, and under that, smaller, *Emergencies call anytime*.

I sat in the car in the gravel lot for ten minutes with the engine off.

I'd decided, driving out, what I'd say, and I'd decided it again at every traffic light, and every time it came out differently. In the end I'd decided on the thing he'd told me. Not a reporter. A woman with one question. I'd left my notebook in the car. I'd left both recorders in the car. I had my phone in my pocket, switched off, and nothing in my hands at all, which was the strangest part. I couldn't remember the last time I'd gone to ask somebody a question with nothing in my hands.



The barn was long and low, with green trim and a wide center aisle open at both ends so the air could go through, and it smelled the way barns smell, of hay and horse and something medicinal and clean. A radio somewhere was

playing country music very quietly. A young woman in breeches came out of an office by the door, with a coffee mug, and asked if she could help me, and I said I was hoping to see Dr. Whitcombe, for a few minutes, about something personal.

“She’s with a horse,” the young woman said. “She’ll be a while. You’re welcome to wait.” She looked at my shoes, which were the wrong shoes. “There’s a bench.”

There was a bench, by the office door, and I sat on it, and waited.

Halfway down the aisle, in a stall with the door open, there was a big brown horse standing very still, with his head low, and a woman crouched at his front feet. She had her back to me. I could see the gray coming into short dark hair, and a flannel shirt with the sleeves rolled to the elbows, and her hands on the horse’s leg, running down it, slowly, from the knee to the hoof, the way you’d run your hands down a banister in the dark, feeling for a splinter. She had a tool beside her on the straw, a big steel thing like a pair of tongs, and every now and then she picked it up and pressed it, very gently, against a part of the horse’s hoof, and watched his face. When he flinched, she said something to him, too low to hear. When he didn’t, she moved the tool a little and tried again.

She didn’t hurry. Not once, the whole time. The horse knew it. You could see him know it. He stood for her like a statue.

I watched her for twenty minutes. I knew already, watching her hands on that horse’s leg, that I was going to get this wrong.



When she came out of the stall, she was wiping her hands on a towel, and she saw me on the bench and came down the aisle, unhurried, and the young woman with the coffee said, “Claire, this lady’s been waiting to see you,” and went back into the office.

“Hi,” Claire Whitcombe said. “What can I do for you?”

She was taller than she’d looked in the video. Her face was her mother’s, from the obituary photograph, the same wide mouth, but not laughing. A plain, tired, intelligent face, that had been up since five and expected to be up

till nine, and wasn't going to waste any of the time in between. She had a smear of something on her cheek. She didn't know it was there.

"My name is Iola Barnett," I said.

I'd thought about that, too, in the car. Whether to give her my name. Whether she'd know it. Six years ago my name had been on the front page of a newspaper above a story about her father's employer, and then on a correction underneath it, and then on a great many angry blogs. People who'd never heard of Carrow House knew my name for about a month. People who had, didn't forget it.

She knew it. I watched it arrive. It didn't arrive in her face. It arrived in her hands, which had been folding the towel, and stopped.

"I know who you are," she said.

"I thought you might."

"What do you want?"

And I could feel it, the way you feel a tide turn under a boat. Everything I'd planned in the car, about being a woman with one question, and being gentle, and going slowly. I could feel her waiting for me to say it, so that she could say no to it and be done. She was already halfway through saying no. She'd been ready for this for six years.

So I said the question. The only one. The one he'd told me to ask, because nobody had ever asked it.

"How long did you wait?"



I'll tell you exactly what happened, because it's the only part I got right.

She didn't say anything. She didn't move. She stood in the barn aisle with the towel in her hands and the country music playing very quietly somewhere behind her, and she looked at me, and the color went out of her face from the top down, slowly, like water going out of a basin. I've seen that happen to people perhaps three times in my life. The last time had been my editor, the morning the correction ran.

The horse in the stall behind her shifted his weight and blew out through his nose, a long, soft, rattling breath, and she turned her head toward the

sound, the way you'd turn toward a child who'd called you, and I saw her see that he was all right. And then she turned back to me, and her face had closed.

"I'd like you to leave," she said.

"Dr. Whitcombe..."

"I don't know what you're talking about." Her voice was very even. "I don't know what you think you know, or who's been telling you things, but I'm working, and I have a mare to see in Hamilton in forty minutes, and I'd like you to leave my barn. Now, please."

"I'm not going to write anything," I said. "I don't write anything anymore. I write about gutters. I just want..."

"Now," she said. "Please."

It was the *please* that did it. It wasn't rude. It was the opposite. It was a woman holding on to the last thing she had, which was her manners, with both hands.

I took a card out of my pocket. A plain one, with my name and my phone number and nothing else. I'd had them made the week before, for this, because my old cards had the paper's name on them. I held it out. She didn't take it. So I put it down on the bench where I'd been sitting, and stood up, and said, "I'm sorry for coming to your work," and meant it, and walked out of the barn into the sun.

She didn't call after me. I didn't look back. I got into the car and sat there, and through the open end of the barn I could see her, still standing in the aisle, exactly where I'd left her, with the towel in her hands. She stood there all the time it took me to start the car and turn it round in the gravel. When I pulled out of the gate, she was still there.



I drove a mile and then pulled into the gravel at the side of the road, under a big oak in a pasture with three horses standing in its shade, and turned the engine off, and got my notebook out of the glove box, and wrote it all down. Every word she'd said. The towel. The *please*. The color going out of her face from the top down. The horse breathing, and her turning to it. I wrote for half an hour,

the way I used to in the car after an interview, before I forgot anything. When I'd finished, I read it back.

She hadn't asked what I meant.

That was the thing I saw, reading it back. I'd come into her barn, a stranger, a woman she knew only from a newspaper six years ago, and asked her how long she'd waited. Not waited for what. Not waited where. And she hadn't asked. She'd said *I don't know what you're talking about*, which is what everybody says. But she hadn't asked me what I was talking about. She hadn't needed to.

And I understood, finally, sitting under the oak, what he'd meant the week before. *Let her have one more week of not knowing anybody's looking. You'll need her to have had it.*

She'd had six years of thinking it was over. Of driving her father to his talks, and putting her hand under his elbow, and parking in loading zones, and not thinking about one Wednesday morning in an alley in Washington more than she could help, at night, every night. And then one more week. One more ordinary week, of horses and mornings and coffee in the office, while a woman she'd never met sat at a kitchen table an hour away, waiting.

I'd taken that week away from her this morning in a barn aisle with five words. And she would know, now, for the rest of her life, the exact difference between the week before and the week after. Every time she heard an engine idle.

He'd wanted her to have it, so that she'd know what she'd lost.

I sat under the oak for a long time after that. The three horses in the pasture came over, slowly, one at a time, and put their heads over the fence by the car, and looked at me through the window, and I looked back at them, and none of us said anything.



Freda was waiting at the kitchen table when I got home, with the laptop shut and her hands flat on it, which meant she'd been waiting a while.

"Well?"

"She asked me to leave."

“Oh.” Freda’s face fell. “That’s... okay. That’s bad.”

“It’s not bad,” I said. I put my bag down. “She didn’t ask what I meant.”

Freda looked at me. I watched her think about it. It took her about four seconds.

“Oh,” she said again, differently.

“Yes.”

“So it’s her.”

“It’s her. She was in the car.” I sat down across from her. “And she’s not going to tell me anything. Not now. Maybe not ever.” I put my notebook on the table between us. “And by tonight, or tomorrow, she’s going to have told her father that I came. And he’s going to call Carrow House, and Carrow House is going to call their lawyers. And in about a week I’m going to get a letter.”

Freda put her hand on top of the notebook.

“Maybe she won’t tell him,” she said.

“Why wouldn’t she?”

“Because she didn’t ask what you meant,” Freda said slowly, working it out as she went. “Because she’s been not telling anybody anything for six years. Not even him, maybe. People who don’t tell anybody anything don’t suddenly start.” She looked at me. “I didn’t tell you about Dad for seven months. And I didn’t tell Dad I hadn’t told you. I just didn’t tell anybody anything, about any of it. It’s easier.” She took her hand off the notebook. “It’s like a habit.”

I looked at my daughter for a long time across the kitchen table.

“We’ll see,” I said. “In a week.”



We saw.

I checked the mail every day that week, and my email every hour, and my phone, which I left switched on, on the kitchen table, face up, all day and all night. I didn’t get a letter from Carrow House’s lawyers. I didn’t get a call. Nobody wrote anything about me on any blog. Nobody came to my door.

Nothing happened at all. And by the end of the week, I’d understood that nothing happening was the loudest thing that had happened to me all summer.

Major André

“She didn’t ask what you meant,” he said.

It was the first thing he said. I’d told him all of it, on the porch, before I’d even said the date into the recorders, standing at the top of the steps with my bag still on my shoulder. The barn, the hoof testers, the towel, the *please*. He’d listened without moving. And then he said that, and I knew he’d seen it before I had, which is to say about a second after I’d said it.

“No.”

“And there’s been no letter.”

“Two days. It’s early.”

“There won’t be one.” He moved the cardigan off my chair for me, though it was eighty-five degrees, and I sat. “She hasn’t told him. She’ll be deciding whether to, for a while. She’ll decide not to. She’ll decide it every night.” He looked out at the field. The hay was all in now, baled and gone, and the field was short and pale and already greening at the roots. “And one night she’ll decide something else. Not because of anything you say. Because you came to her barn and didn’t say anything else.”

“How long?”

“I don’t know. Longer than you’d like.” He smiled. “Say the date, Ms. Barnett. It’s July. That’s when he came back.”

Session thirty-six, Thursday, July first.



Clinton came home in the middle of June, with Charleston in his pocket.

You have to understand what that meant to the city. Charleston was the greatest victory the King's army ever had in that whole war. A rebel army of five thousand men, surrendered, with all its guns and its general, in the biggest city in the South. The bells rang for a day. The Loyalists drank the King's health in every tavern on Queen Street. Rivington printed the surrender terms on the front of the *Gazette* with a border round them like a wedding notice. For the first time since I'd come into the lines, the city felt like a place that thought it might win.

And Major André came home with the General, and the whole secret business of the army came home with him.

I'd seen him twice before, at a distance, as I've told you. Now Robinson took me to him.

He was too busy to see me for a month, with the General home and a war to restart. It was a morning at the end of July before Robinson took me to him, at headquarters on the Broadway, at the bottom of the island, a big house with a garden that went down toward the water. André had an office on the first floor at the back, looking out over the garden, with a long table under the window covered in papers and maps, and a smaller table to one side with a drawing board on it, and a half-finished pencil sketch pinned to the board of a man in a cocked hat asleep in a chair. I recognized the man. It was one of Clinton's aides. It was very good, and very unkind.

André was standing at the window with a letter when we came in. He turned round.

He was beautiful. I don't know how else to put it. Not in a soft way. He was thirty, slim, not tall, with dark hair tied back and very dark, very bright eyes, and a way of standing that made everybody else in a room look as if they'd been put together in a hurry. His coat was the best-cut coat I saw in that whole war. And he smiled the moment he saw Robinson, a real smile, delighted, and came across the room with his hand out, as if Robinson were the one person in New York he'd been hoping would walk through his door that morning.

He made everybody feel like that. I was going to tell you it was a trick. It wasn't. That was the extraordinary thing about him. He meant it every time.

"Colonel," he said. "And this is the famous Freeman."



He knew all about me. Beckwith had written it all down for him, the ice and the deserters and the paper and the road, and he'd read it on the ship coming home, he said, twice, the way he read everything. He'd been in Charleston for six months and come back to find that Beckwith had shut down Washington's best correspondence in his absence, and Beckwith had told him, with the scrupulous honesty that was the best thing about Beckwith, exactly whose idea it had been.

"I don't believe a word of it," André said cheerfully. "So I'm going to test you. You don't mind?"

"No, sir."

He went to the long table and took a paper off it, and held it up in front of my face, about a foot away, for perhaps two seconds, and took it away again.

It was a return. A list of figures. The strength of every British regiment in the southern army, as it had stood at the end of May, regiment by regiment, rank and file, sick and present, with the totals at the bottom.

"Well?" André said.

I gave it to him. All of it. Twenty-three regiments and corps, in the order they were written, with every figure in every column, and the totals. It took me about four minutes. A man who can't read can recognize numbers, Ms. Barnett. Lots of men who couldn't read could count, in those days, and knew their figures off a bill. I'd decided, on the way up the stairs, that numbers were safe.

André listened to the whole thing with the paper in his hand, following it down with his finger. When I'd finished he looked up at Robinson, and then at me, and his eyes were shining.

"That is the most remarkable thing I have ever seen," he said. And then, to Robinson, "He's got the sick wrong in the Seventy-first. Hasn't he? Two

hundred and twelve?”

“Two hundred and twenty-one, sir,” I said. “The clerk’s made his ones like sevens.”

André looked at the paper. He laughed out loud.

“So he has,” he said. “So he has.”



That would have been the end of it, if it had been anybody else. It was the end of it for Robinson. He went off to see Clinton about something, and left me there, to be told what André wanted done with me.

André wasn’t finished.

He was a man who couldn’t leave a puzzle alone. It was the thing that made him so good at what he did, and in the end it was the thing that killed him, though neither of us knew that yet. He walked round his drawing table a couple of times with his hands behind his back, looking at the floor. Then he went to a little writing desk in the corner, and picked up a sheet of paper that was covered in his own handwriting, crossed out and written over and crossed out again, and came back and held it up in front of me, the same way, a foot from my face, for two seconds.

And I read it. Of course I read it. I couldn’t not. That’s what reading is, once you can do it; you can’t look at words and not read them, any more than you can hear your own name and not turn round.

It was a poem. Verses, rhymed, very bad on purpose, about a rebel general called Wayne who’d attacked a Loyalist blockhouse on the Jersey shore a few days before and been beaten off, and had consoled himself by stealing the local farmers’ cattle. André was writing a mock epic about it, for Rivington to print. It was called *The Cow-Chace*. It was rather funny.

He took it away.

“What’s the fourth line?” he said, quite gently.

I didn’t answer for a long moment. And then I made the only mistake I made with him in all those months.

“*And all the cows in Jersey*,” I said.

And then I heard myself, and stopped.



He didn't say anything at all for a while. He stood there with the poem in his hand and looked at me, and I looked at the floor, and I thought about the man outside the tavern on Queen Street, the free man born on Long Island, who'd come out of the Provost after six weeks with his papers gone. I thought that I'd spent a year in that city and been careful every single day, every hour, and that it had taken a man who couldn't leave a puzzle alone about two minutes.

Then André went and shut his office door. Quietly. And came back. And sat down on the edge of his long table, so that his face was lower than mine, which I don't think any white man had done in that body's whole life.

"Where did you learn?" he said.

"I don't know, sir."

He smiled. "That's not true. But I can see why you'd say it." He turned the poem over in his hands. "Does Robinson know?"

"I think he wonders, sir. I've never told him."

"And Beckwith?"

"No, sir."

"Good." He put the poem down on the table beside him. "Then we shan't tell either of them. They're both very fine officers, and neither of them could keep that sort of thing to himself for a week if his life depended on it. Robinson would tell his wife, and Beckwith would put it in a report." He looked at me. "And then it would go round the town, and some Loyalist with a grudge would decide that a reading Black man was a forger, and you'd be in the Provost, and I'd have to waste a great deal of my time getting you out. And I'm very busy." He paused. "So you'll go on not being able to read. And I'll go on not having noticed. And you'll be a great deal more use to me than either of them knows. Is that agreeable?"

"Yes, sir."

"Then we shall both have a secret, Freeman." He stood up, and picked up the poem, and looked at it, and made a face. "Was the fourth line any good?"

"No, sir," I said. "It was very bad."

He laughed so hard he had to sit down again.



He stopped. He was smiling, out at the field, the way you smile at something nobody else can see.

“That was the once,” I said. “You told me someone found out. Once.”

“That was the once.” He turned the smile on me. “Nobody else, in that body. Not ever. He kept it to the end.” He was quiet for a moment. “You’ll want to know whether I liked him. I liked him more than anybody I met in that war. More than Prince, and I loved Prince. André was the only man in the British army who ever looked at me as if I might be interesting. Not useful. Interesting. And I’ve thought, since, that that’s a very dangerous thing for a man in my position to be grateful for, and that I was grateful for it anyway, with my whole heart, and that he knew it, and used it.” He picked up his glass. “Both of those are true. You don’t get to pick.”



● RECORDING · AUGUST 1780

He used me, that summer, for the thing he cared about most. And I didn’t know what it was for nearly two months.

He never told me. That was the rule of his correspondence, which he’d written down himself in a letter long before, though I didn’t see that letter till much later: every messenger was to remain ignorant of what he carried. There was a man, on the other side, an American general, writing to André in secret. That was all I knew, that summer. Letters came in from him, by roundabout roads: under flags of truce with other business, with ladies’ letters about bonnets and gloves, with exchanged prisoners coming back. The letters were in a cipher made of numbers, three numbers to a word. Page, line, word, out of some big book. I glimpsed one, once, on André’s table, and kept it, and could have read it in a moment if I’d had the book. I didn’t have the book. I didn’t try to find it. I knew better.

What I did was the thing I was good at. I watched the roads the letters came by, and the men who touched them, and made sure nothing leaked.

Something did, once, in August. A clerk in the Adjutant General's office, a young Loyalist from Philadelphia with debts, who copied the outsides of letters, the covers and the seals and the names they were addressed to, and sold the copies to a man from Jersey who came into town on market days. He didn't know what was in them. He didn't need to. Somebody on the other side, putting those covers together, week by week, would have seen a pattern in where they went, and who they went to, and when.

I saw him do it. I saw him slip a folded paper to the man from Jersey at the Fly Market, between two baskets of peaches, one hot Saturday. I told André. André thanked me, and said nothing more about it. And the next week the clerk was posted to a regiment in Halifax, Nova Scotia, with a good character and no explanation, and the man from Jersey stopped coming to market.

Nobody was hanged for it. André wasn't a man for hanging people if he could help it. He said once, in my hearing, that a hanged spy was a wasted opportunity, and that he'd much rather have a frightened one. Beckwith had told him what I'd said, I suppose, about frightening Setauket. He'd liked it.



"The general," I said. "The American general writing to André."

"Yes."

"Arnold."

He looked at me for a long moment.

"You looked it up," he said.

"Everybody knows it. It's the one thing everybody knows about that whole war. Benedict Arnold."

"Everybody knows it now." He set his glass down. "That summer, in all New York, I'd guess a dozen people knew it. Clinton. André. Beckwith. Robinson. A clergyman called Odell, who decoded for them. Perhaps the General's secretary. I wasn't one of them. I carried his letters for two months

and didn't know whose they were. I found out in the worst way it's possible to find anything out. You'll hear it. Not today."

"Did you like him? Arnold?"

"I never met him," he said. "Not until the end. And then I didn't." He looked out at the pale field, at the line of trees beyond it, blue in the heat. "But I knew what he was doing. Even before I knew who he was. A man selling his own people for money. I knew exactly what that was." He looked back at me. "I'd been sold, Ms. Barnett. In that body. Reynolds bought Caesar for forty pounds from a man in White Plains when he was nineteen. It's in Reynolds's account book, under the cow."

He picked up his glass again, and found it empty, and set it down.

"I worked very hard for André that summer," he said. "I'd do it again. But I never once, in all of it, stopped knowing what the letters were for."

Newport

“I’ve told you some of this a little out of order,” he said, after lunch. “I’m going to go back two weeks. To the middle of July. Before André and I had our secret. Because something happened in those two weeks that I didn’t see at the time, and I want you to see it the way I didn’t.”

He’d made sandwiches, tomato and mayonnaise on the bakery bread, with the first tomatoes from the plant by the back step, and salt and pepper, nothing else. We ate them on the porch, in the shade at the north end, with the plates on our knees. It was too hot to eat anything else. It was too hot, really, to eat that.

“Lose a round,” he said. “That’s what this one is. I want you to have one of those too. It’s only fair.”



• RECORDING · JULY 1780

The French came on the tenth of July.

Everybody had known they were coming. The King of France had joined the rebels’ war two years before, and sent a fleet once already that had done nothing much, and now he was sending an army: five or six thousand soldiers, real ones, regulars, in white coats, with a squadron of warships to carry them. They came into the harbor of Newport, in Rhode Island, on the tenth and eleventh of July, and landed, and started to dig.

Clinton had known they were coming too. He’d planned for it. If he could get his own army up the Sound to Rhode Island fast enough, before the French were dug in, he could fall on them while they were still unloading

their tents, and that would very likely be the end of the French army in America before it had fired a shot. He needed two things. He needed the navy, to carry his men and to beat the French squadron. And he needed the French not to know he was coming.

He didn't get either. But it was a near thing on the second. That's my part.



The news that the French had landed came to the city on the eighteenth, by a courier from the far end of Long Island. And that same night the whole army began to move.

I'd never seen anything like it, in that war. Six thousand men, perhaps more, marching out of their camps and quarters on the island and the Jersey shore and the city itself, all heading east, for the narrows at the top of the East River where the Sound begins, at Whitestone and Throg's Neck, where the transports were coming round to meet them. All the roads full. Every wagon in the city commandeered, every horse. Officers shouting at each other in the dark. And every guide the Quartermaster had on his books called in, to take the columns along the roads that were too small for them.

I was one. I spent four days and three nights on horseback, going back and forth along the north shore of the island, between the camps and the landing places, with columns of men behind me. I didn't sleep. Nobody slept. And I didn't go near the ferry once in all that time, or the city, or the shops, or Setauket road. There wasn't a minute for it.

I've thought since that if anybody on the other side had wanted the best possible week to send a letter out of New York, they couldn't have chosen better. Every eye in the British army was looking at the Sound. Including mine.



On the morning of the twentieth, very early, before it was light, I was sent back into the city with a message for the Quartermaster, and I came down

Queen Street to the river just as the sun came up, because it was the quickest way, and I passed the top of the ferry stairs.

The widow was there with her cart. Her eggs were on top, in their two rows on the white cloth, and I saw them as I went by, because I saw everything. Eleven. A gap in the front row, where the sixth should have been. I noticed it without noticing it, as I'd noticed it before. I didn't stop. I was on a horse, with a message.

And at the bottom of the stairs the first boat of the morning was pushing off for Brooklyn, with half a dozen people in it, and one of them was the carter.

I knew his back. I'd have known it anywhere. Broad, in a brown coat, sitting very upright on the thwart. But there was something wrong about him, and I'd ridden fifty yards on along the waterfront before I knew what it was.

He didn't have his wagon. He didn't have his good gray horse. He was going over to Long Island in the first boat of the morning with nothing in his hands at all, sitting upright on the thwart like a man in church, and his face, when he turned it to look back at the city, was gray.

A carter without a cart. Going home in a hurry, at dawn, with his whole army on the move round him, empty-handed.

I knew what it meant. I knew it in my stomach, on that horse, on the waterfront, with the sun coming up over Brooklyn. And I had a message to deliver to the Quartermaster, who would have had me flogged if I'd been an hour late with it, and a column waiting for me at Flushing by noon, and no officer anywhere near me who'd have listened to a guide on a horse telling him that a carter had gone home without his cart.

So I delivered the message. And I rode back out to Flushing, and took my column to Whitestone. And I told myself I'd find Beckwith that night and tell him.



I found him the next night. Not that night. There wasn't a minute for it, that night either.

I told him about the carter. He listened, in a tent on the shore at Whitestone, with a candle and a hundred papers and men coming in and out every minute. Then he said what I'd known he'd say.

"Then Washington knows. Or will, in two or three days." He rubbed his eyes. "It doesn't signify now. We're past being secret. You can't move six thousand men without every farmer on Long Island knowing it, and every farmer on Long Island has a cousin in Connecticut." He looked at me. "You couldn't have stopped him. You know that."

"I could have stopped him at the ferry," I said. "If I'd been at the ferry."

"And had him searched, and found nothing, and let him go," Beckwith said. "Because there'd have been nothing on him. Would there?"

I thought about it. I thought about him sitting on the thwart with empty hands.

"No, sir," I said. "Nothing on him. It was all in his head. He was going to ride fifty-five miles and say it out loud to somebody."

"Then there's your answer." Beckwith went back to his papers. "Get some sleep, Freeman. We start embarking in a day or two, and I'll want you awake."



Here is what had happened. I learned it a long time afterward, reading their letters, in that library, in the reading room with the green lamps.

Washington had dropped the man in the city in May, as I've told you. On the eleventh of July, the day after the French landed, he'd written to Tallmadge to start him up again, at once, at any price, because he needed to know what Clinton was going to do. Tallmadge got the letter three days later and went to the Connecticut shore. The boat went over to Setauket. The man in Setauket was sick in bed with a fever. So he sent the carter to the city.

And the man in the city was frightened, still. I'd seen to that. But he wasn't too frightened to do it once more, for this. He wrote a letter on the nineteenth or twentieth, in the stain, on a sheet with an ordinary letter on the other side of it, to a well-known Loyalist colonel on Long Island, about some goods the colonel had ordered, so that if the carter was stopped and searched, it would look like the most loyal letter in the world. So I'd been wrong, in

Beckwith's tent. There was something on him after all. And then I think he told the carter the rest, out loud, in case the letter was lost. And the carter rode it fifty-five miles in a day. He was back in Setauket on the evening of the twentieth, the man in Setauket wrote, *in great haste*.

The man in Setauket got up out of his sickbed and wrote a covering note and sent it down to the boat with a message I've never forgotten, because it's the most frightened, most urgent thing I've ever read in that whole correspondence. *Let not an hour pass*, he wrote. *For this day must not be lost. You have news of the greatest consequence perhaps that ever happened to your country.*

Eight thousand troops, he said, embarking at Whitestone, for Rhode Island. The fleet sailed. The French had only seven ships of the line.

Two days later it was in Tallmadge's hands, and the day after that in Washington's.



He stopped and ate the last corner of his sandwich, slowly.

"So they won," I said.

"They won the round." He wiped his fingers on the napkin. "But I want to be honest with you about what the round was worth, because a great many people since have made it worth a great deal more. They say the man in the city saved the French army. He didn't. Their letter wasn't the first warning. It wasn't even the second. A colonel in a sloop got to Newport half a day ahead of it, with the same news from somebody else. A man in Jersey had told Washington's own aide the day before. That's how it is, in a war. The truth comes in by six doors at once, and afterward everybody claims they opened the one it came through."

"Then why did Clinton turn back? I read that he turned back."

"He did. Ten days later. From Huntington Bay, halfway up the Island, with seventy transports full of men." He folded the napkin in half. "Because the navy wouldn't move fast enough, and the admiral and the general hated each other and wouldn't talk, and by the time they'd stopped hating each other long enough to sail, the French had dug in so deep it'd have been murder to go at

them. And because Washington, who's the cleverest of them all, marched his whole army down to the Hudson as if he were going to attack New York while Clinton was away. So Clinton came home. That's all." He looked at me. "The man in the city did a brave thing, and got his news through, and it changed nothing at all. Neither did my failing to stop him. Neither of us decided it, that time. The weather mattered, and two old men who couldn't stand each other."

"So why tell me?"

He was quiet.

"Because I had it in front of me," he said, "and I didn't see it. The carter on the thwart, with no cart. I saw that. I knew what it meant. But I didn't see the rest of what was in front of me that morning, and I've had every year since to wish I had." He folded the napkin again, smaller. "It was in front of me the whole time, Ms. Barnett. All year. I just didn't look at it, because it was the kind of thing nobody looks at."



I looked down at my notebook.

I'd written it while he talked, without thinking, the way you write a phone number somebody's reading out to you. *July 20. Widow at top of ferry stairs. Eleven.* And I'd drawn a circle round the eleven, and I didn't remember doing that either.

I looked up. He was watching me.

"Eleven," I said.

"Yes."

"January, eleven. March, eleven. May, twelve, every day. The twentieth of July, the day the carter goes home without his cart, eleven." I looked at the circle. "You said keep writing them down. You said you'd say nothing else."

"I did say that."

"Are you going to say anything else?"

"No," he said, and smiled, and picked up both our plates, and stood up with his hand on the rail. "Not yet. It's July. I didn't see it until December." He

looked down at me. “You’ve seen it in July. You’re quicker than I was, Ms. Barnett. I’d like you to remember that, when you’re feeling slow.”

And he went in with the plates, and I sat alone on the north end of the porch, in the heat, with the circle on the page, and the field going pale gold in the afternoon light, and in my head, very clearly, a woman at the top of a flight of stone stairs above a river, at sunrise, setting out her eggs in two rows on a white cloth, counting.

Glover and Hoyt

Nine days, and nothing from Purcellville.

I'd stopped checking the mail every hour. I checked it every three. I'd stopped leaving my phone face up on the kitchen table all night and started leaving it face down, which Freda said was worse, because it meant I was pretending. She was right. She was right about most things that summer, and insufferable about all of them, and I'd never liked her more.

On the Thursday he was waiting for me at the bottom of the porch steps, which he hadn't done since the spring, standing in the shade of the maple by the gravel with his hands in his pockets.

"I wanted to see the car come up the road," he said, when I asked. "It's a good thing to see, a car coming up a road. You'll understand later." He turned and went up the steps, slowly, one hand on the rail. "Nothing from her?"

"Nothing."

"Good."

I said the date, *session thirty-seven, Thursday, July eighth*, and he settled himself on the bench in the shade with the cardigan beside him and his glass of water on the little table, and looked out at the field.

"August," he said. "The ring was back. And this time I knew where the boat came in."



They'd started again in the middle of August. I knew it before anybody else at headquarters did, because the carter had a parcel the shape of a quire again, under his sugar, for the first time since April. He'd been over the ferry and back, and I'd watched him go through Hill's table at the Brooklyn landing, and seen the parcel, and seen Hill's men riffle it and hand it back.

I didn't stroke his horse that time. I let him go. I'd frightened that road once, and it had worked, and now it was open again, because Washington needed it more than they were frightened. You can't frighten people twice the same way. The second time, they're ready for it. So I didn't try to close the road again. I went to the other end of it.

The boat.



I've told you about Brewster. The rebels' whaleboat officer, born in Setauket, who came over the Sound from Connecticut in the dark with armed crews to raid the Loyalist farms on the north shore. Everybody knew Brewster. He didn't hide. He used his own name, and he fought, and he took Loyalist boats in the Sound and Loyalist cattle off the shore, and the Loyalists on the Island hated him the way you hate weather.

What nobody at headquarters had worked out was that Brewster wasn't only raiding. He was collecting the mail.

I'd worked it out in the spring, with my finger on Beckwith's map, as I told you. The carter went to Setauket. Somebody in Setauket put it in a boat. There was only one rebel boat that came over to Setauket regularly, and everybody knew its captain's name. So it was Brewster. It had to be. And if it was Brewster, then on the nights the letters went across, Brewster had to come over to the Island and wait. Not raid. Wait. In a cove somewhere near Setauket, in the dark, with his boat drawn up in the reeds, for somebody to come down to the shore with a packet.

A raider moves. A man waiting for a letter has to sit still.



There were Loyalist boatmen on the Island too, of course. Refugees, mostly, men who'd been run out of Connecticut by the rebels, who'd armed boats of their own and fought Brewster's men up and down the Sound for years, a little private war on the water, raid for raid, boat for boat. The two best of them were called Glover and Hoyt. They worked out of Lloyd's Neck, a big hook of land on the north shore with a Loyalist fort on it, halfway between the city and Setauket.

I went to see them at the beginning of August, with a pass from Beckwith, on a borrowed horse.

They were not men who expected to take advice from anybody, and certainly not from a Black man on a borrowed horse with a paper they couldn't read very well. Glover was small and dark and quick, Hoyt was big and slow and red, and they both looked at me the way Captain Rudd had looked at me in the redoubt on Staten Island. But they listened. They listened because I didn't tell them anything about spies, or letters, or Washington. I told them about Brewster.

"He waits," I said. "Near Setauket. Not every week. Every two or three weeks. He comes over on a dark night and lies up in a cove all next day and goes back the night after, without raiding anything. Have you never wondered what he's doing?"

Hoyt said he'd supposed Brewster was visiting his mother.

"He's waiting for something to be brought down to him," I said. "And while he's waiting, he can't move. He's got to stay where he said he'd be. He's got to be there when they come. That's the only time Brewster's ever in one place for twenty-four hours, with his boat drawn up on the shore and his men asleep in the grass."

Glover was looking at me differently by then.

"Which cove?" he said.

"I don't know. One of the ones east of the harbor. Behind the Strong farm, perhaps, on the Neck. There's good cover there." I'd never been there. I'd only listened to a hundred carters and boatmen and farmers at the ferry talk about that shore, for a year, and kept all of it. "And I don't know which night. But it'll be a dark one, near the new moon, when the carter's just come

back from the city with a parcel. Watch the carter. When the carter's been to the city, watch the coves."



They watched.

It took them two weeks. And on the seventeenth or eighteenth of August, I don't know the exact night, I wasn't there, they found Brewster lying up near Setauket with his boat, waiting, exactly as I'd said. Waiting for dispatches from the man in the city that hadn't come down to the shore yet.

They went at him in the dark. It was a hard little fight, in the reeds and the shallows, the way all those fights on the Sound were. Brewster lost one man taken and one wounded. His men killed one of Glover's on the spot. And Brewster got back into his boat and got away across the Sound to Connecticut in the night, the way he always did, with half his crew and none of his letters.

The letters stayed on the Island. The man in the city's dispatches, the first he'd written since he'd started again, were sitting in Setauket waiting for a boat that had just been driven off. Tallmadge wrote to Washington a couple of days later, I read it afterward, that his boatman had been *drove from Long Island so suddenly* that the dispatches had been left behind. Brewster wrote, in his own letter, which was a very angry letter, that Glover and Hoyt *never stayed to bury their dead man*.

That's true. They didn't. I didn't, either.



He stopped. The bees were in the clover at the edge of the porch again. Somewhere down the road a dog was barking at nothing, on and off, the way they do in the heat.

"A man died," I said.

"A man died. One of ours. One of Glover's crew, a boatman from Stamford whose name I never knew." He was quiet. "I'd told them where to go and when. I hadn't told them to fight. But you don't send armed men at Caleb

Brewster in the dark and expect a conversation.” He looked at his water glass. “I said I’d tell you my part exactly, no more and no less. That’s my part. A man I never met died in a creek on Long Island because I’d worked out that a raider who’s waiting for a letter has to sit still.”

“And the letters got through anyway.”

“They got through anyway. A week late.” He smiled a little, without much in it. “Brewster came back over at the end of the month and lay up behind the Strong farm again, the same cove, because he was a stubborn man and it was a good cove, and a lieutenant of dragoons went out on foot looking for the Strong family’s hounds and walked within gunshot of him. Brewster wrote that the lieutenant *begged so hard* not to be taken, when they jumped him, that he let him go, because he was too near the house.” He shook his head. “That’s the Sound, in that war. Everybody knew everybody. Half the time they let each other go.”

“So you lost that round too.”

“No,” he said. “No, that one I won. A week is a long time, in a war. A week late is a week in which Washington didn’t know something. And it was the first letter he’d written them in three months, and the boat that should have carried it had been shot up in the night by men who knew where it would be.” He looked at me. “They knew, after that, that somebody knew. It wasn’t a road anymore. It was a road with somebody standing on it. You can feel the difference, from inside. I’ve been on both sides of it.”



• RECORDING · AUGUST 1780

The last week of August I was out in Westchester again, with a troop of DeLancey’s refugee horse, the Westchester men, hunting the rebels’ dispatch riders.

Washington’s army was up the Hudson by then, around the forts in the Highlands, and his letters to his officers in Connecticut went across the Neutral Ground by express, a dragoon on a good horse, riding hard, alone or in pairs. There was a bridge over the Croton River called Pine’s Bridge that

every one of them used, because it was the only good crossing for miles and the fords were deep in summer. I'd known it since I was Caesar's age, which is to say since before I was in him. The body knew the bridge. It had driven cattle over it.

We lay up in the woods above Pine's Bridge for two days. On the second evening, a rebel dragoon came down the road from the north, alone, on a tired horse, with a leather satchel on his back. DeLancey's men took him on the bridge without a shot. He'd been riding since dawn. He looked very young, and very tired, and he didn't even try to run.

We brought him into New York with his satchel. I never saw what was in it. Letters to and from officers in Connecticut about horses and forage and pay. Nothing very much, Beckwith said afterward. But nothing very much is still something, if it's the enemy's, and it was in our hands and not theirs.

I remember the bridge, Ms. Barnett. That's why I'm telling you. Pine's Bridge. Rough planks, on stone piers, over brown water, with the road going up through the trees on the far side toward Tarrytown. I lay above it for two days and learned every board of it, without trying, because that's what Caesar's eyes did.

A month later, almost to the day, a gentleman in a civilian coat would cross that bridge on a borrowed horse, heading south for the British lines, and I would be on the wrong road.

But not yet.



• RECORDING · SEPTEMBER 1780

On the twelfth of September André sent me to Oyster Bay with a letter.

It was the first time he'd ever sent me with one of his own. Sealed, with his own seal, which was a little classical head, very fine. To Colonel Simcoe, whose Rangers were in quarters at Oyster Bay again, on the north shore, in the house of a merchant family called Townsend.

I took the letter out by the ferry and along the north shore road on a good horse of André's, and gave it to Simcoe in the front parlor of the Townsend

house, a plain wooden house with a big tree in front and a hall that smelled of beeswax. Simcoe was a tall, cold, clever man with a long face, and his Rangers were the best soldiers the King had in that whole country, and the most feared. He broke the seal standing up, and read it at the window, and then he laughed, a short laugh, not unkind, and read a line of it aloud, to himself, in a tone of great amusement.

“Apparent arrangements,” he said, *“are not always real ones.”* He folded the letter and put it in his coat. “Tell the Major I understand him perfectly. And tell him my men are ready.”

I didn’t know what it meant. I didn’t know what his men were ready for. Every messenger was to remain ignorant. I rode back to the city with the answer and gave it to André word for word, as I gave everything, and André smiled and said, “Good,” and went back to his papers.

I stood in the front hall of that house, Ms. Barnett, with my hat in my hands, while Simcoe read his letter. And while I stood there, one of the sons of the house came down the stairs. Home from the city for a day or two, a servant said afterward. A pale young man a few years younger than me, with a long nose and a careful mouth, in a good plain coat. He stood aside on the bottom step to let a Ranger officer go by, and glanced at me, the way a man glances at another man’s servant, and went out by the back. I looked at him for perhaps three seconds. I have him still, every line.

It was another hundred and fifty years before anybody in the world knew who he was. I’d stood in his own father’s hall, with André’s letter in my hand, and watched him go by, and thought of nothing at all.



“Who was he?” I said.

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he picked up his glass and drank the rest of the water in it.

“Look it up,” he said. “Oyster Bay. Townsend. You’re quicker than I was.” He set the glass down. “That’s the end of August, Ms. Barnett. Next week is September. I’d like you to bring Freda, if she’ll come.” He looked out at the pale

field, and the heat lying on it, and the line of trees. “I don’t think I want to tell September twice.”

I looked it up that night, at the kitchen table. It took me about four minutes.

Robert Townsend. Of Oyster Bay. Merchant. Proven in 1930, by a historian with a handwriting expert, to have been the man in the city. The man who wrote the letters. The one who stopped writing in April, and started again in July, and whose dispatches were left sitting on the shore in August when Brewster’s boat was driven off.

I sat and looked at the screen for a long time. Then I wrote in my notebook, under the date: *Tom stood in his father’s hall. 1780. Watched him go by for three seconds.* And then, because I couldn’t help it: *Didn’t know.*

And then, because I really couldn’t help it: *Neither did anyone. For 150 years.*

What Ice Does to Sound

Freda came.

I'd asked her on the Thursday night, at the kitchen table, carefully, the way you ask a sixteen-year-old anything in July. He'd asked for her, I said. He'd said he didn't want to tell September twice. She'd looked at me over her laptop for a long moment, and then said, "Is it the bad part?" and I'd said I thought it was, and she'd said, "Okay," and gone back to typing, and then stopped typing and said, "Should I bring something? Like, a thing?"

She brought a pie. She made it herself, on the Wednesday night, peach, from a recipe of her father's mother's that Dez had texted her, and it came out of the oven at eleven o'clock looking like something from a magazine, and she stood over it with her hands on her hips and said, "That's going to be a disaster," and covered it with a dish towel and wouldn't let me look at it again.

She sat in the front seat with it on her knees the whole way up. Two hours. She didn't put her headphones on once. When we turned onto the gravel road, she sat up and looked at everything: the long field, mowed short and pale, and the line of trees, and the little house at the end with the porch and the maple, and him at the bottom of the steps, under the maple, with his hands in his pockets, watching the car come up the road.

"He's waiting for us," Freda said.

"He's been doing that."

"Since when?"

"Since last week."

She was quiet. Then she said, very quietly, “That’s nice,” in a voice I hadn’t heard her use since she was about nine.



He was delighted with the pie. Not polite. Delighted. He lifted the dish towel and looked at it for a long time, and then at Freda, and then he said, “Peach,” as if she’d brought him something he’d been trying to remember the name of for a hundred years. He made her tell him the recipe, all of it, standing in his kitchen, and asked whose it was, and when she said her grandmother’s, her dad’s mom’s, he said, “Then it’ll be good,” and she went pink to the ears.

We had it for breakfast. He said that was allowed, in July, and that he had it on good authority. He made coffee, and put the pie on the kitchen table with three plates and three forks and a knife, and let Freda cut it, and it was not a disaster. It was the best pie I’ve ever eaten. I’ve told her so since, and she says I’m just saying it, and I’m not.

I said the date into the recorders with my mouth full. *Session thirty-eight. Thursday, July fifteenth. Freda’s here.*

“Freda’s here,” he said, and lifted his coffee to her.



I told him about the silence while we ate. Two weeks, now. No letter from Carrow House. No call from their lawyers. No call from Claire Whitcombe. Nothing.

“I think she’s protecting herself,” I said. “I think she’s decided the safest thing is to do nothing. If she tells her father I came, he’ll panic, and call the lawyers, and then there’ll be lawyers, and then there’ll be questions, and somebody might ask her where she was on a Wednesday morning six years ago. So she says nothing. And if she says nothing to him, she’ll certainly say nothing to me.” I put my fork down. “I think it’s over. I think she’s just going to wait me out.”

He finished his piece of pie first. He took his time.

“Freda,” he said. “Did your mother ever tell you about the ice?”

Freda looked up, surprised. "The ice in the harbor? I typed it. When it froze. When you lay on the blanket and listened to the sleighs."

"What did I say about it?"

She thought. She'd typed every word of it. I watched her find it.

"You said sound carries. On the ice. When it's still and cold. You could hear a dog bark in New Jersey."

"I did. And what's the other half of it?"

She didn't know. Neither did I. He waited, and when neither of us said anything, he turned his cup a quarter turn on the table.

"When an army's coming," he said, "the dogs stop barking. On a still night on the ice you can hear every dog on the Jersey shore, every night, all night, barking at the cold and the dark and each other. And one night, they stop. A whole village of dogs, gone quiet. And it's the loudest thing you've ever heard. Because a dog stops barking for one reason. Somebody it knows has come into the yard, and told it to be still."

Freda had stopped eating.

"Your mother's right," he said to her, "that the dog's gone quiet. She's wrong about why." He looked at me. "If Claire Whitcombe were protecting herself, she'd have told her father the same night. That's what you do, if it's yourself you're afraid for. You call the strongest person you know and say, *somebody came*. You get your lawyers ready. You get ahead of it. Every frightened person in the world does that."

"She didn't," I said slowly.

"She didn't. She's kept quiet two weeks. She's kept it from the strongest person she knows, who's also the person who'd most want to know." He set his cup down. "People don't keep quiet like that for themselves, Ms. Barnett. They keep quiet like that for somebody else. Somebody who'd be in danger if her father panicked, and started making telephone calls. Somebody the telephone calls might reach."



Nobody said anything for a while. Outside, the bees were working in the clover. In the field a hawk was hanging over the short grass, quite still, with its wings

moving very slightly, the way they do when they're watching something.

"Who?" Freda said at last. She said it to him, not to me.

He didn't answer. He looked at me. He was waiting for me to say it, the way he'd waited in the spring for me to find the eggs, and the way he'd waited on the first day, last October, for me to decide whether he was mad.

I didn't want to say it. I'd stopped letting myself think it, years ago. You do, after a while. You put a thing down so you can carry everything else.

"Somebody they're hiding," I said.

"Yes."

"Somebody who'd be in danger if Carrow House's lawyers started asking where they'd gone. Somebody who's been somewhere, all this time, that only the Whitcombes know about." I could hear my voice going thin. "You think he's alive."

"I think," he said carefully, "that a woman sat in an alley for twenty-seven minutes with the engine running, while her father and another man carried two boxes and a computer down a flight of stairs. And that the other man was the one whose cat was shut in the bedroom. And that she drove them both away. And that six years later, when a stranger came to her barn and asked how long she'd waited, she went white, and asked her to leave, and then told nobody, not even her father. Not for her own sake." He paused. "I think you should let yourself think it, Ms. Barnett. I think you've earned that much. I don't know any more than you do. But I've been on the ice. I know what it means when the dogs go quiet."



Freda reached across the table and put her hand on top of mine. She didn't say anything. She didn't need to. She'd been ten, the summer it happened. She'd sat on the stairs at night, the week after, and listened to me crying in the kitchen and pretending to be on the phone. We'd never once talked about it.

"So what do I do?" I said.

"Nothing," he said. "Nothing at all. You've done the one thing. She knows you know. She knows you came yourself, with nothing in your hands, and asked her one question, and went away when she asked you to. She knows you

haven't told her father, or the lawyers, or the newspaper, because if you had, she'd have heard about it by now." He picked up the knife and cut himself a second, very small piece of pie. "You've left her a card on a bench. That's the most frightening thing you can give a person who's been keeping a secret for six years. A way out that they have to choose for themselves."

"How long?" I said. "You said longer than I'd like."

He thought about it.

"If I'm right about why she's quiet," he said, "she's asking him. Whoever it is. She's driven out to wherever it is and sat with him and told him a woman came to the barn, and he's had to decide what he wants. And he's had six years of wanting not to be found." He ate the piece of pie. "But he chose you, once. Out of every reporter in the city. He picked up a telephone and called a newsroom and asked for you by name. A man doesn't forget why he did that."



Then he got up, and took the plates to the sink, and stood there for a moment with his back to us and his hands on the edge of the counter, looking out of the window at the hawk over the field.

"Freda," he said, without turning round. "Have you typed all of it? The whole year so far?"

"Everything," Freda said. "Up to last week. The boat and the hounds and the man coming down the stairs."

"Then you'll have noticed the eggs."

I looked at Freda. She looked at me. Then she looked at the back of his head, and said, with great dignity, "I'm not stupid."

He laughed. He turned round, still laughing, with his hand on the counter.

"No," he said. "No, you are very much not. Don't tell me what you think. I don't want to hear it. Not yet. I want you to hear the next part the way I lived it." He came back to the table and sat down, and folded his hands on it, and the laughing went out of his face, slowly, the way the light goes off a field when a cloud comes over. "Because I didn't know, then, about the eggs. I didn't know anything. I knew a young man in a beautiful coat had trusted me with a secret,

and that I'd have done anything for him. And that's what I want you to have, both of you, for the next part. Just that."

He looked at the recorders, and at me, and nodded.

"September," he said.

The Vulture

• RECORDING · SEPTEMBER 1780

I worked out whose letters they were on the seventeenth of September, from a piece of paper about a house.

André hadn't told me. He'd kept his own rule to the end: every messenger ignorant. But that summer I'd carried a great many of his papers, and stood by a great many of his tables, and I couldn't help what I saw, any more than I could help breathing. And on the sixteenth Colonel Robinson went up the Hudson on a sloop of war called the *Vulture*, with a letter in his pocket under a flag of truce, to an American general. About his house.

I've told you about Robinson's house. The fine house in the Highlands, up the river, that he'd lived in like a duke before the war, among his tenants. The rebels had taken it when he wouldn't swear to them. And now an American general was living in it, because it stood right across the river from the great fortress at West Point, and the general had made it his headquarters when he took command of the fort in August.

Robinson's letter asked that general, very politely, for a meeting under a flag, to discuss his confiscated property.

Robinson didn't care about his property that week. I knew Robinson. I'd watched him for a year. He'd been nervous for days, in the way a careful man is nervous when he's doing something he's not built for. He'd been going in and out of André's office with the door shut. He'd stopped talking to me about the country. And now he was going up the river, in person, at his age, to talk about a house he'd been trying to get back for four years through

lawyers, to the one man in America who happened to be living in it, and who happened to command West Point.

I knew whose letters they were. I knew what was being sold. And I knew, from the way André had been all that month, that it was nearly done.

General Benedict Arnold. Gustavus. Mr. Moore. He'd been writing to André for more than a year, and André was going up the river to buy West Point from him, and the war was nearly over.



I went to André that night.

I shouldn't have. It wasn't my place. A guide doesn't knock on the Adjutant General's door at ten at night. But we had our secret, the two of us, and I think he'd have been more surprised if I hadn't come.

He was at his long table under the window, alone, with one candle and a great many papers, and he looked up when I came in and didn't seem surprised at all. He looked tired. It was the only time I ever saw him tired. He was writing the last canto of his poem about Wayne and the cows, of all things, for Rivington to print, and there was a pile of crossed-out verses at his elbow.

"Freeman," he said. "You've guessed."

"Yes, sir."

"I thought you might. I told the General you would." He put the pen down. "Sit down. No, sit. Nobody's going to come in."

I sat. In the other chair, across the table from him, in the Adjutant General's office at headquarters, at ten at night. I don't think I've told you how strange that was. In that body, in that city, in that whole year, it was the only chair anybody ever offered me.

"You want to tell me something," he said.



I told him what I knew about the Neutral Ground.

He knew some of it. Everybody at headquarters knew some of it. But he'd never been there, not the way I had, on foot, at night, on the roads. He'd ridden through it with escorts of dragoons. He'd never been alone in it, and I had, and I tried to tell him what that meant.

"There are men on every road between the river and the Sound, sir," I said. "Ours and theirs and nobody's. DeLancey's Cowboys on the south side. The rebel militia on the north. And bands of men who belong to neither, who'll stop anybody on a horse with a good coat and take the coat and the horse and whatever's in his pockets, and if they find anything worth money on him, they'll sell it, and him, to whichever side pays. They don't care whose pass you carry. Half of them can't read it." I leaned forward. "If you go up the river, sir, come back down it. On the ship. In your own coat. Whatever happens. Whatever he says to you."

He looked at me for a long moment.

"That's the arrangement," he said. "I'm to go up to the *Vulture*, and meet him under a flag, by water, and come back the same way. The General was very clear about it. So was I." He smiled. "I'm a staff officer, Freeman. Not a spy. I've no intention of creeping about Westchester in a farmer's hat."

"He'll want you to."

"Who will?"

"General Arnold, sir." It was the first time either of us had said the name aloud. It sat in the room between us like a third person. "He's selling his country for money. He'll be frightened. A man selling his country is frightened all the time, every minute, from the first letter to the last. He'll want the meeting somewhere he controls. On his side of the river. In a house. And when it's done, if anything's gone wrong, if the ship's moved, if there's a shot fired, if anybody's seen you, he won't want you anywhere near him. He'll want you gone the fastest way he can find. And the fastest way won't be the safe way. It'll be a horse, and a pass in his own hand, and a civilian coat over your uniform so nobody stops you." I stopped. "And if they do stop you, sir, in a civilian coat, behind their lines, with papers, you're not a staff officer any more. You're a spy. And they'll hang you."

He didn't say anything for a while. He picked up a crossed-out verse and looked at it and put it down again.

"You've thought about this a great deal," he said.

"Yes, sir. I've thought about very little else since I saw Colonel Robinson's letter about the house."

"And what would you have me do?"

"Take me with you," I said. "If you go ashore. If anything happens. If it has to be the land road. Take me. I know every road in that county. I know which farm has a dog and which ford is deep and which tavern keeper sells news. I can get you from the river to our lines in a night, by roads nobody watches, and nobody looks twice at a gentleman's servant. Nobody ever looks at me at all."



He thought about it. I'll always be grateful for that. He didn't wave it away. He sat there with the candle between us and thought about it honestly, the way he thought about a puzzle, turning it over.

Then he shook his head.

"No," he said, gently. "Thank you. No."

"Sir..."

"Two reasons." He held up one finger. "First, the arrangement. Arnold's been told one person. One officer, coming up under a flag. If I come ashore with a servant he doesn't know, he'll think he's been betrayed, and the whole thing will stop dead, and a year's work with it. He's frightened, as you say. A frightened man sees a stranger and runs." He held up a second finger. "And second, I'm coming back by water. On the *Vulture*. In my own coat. I've given the General my word. So there won't be a land road, and I shan't need a guide." He smiled. "You've been too long in the Neutral Ground, Freeman. Everything looks like an ambush to you."

"Everything is an ambush, sir. In the Neutral Ground."

He laughed. Then he stopped laughing and looked at me in the candlelight with his dark bright eyes, and said something I've never forgotten.

"I know what you're afraid of," he said. "You're afraid I'll be too clever. That I'll see a quicker way and take it, because I always do. You're right to be afraid of that. I'm afraid of it too." He picked up his pen. "So I'll make you a promise, since you've been honest with me. If I have to come back by land, I'll come back in my own coat. Whatever Arnold says."



He stopped. Freda had stopped eating pie some time ago. She was sitting with both arms wrapped round her knees, on the kitchen chair, with her chin on them.

"He promised," she said.

"He promised," he said. "And he meant it. He always meant it."

Freda looked at him. Then at me. Then she put her face down on her knees for a moment, and brought it up again.

"I looked it up," she said. "Last night. After you said September. I'm sorry. I couldn't not." Her voice wobbled, and she steadied it. "He wore a different coat."

"Yes," he said gently. "He did."



• RECORDING · SEPTEMBER 1780

The first attempt was on the eleventh, at Dobbs Ferry, before Robinson's letter about the house. André and Robinson went up by boat to meet Arnold on the river, and Arnold came down by barge from his side, and the British gunboats on the river, who hadn't been told, saw a rebel barge on the water and fired on it, and Arnold turned round and went home. That was nearly the end of it, right there. A gunboat lieutenant doing his duty.

They tried again. Arnold wrote, under his false name, that he'd be on the river on the night of the twentieth. Robinson went up on the *Vulture* on the sixteenth with his letter about the house, and the *Vulture* anchored off a long low point of land on the east shore called Teller's Point, a few miles below King's Ferry, and waited.

And on the morning of the twentieth, André went up to join it.

I went down to the slip to see him off. I had no business there. He saw me, standing at the back of the little crowd of boatmen and porters, and lifted his hand to me, quite openly, the way he'd lift it to Robinson or to the General, and I lifted mine.

He was in his uniform. The scarlet coat, and the gold lace, and the gorget at his throat. Under his boat cloak, but in it. I looked very carefully, because I'd been afraid of exactly that. He had nothing else with him but a small valise. No other coat. I let out a breath I'd been holding since the seventeenth.

He'd said he'd come back in his own coat, and there wasn't another coat in that boat to put on.



I was sent to the lines that night, with a party of DeLancey's horse, to the advanced posts below the Neutral Ground, on the east side of the river, to wait for him in case he came back by land after all. André had arranged it, in spite of what he'd said, which tells you that he'd thought about what I'd told him more than he'd let me see. If he came down by road, we were to meet him at the edge of the Neutral Ground and bring him in. If he came by water, we'd never see him, and that would be best of all.

My orders, from Beckwith, through the officer of DeLancey's party, were to wait at the lines, and on no account go forward into the Neutral Ground on my own. Two days. Then come home.

I waited.

On the night of the twentieth, nothing. On the night of the twenty-first, nothing. The river was very still. Nothing moved on it that we could see, from the heights, but the moon on the water and a fishing boat or two.

And at first light on the twenty-second, very far up the river, nearly thirty miles off, so faint I felt it in the ground before I heard it, somebody began firing a cannon.



He stopped. He put his hands flat on the kitchen table, on either side of his cup, and sat looking at them.

Nobody said anything. The kitchen clock ticked. Outside, the hawk had gone from the field.

“That’s enough for this morning,” he said at last. “We’ll go on after lunch. I’d like to walk down the road a little way first, if you two don’t mind. I’d like to see the car again.” He got up, with his hand on the edge of the table. “It’s a good thing to see. A car on a road. In the sun.”

He went out. Through the window I watched him go slowly down the porch steps with his hand on the rail and across the gravel and out to the end of the drive, where the car was, and stand there in the hot white sun beside it, with his hand resting on the roof, looking down the long straight gravel road toward the south.

Freda came and stood beside me at the window.

“He’s waiting for somebody,” she said.

“No,” I said. “I think he’s waiting for somebody who didn’t come.”

The Wrong Road

He came back from the end of the drive after a quarter of an hour, slowly, and washed his hands at the kitchen sink for a long time, and then made sandwiches, because it was lunchtime, and he made them for us every Thursday, and I think he needed to do something that he always did.

Freda helped. He let her. She buttered the bread and he cut the cheese, and neither of them said anything, and I sat at the table and watched them, the tall girl and the old man, side by side at the counter, moving around each other in the small kitchen as if they'd done it for years.

We ate on the porch. Nobody was very hungry.

Afterward he sat back on the bench, in the shade, and looked out at the field for a while. Then he said, "All right," to nobody in particular, and I started the recorders again.



• RECORDING · SEPTEMBER 1780

A cannon is a very simple sound, at thirty miles. It isn't a bang. It's a push, in the air and in the ground, that you feel in your chest more than hear. Then another. Then a long pause. Then another.

I stood on the heights above the lines in the gray light with the officer of DeLancey's party beside me, and we counted. Fourteen shots, in perhaps half an hour. Then nothing.

"Our people?" the officer said. "Or theirs?"

I didn't know. Nobody could have known, at that distance. But I knew where it came from. Up the river, on the east side, about where Teller's Point would be. Where the *Vulture* was anchored. Where there was no reason for anybody to be firing a cannon at dawn unless they were firing at a ship.

"Theirs," I said. "From the shore. At the *Vulture*."

He looked at me. "How can you know that?"

"Because the *Vulture*'s been sitting off a rebel shore for six days doing nothing, sir, and the rebels have guns, and sooner or later somebody was going to get bored." I was already thinking past it. "If they've hit her, or frightened her, she'll drop down the river. Out of range. And if she drops down the river..."

I didn't finish. I didn't have to. If the ship had dropped down the river, then wherever André was, he wasn't on it. He'd gone ashore in the night, to meet Arnold, and he'd come back to the shore at dawn to find his ship gone, or going.

And then the only way home was the land road.



A fishing boat came down that afternoon with the news. The *Vulture* had been hit, more than once, and had dropped a few miles down the river, out of range, and anchored again off Sing Sing. She was in no hurry. Nobody aboard her was signaling anybody.

I didn't need to see. I knew. I knew the way you know a thing about a person you've watched for a long time, as I'd known Robinson was nervous, and the carter was frightened, and Beckwith was angry. André was ashore. On the rebel side of the river. And Arnold, who was frightened, every minute, from the first letter to the last, had his visitor on his hands in broad daylight with a rebel shore battery wide awake and every militiaman for miles round looking up the river at the British warship.

He'd want him gone. The fastest way he could find.



I'd spent all summer thinking about the land road, and I'd thought it through to the end long before that morning. I want you to know that, so you'll understand what I did next. It wasn't a guess.

If André came down by land, he'd come down the east side of the river. He'd have to cross somewhere. The nearest crossing to Teller's Point was King's Ferry, a few miles up, and Arnold controlled King's Ferry. He'd send André over there, with a pass. And a pass from Arnold would be good on the roads Arnold commanded, which were the roads through his own posts. Down from the ferry, east, through the country behind the American lines, to their outposts. To North Castle, where a lieutenant colonel called Jameson kept a post of dragoons. And then through the outposts, on Arnold's pass, to White Plains. And from White Plains, into the Neutral Ground and down to us.

The White Plains road. A man with a pass from the commanding general would take the road his pass was written for. He'd go through the posts openly, because his pass was good at the posts. He'd ride in daylight. He'd look like what he was pretending to be, a gentleman on business, with a paper from the general. That was the sensible road. The safe road. The only road where the paper in his pocket meant anything.

And André was a soldier. He'd never been in the Neutral Ground on his own. He didn't know the back roads, and there'd be nobody to show him. He'd do what soldiers do in a strange country. He'd follow his orders, and his orders would be his pass.

So I went up the White Plains road to meet him.



My orders were to wait at the lines and on no account to go forward. I want you to know that too. I disobeyed them. I'd do it again. I'd do it every time.

I took a horse from DeLancey's party, the best one, without asking, and rode north out of the British lines a little before sunset on the twenty-second, alone, into the Neutral Ground. I took Robinson's paper, which was no use to me at all where I was going, and a knife, and a loaf of bread. And I rode up toward White Plains by the back ways, by the farm tracks and the wood roads

and the fords, by every road Caesar's body had known since it was a boy, in the dark.

It was a clear night. Very still. There was a half moon. You could see a long way on the roads, and I watched them all. Every rider. Every horse tied at a tavern door. Every lantern on every porch. I passed farmhouses I'd guided Loyalist horse to, and farmhouses I'd helped burn, and farmhouses where I knew the dogs. I passed the crossroads at Young's, where the house had been, and didn't look at it. By midnight I was on the high ground above White Plains, looking north up the long road that came down from North Castle, from the American posts. The road he'd come down, if he came.

I waited there all night. In a stand of cedars above the road, with the horse tied behind me and the bread uneaten in my coat, watching that road come down out of the dark.

Nobody came.



At first light I went further north. I couldn't help it. Up the road toward North Castle, as far as I dared, which was further than I should have. I thought he might have been held up, at a post, by a careful sentry. I thought he might have lodged somewhere for the night, the way travelers did. I thought a great many things. I asked a boy driving cows, as if I were a runaway, whether he'd seen a gentleman ride by, and he said there'd been gentlemen riding by all week with the armies the way they were, and asked me if I was a runaway, and I said no and gave him half the bread.

The sun came up. It got warm. Nine o'clock came, and went, on that empty road. I can tell you the exact moment, because I've worked it out since, a thousand times, from the records. At about nine o'clock on the morning of the twenty-third of September, while I sat on a borrowed horse in a stand of cedars above the White Plains road, looking north, with my bread in my coat, Major John André was sitting on a borrowed horse on a different road, perhaps eight miles to the west of me, being asked to get down.



He'd come down the river road. Through Tarrytown.

Not the road his pass was for. The other road. The river road, that ran down along the Hudson through the Neutral Ground, through country that was nobody's, where his pass from Arnold was no use to him at all. Where every band of men on the road was either the King's Cowboys or the rebels' militia, or nobody's, and a gentleman alone in a good coat was a gift from heaven to any of them.

Why? I've asked that every year since. The man who crossed with him at King's Ferry left him near Pine's Bridge that morning, after breakfast, and turned back. The story goes that somebody had told André, the night before or that morning, that the river road was safer. That it was in the Cowboys' country, and that the Cowboys were friends to the King. Which they were, mostly, if you were the King. Perhaps somebody told him that. Perhaps he worked it out for himself, and was too clever, the way he'd been afraid he'd be. He took the road toward people he thought were his own side.

At a little stream above Tarrytown, three men stepped out of the trees with muskets. One of them was wearing a faded Hessian coat that he'd taken off somebody somewhere. And André looked at the coat, and thought he was among friends, and said the thing you never say.

He told them he was a British officer.



There were eight of them, in the end, rebel militia, out on the road that morning on their own account, looking for cattle thieves and anything else worth taking. Three stopped him. Three of them searched him. They made him take off his boots. And in his stockings, under his feet, they found papers in General Arnold's own hand: the state of the works at West Point, the strength of the garrison, the placing of the guns, the minutes of a council of war.

He offered them his watch. His horse. Any sum of money they liked to name. They took him to the American post at North Castle instead.

He was wearing somebody else's coat.



He stopped.

He didn't stop the way he'd stopped before, to drink his water or to look at the field. He stopped the way a clock stops. His hands were on his knees, and he was looking at nothing, and he didn't move.

Freda didn't move either. She was sitting on the top step of the porch, where she'd gone after lunch, with her back against the post and her arms round her knees, and she was looking at him, and her face was wet. She wasn't making any sound at all.

I reached over, after a while, and turned off the recorders. Both of them. I didn't ask. It was the first time I'd ever done that, in all those Thursdays, without being asked. He didn't seem to notice.

We sat there. The three of us, on the porch, in the afternoon, in the heat. Somewhere a long way off a tractor was working, and the sound of it came and went on the hot air. A car passed, on the paved road at the end of the gravel, a mile off, and he turned his head very slightly toward the sound, and then away.

"He took the coat," he said at last. Quietly. Not to us. "He promised me, and he took the coat."

Nobody said anything.

"Arnold made him," he said. "I know that now. I've read all of it, everything anybody ever wrote down. Arnold was frightened, and in a hurry, and the ship was gone, and he talked André into it, into the coat and the pass and the papers in his boots, all three, every one of the three things that hanged him. And André let him. Because he was a soldier who'd been told to do a thing by a general. Because he was clever, and he could see that the coat was quicker. Because he didn't know the roads, and he trusted the man who did." He turned his head and looked at me, and I'd never seen his face like that. "He trusted the wrong man who knew the roads, Ms. Barnett. That's all. He had two of us. He trusted the wrong one."



After a long time he said I could turn the recorders back on.

"Not because I want to go on," he said. "Because I want it written down. Freda will type it. I want the rest of it on the tape, the way it was, so it's said once, and done."

I turned them on. He said the rest of it in a level voice, looking at the field.

He'd ridden back to the British lines on the afternoon of the twenty-third, with no news, and been put under arrest by DeLancey's officer for taking a horse and disobeying orders, and released the next morning when Beckwith sent for him. On the twenty-fourth, nothing. The *Vulture* lay in the river, waiting. Robinson sent a letter down to Clinton that day saying they'd heard nothing of André since he left the ship. On the twenty-fifth, a rumor, from the river, that something had happened at West Point, that Arnold had come down to the *Vulture* in his barge in a great hurry, under a flag, and gone aboard her and not come off.

And on the twenty-sixth, General Benedict Arnold came into New York.

"The people exult much," the Chief Justice wrote in his diary that night. *But it is not known yet that André was caught.*

"That's the only time I ever saw him," he said. "Arnold. On the twenty-seventh, on the Broadway, coming out of headquarters with two of Clinton's aides, in his new British coat, with his limp. He walked straight past me. I was standing at the gate, holding a horse. He didn't look at me, and I didn't look at him." He was quiet a moment. "I told you I never met him, and then I didn't. That's what I meant. I stood six feet from the man who'd talked André into that coat, and I didn't do anything at all. I held the horse."

He looked at Freda, on the step.

"That's the end of the road part," he said, gently. "You can stop now. Both of you. The rest is a week of waiting. I'll tell it next Thursday."

Freda wiped her face on the knees of her jeans, first one side, then the other.

"No," she said. "I want to hear it now. All of it. I don't want to wait a week knowing."

He looked at her for a long time.

“You’re very like your mother,” he said.

“Everybody says that,” Freda said, and her voice cracked in the middle, and she didn’t care. “Tell it anyway.”

A Deserter Is Never Given Up

• RECORDING · SEPTEMBER 1780

Clinton wrote to Washington the day Arnold came in. He said Major André had gone up the river under a flag, at General Arnold's invitation, and so could not be held as a prisoner, still less as anything worse, and he asked for him back. Very correct. Very polite. Everybody at headquarters agreed it was a very good letter.

The town didn't know yet. Not for a day or two. The town knew only that General Arnold had come over to the King, and it was delighted. People stood outside headquarters to see him come and go. A printer called Gaine wrote in his journal that it was to the great surprise of everybody. And then, the next day, he wrote that Major André had been taken by General Washington, and that it was supposed he would be ill used.

Supposed he would be ill used. That's how the city found out.



I'll tell you the week the way I lived it. In pieces. That's how it came.

On the twenty-eighth, word came down the river, the way word does, by boatmen and deserters and market women, that the rebels had moved André. Across the Hudson, under a heavy guard, to a village called Tappan, on the Jersey side, near the border with New York, where Washington had his headquarters that week. They'd put him in a tavern, in an upstairs room, with two officers in the room with him day and night, and the door open.

On the twenty-ninth, the news that there'd been a board. Fourteen of Washington's generals, at a table in a church in Tappan, with André in front of them, answering their questions. He'd answered them all, truthfully, the deserters said. He'd told them everything about himself and nothing about anybody else. He'd been so frank and so courteous that some of the generals hadn't been able to look at him. And at the end of the afternoon they'd found that he'd come behind their lines in disguise, under a false name, with papers, and that by the laws of war that made him a spy. And that he ought to suffer death.

I heard that in the yard at headquarters, from a groom, while I was holding a horse. I remember the horse. A bay mare, with a white sock behind. She stood on my foot, and I didn't notice until somebody pointed it out.



On the thirtieth, a Saturday, I went over to Paulus Hook.

It was an accident. I want to tell you that, because if I'd planned it I'd have been prouder of it, and I wasn't proud of anything that week. An officer of the garrison there needed a guide to take a party up into Bergen the next day after some cattle, and Beckwith sent me, because he wanted me out of the city and out of his sight, I think. I'd been going about headquarters for three days like a ghost.

That evening, a rebel captain came down to the post at Paulus Hook under a flag of truce, with a troop of dragoons and a packet of letters from Washington for Clinton. The commandant of the post asked him to supper, as officers did, under a flag, in that war. And because the commandant's servant had a fever, and I was there, and a Black man in a decent coat is a servant to anybody who needs one, I waited at the table.

I stood behind the commandant's chair with a bottle, and filled the glasses, and listened.

They talked about nothing, at first. The weather. The cattle in Bergen. The roads. And then, near the end, when the wine had gone round twice, the rebel captain leaned a little toward the commandant, and lowered his voice, and said something that he plainly hadn't been told to write down.

He said, as one of them remembered it long afterward, that if Sir Henry Clinton were to give up General Arnold to General Washington, Major André would very likely be set free.



I didn't drop the bottle. I've always been rather proud of that.

The commandant didn't answer. He looked at the rebel captain for a long moment, and then he got up from the table, and called for his horse, and went down to the boat, and was rowed across the river to the city in the dark to see the General himself, at that hour, with that in his pocket. The rebel captain sat on alone at the table with his wine. I filled his glass. He looked up at me once, a young, tired, decent face, and I think he was ashamed of what he'd been sent to say, and I think he hoped it would work, as much as I did.

I stood behind that empty chair for two hours.

I've thought, since, about what I'd have given, in those two hours. Everything. Arnold. Of course Arnold. I'd have carried him over to Tappan myself, on my back, tied in a sack, and laid him at Washington's feet. A man who'd sold his country for money, and talked the best man I knew into somebody else's coat to save his own skin, and then run. What was he worth? What was he worth to anybody?

The boat came back in two hours. The commandant came up the steps from the landing, slowly, and stood in the doorway, and the rebel captain stood up.

"Sir Henry's answer," the commandant said, "is that a deserter was never given up."



He stopped.

He wasn't looking at the field now. He was looking at Freda, on the top step, with her back against the post. She'd stopped crying some time back. She was very white.

"That's not fair," she said. "He could have. He could have just... swapped."

“He could have,” he said. “And every man who’d ever come over to the King, in that war, on a promise, would have known that the King’s promise was good only until it became inconvenient. Every Loyalist in New York. Every deserter. Every Black man who’d come in on a proclamation.” He looked at her steadily. “Every one of us, Freda. Me. If Clinton gave up Arnold, then the next time it was convenient, he could give up any of us. To be hanged, or to be sold back to the men who’d owned us. And everybody would know it.”

Freda stared at him.

“So he saved you,” she said slowly. “By not saving André.”

“That’s what I’ve had to think about, ever since,” he said. “Yes. A deserter was never given up. Arnold was a deserter. So was I.”



• RECORDING • OCTOBER 1780

On the first of October, a schooner called the *Greyhound* went up the river under a flag, with three gentlemen from the city aboard: a general, and the lieutenant governor, and the Chief Justice. They were to plead for André. They’d been up half the night before, at a council at headquarters, deciding what to say, and they’d decided he wasn’t a spy at all, and they’d written it all down very carefully.

The rebels let one of them ashore. General Greene came down to meet him at Dobbs Ferry. They talked for a long time, by the river. Greene listened, and was courteous, and said, at the end, that the decision had been made, and nothing could alter it. And then he hinted, the general wrote afterward, that André might be safe if Arnold were given up.

And our general, the record says, *answered with a Look*.

That’s all. Answered with a look. I’ve read those three words in an old letter more times than I’ve read anything, in all my lives. I can see the look. I don’t need anybody to describe it to me.

They hanged André the next day, at noon, on a hill outside Tappan. The second of October.



We didn't know for three days.

On the third, Gaine wrote in his journal that the general had come back down the river, and that Major André was not hanged. The whole city believed it, for a day. I believed it. I went down to the slip at the bottom of Queen Street, where I'd watched him go up the river in his scarlet coat, and stood there half the afternoon, watching every boat that came down, as if he'd be in one of them.

On the fifth, it came. The lieutenant governor wrote in his diary that an account had come to town that morning that Major André was executed at Tappan. And on the sixth and seventh, Gaine wrote that it was confirmed, and that there were great lamentations.

There were. I'll say that for the city that week, and for the army. They loved him. The General put out an order to the whole army mourning him as a gentleman of the highest integrity and honour. Robinson, I was told, sat on the edge of his bed in his lodgings with his face in his hands. Every officer in the army put a band of black crêpe round his arm.



They told it all over the city, afterward, what had happened at Tappan. The rebels had told it to the boatmen and the boatmen to everybody.

That he'd been courteous to everybody to the end. To his guards, who wept. To the officers who came to see him. That he'd drawn a picture of himself, the night before, with a pen, sitting at the table by the window, and given it to the officer of the guard. That he'd shaved, and put on his uniform, which his servant had been allowed to bring him from the city, and come out and walked to the hill between two officers, arm in arm, talking to them. That he'd asked Washington to let him be shot, like a soldier, and not hanged, like a thief, and Washington hadn't answered. That when he saw the gallows, he'd stopped for a moment, and then gone on. That he'd put the noose round his own neck, and tied the handkerchief over his own eyes. That when

they asked if he had anything to say, he'd said only that he wanted them to bear witness that he met his fate like a brave man.

And that the American officers who stood round that hill, the officers of the army he'd come to destroy, had wept like children. Every one of them.

His servant came back to the city at the end of the month, under a flag, with his master's things. His uniform. His watch, which had been taken by the men who stopped him on the road, and which André's friends had bought back from them for forty guineas.

I saw the servant come up from the slip, carrying them. A thin young Englishman with red eyes, with the scarlet coat folded over his arm.

It was his own coat. It came home. He didn't.



Nobody said anything for a very long time.

The sun had gone round. The porch was in shade now, all of it, and the field had turned the color it turns in the late afternoon in July, a deep tired gold, with the shadows of the trees reaching right across it.

"I have his face," he said at last. Quietly. "From the night in his office, with the candle. Saying he'd come back in his own coat. I have it exactly. I'll have it until I die in this body, and then I suppose I'll lose it, the way I've lost everything else of Caesar's. And I find I don't know if I'll be sorry."

He stood up, with his hand on the rail.

"There's one more thing," he said. "And then I'll stop, and you can drive home." He looked at me. "The man in the city stopped writing, that October. After Arnold came over. I'll tell you how, next week. He was frightened, and he had every reason to be. But before he stopped, he wrote one more letter. And in it, he wrote this. I've read it so often I don't need to look at it." He closed his eyes. *"I never felt more sensibly for the death of a person whom I knew only by sight, and had heard converse, than I did for Major André."*

He opened his eyes.

"That's the man I'd been hunting all year," he said. "The man whose road I'd shut, and whose carter I'd frightened, and whose boat I'd had shot up in a creek. And he sat in his room, in that city, and grieved for André, the same week

I did.” He was quiet for a moment. “That was a war, Ms. Barnett. Freda. That’s what a war is. We were on opposite sides of it, he and I, and we were the only two men in that city who’d have understood each other completely, and neither of us ever knew the other one existed.”



Freda typed it on the Sunday.

I offered to do it myself. She wouldn’t let me. She took the laptop into her room and shut the door, and I heard her through it all afternoon, stopping and starting the tape, and once, about four o’clock, I heard her crying, quite hard, for a minute or two, and then the typing again. I didn’t go in. She wouldn’t have wanted me to.

At six she came out and put the laptop on the kitchen table and said, “It’s done,” and went and stood at the back door looking out at the yard for a while.

“He was thirty,” she said, without turning round. “That’s not that much older than Dad was when he left.”

I didn’t say anything.

“He’s been dead nearly two hundred and forty-seven years,” Freda said. “Why does it feel like somebody died this week?”

“Because somebody told you about him who loved him,” I said. “That’s how it works. That’s all it takes.”

She thought about that, looking out at the yard. Then she turned round, and wiped her face with both hands, and said, “I’m going to make Mr. Hale another pie,” and went to the cupboard to see if we had any flour.

The Provost

Freda made a blueberry pie, the second time, and it fell apart when she cut it, and he said it was the best thing that had happened to him all week and had two pieces to prove it. She came up with me again. She hadn't asked if she could. She'd just been sitting in the car when I came out of the house on the Thursday morning, with the pie on her knees and her seat belt on, looking straight ahead, and I'd got in and started the engine and neither of us said anything about it.

He was at the bottom of the steps again, under the maple.

Session thirty-nine. Thursday, July twenty-second. It was cooler. A front had come through in the night with a long grumble of thunder that never quite turned into rain, and the air had a clean, washed edge to it, and there was a little wind in the maple. He sat on the bench in the cardigan, for the first time in weeks, and Freda sat on the top step with her back against the post, which was her place now, and he looked at the two of us and said, "October," and then, "This is the part where I win."

"After André?" Freda said.

"After André." He looked out at the field. "I've told you the truth about everything else. I'll tell you the truth about this. I've never in any life worked as hard as I did that autumn, or as well. And I've never been as unhappy doing it."



• RECORDING • OCTOBER 1780

Arnold gave them a list.

That was the first thing that happened, before André was even dead. Arnold came over to the King on the twenty-sixth of September, and on the twenty-eighth, while André was being moved to Tappan, men from the Provost Marshal's office went through the city with a list of names in Arnold's hand and took people out of their houses. Merchants, mostly. Gentlemen. A few tradesmen. People Arnold said, from what he'd learned as a rebel general, had been sending news to Washington. Some of them had, I expect. Most of them hadn't. A Hessian officer wrote in his diary that more of them were taken to the prison every day.

I watched them taken. I watched a man I knew by sight, a respectable old merchant from Hanover Square who'd once given me a penny for holding his horse, led down the Broadway between two soldiers in his nightcap, with his wife running after them in the street. They held him six weeks and let him go. I don't believe he'd ever written a word to anybody.

That's what a list from a man like Arnold is worth, in a war. He didn't know who Washington's people in New York were. Nobody had ever told him. He was a general. Generals aren't told. So he gave them every name he'd ever heard spoken in a rebel camp with any kind of look on the speaker's face, and they filled the Provost with them.

It frightened the city. I'll give it that. It frightened everybody. That's the trouble with a list like that. It frightens the innocent and the guilty exactly the same amount, and the innocent have nothing to hide, so they go on as before. The guilty were frightened already.



There was a new man in André's office by the middle of October. Oliver DeLancey, a New Yorker, a Loyalist, a cavalry officer, cousin to the DeLanceys whose refugee horse I'd ridden with in the Neutral Ground. He was made Adjutant General in André's place, and he took over André's secret business, with Beckwith beside him.

He sent for me the first week.

He wasn't André. Nobody was. He was a brisk, square, practical man with no imagination, and he didn't offer me a chair. But he'd read what

Beckwith had written about me, and he'd read what André had written, and he looked at me across André's long table under the window, with André's drawing board still in the corner with nothing pinned to it, and he said, "The Major thought very highly of you."

"Yes, sir."

"So did he of a great many people. He was a generous man." He put his hands flat on the table. "I'm not. I want Washington's people in this city, Freeman. The real ones. Not Arnold's merchants. I want them in the Provost, and then I want them on the end of a rope, the way they put the Major on the end of one. Can you find them?"

I looked at him. And then I looked at the drawing board in the corner, for longer than I should have.

"I can make them stop, sir," I said. "I think that's better."



I want to tell you why I said that, because Freda's going to ask me if I don't.

It wasn't mercy. Not only. I'd spent a year in that city by then. I'd watched what the Provost did to people, and what the gallows did, and what a list did. And I'd watched André go up the river and come back folded over his servant's arm. And I'd found, sitting in a cedar wood above the White Plains road on the morning of the twenty-third of September, that I didn't want to put anybody else in a coat that would hang them. Not even the people I was hunting. Not even the man in the city.

And it was better. That was the other half of it, and it was true. A hanged spy tells you nothing. A frightened one stops, and goes on being frightened, and frightens the next one, and the one after. André had said that. I'd heard him. *A hanged spy is a wasted opportunity.* I wasn't going to waste his last idea on DeLancey.

DeLancey looked at me for a long time. Then he said, "Make them stop, then," in the voice of a man who thought I was being soft, and would hang me too if I failed, and I went out.



So I made them stop. I'll tell it quickly, because it's mostly small things, done well, one after another.

I watched the ferry. I'd never stopped watching it. And on the eighth or ninth of October, I went past the dry goods shop in Hanover Square that I'd watched in the spring, the one the carter had come out of with the quire of paper. And the shutters were up. In the middle of a Monday. And they stayed up. I went past every day for eighteen days, and the shutters stayed up, and on the twenty-seventh they came down again, and the young partner was back behind the counter, very pale. That day, I read long afterward in his own account book, he drew a great deal of money out of the business in cash.

I didn't go in. I didn't tell DeLancey. I knew what DeLancey would do with a shop that had shut its shutters for eighteen days in the week after Arnold came over. He'd have had the partner in the Provost by dinner, and the shop turned out, and nothing would have been found, because there'd be nothing to find. And then DeLancey would have had to decide what to do with a frightened young merchant with nothing against him but his shutters. And DeLancey didn't like waste.

I let it be. I'd frightened that shop once. It was frightened again. That was the round.

I've told you the man in the city wrote one more letter, after André died. His last for a long time. He said in it that he was glad Arnold didn't know his name. And then he stopped writing. For the whole winter. Their man in Setauket wrote to Tallmadge at the end of October that the man in the city had *resolved for the present to quit writing and retire into the country for a time*, and that the enemy were *very severe*, and that he himself *did not think myself safe there a moment*.

Very severe. That was me, Ms. Barnett. And Freda. That was me, and DeLancey, and the ghost of a young man in a scarlet coat.



The second thing was the boat.

The rebels had boats on the Sound besides Brewster's: whaleboats, with crews of Long Island men who'd gone over to Connecticut and came back raiding. One of them was commanded by a Captain Conklin. And there was a man in Setauket, a Loyalist, called Abijah Tooker, who knew a great deal about who came and went on that shore and liked to be paid for it. I'd found him in August, through Glover. I'd never met him. I'd sent him a little money now and then by a Loyalist sloop, and he sent back what he knew.

At the beginning of October, Tooker sent word of where Conklin's crew would be. Refugee boats went out and took them, near a place on that shore called Treadwell's Banks. A rebel lieutenant was killed. The rest were taken. And the man in Setauket wrote to Tallmadge that week, angry and frightened, that *their misfortune is owing to Abijah Tooker of Seatauket*.

He was right. It was. It was owing to Abijah Tooker, and to me.



And the third thing. The one I want to tell you properly.

There was a man who helped them. Not one of the ring. One of the people around it, who carried a thing here and there, who held a horse, who kept a letter in his house for a night. Every chain has people like that. They're never in the books. They're never in anybody's books. He was a ferryman on the Brooklyn ferry, an old man with one eye, who'd worked the sweeps on those flat boats for thirty years. I'd watched him all year. I'd watched him take a folded paper from the carter, once, in the spring, and put it inside his hat, and give it to somebody on the Brooklyn side. I'd never done anything about it. I'd been saving him.

In the first week of November, after the shutters, I gave him to DeLancey.

Not as a spy. I was very careful. As a man who'd been seen carrying letters for persons unknown. DeLancey had him taken up at the ferry stairs and put in the Provost. And they questioned him, and he said nothing. Nothing at all. He said he was an old man who rowed a boat, and he'd carried a great many things for a great many people in thirty years, and he couldn't remember any of them, and he was sorry. He said it for three weeks. They didn't

hurt him. I'd asked DeLancey not to, and DeLancey had looked at me as if I were mad, and then, I think because André would have, agreed.

I went to see him in the Provost. Twice. I brought him a blanket, because it was cold, and bread, and once a little tobacco. He looked at me through the bars with his one eye and knew perfectly well who'd put him there, I think. And he took the blanket. And he said thank you. And he said nothing else, to me or to anybody, ever.

The man in Setauket wrote to Tallmadge in the middle of November. *Several of our dear friends were imprisoned, he wrote. In particular one that hath been ever serviceable to this correspondence. This step so dejected the spirits of C. Junr.,* he wrote, meaning the man in the city, *that he resolved to leave New York for a time.*

Ever serviceable. That was my ferryman. With one eye, and my blanket, and his mouth shut.

They let him out after Christmas. Nobody had ever been able to say what he'd done. He went back to the ferry and worked the sweeps till he died.

And that was the end of it. The road was shut. The man in the city had gone to the country. The man in Setauket was afraid to go to New York. The boats were watched, and some of them were taken. The ring that had written to Washington every two weeks all summer was silent, all that winter. Nobody was hanged. Nobody was ever going to be.



He stopped and drank some water. The wind moved in the maple. Freda was sitting very still on the top step.

"You won," she said.

"I won."

"But you don't look like you won."

He thought about it.

"There's a thing that happens," he said, "after a loss like André. You go on. You do the work. You do it better than you've ever done it, because the work's the only thing in front of you that you can get right. And you win, and you win, and you win, and it doesn't help at all." He looked at her. "I'm not telling

you that so you'll be sad. I'm telling you because one day you'll lose something, and you'll go on, and win things, and wonder what's wrong with you that it doesn't help. Nothing's wrong with you. It just doesn't. Not for a while."

Freda looked at him for a long moment.

"How long's a while?" she said.

"In that case," he said, "about two hundred years." Then he smiled at her, properly, the first real smile all morning. "But I'm very slow."



He was right about Claire. I want to put that down here, out of order, because it happened six days later, and I don't want it to get lost in the rest.

It was the Wednesday. The twenty-eighth of July. I was at the kitchen table at a little after ten in the morning, writing three hundred words about a roofing company. Freda was asleep. The house was quiet. And my phone, face down on the table where it had been face down for four weeks, buzzed once, and then again.

A number I didn't know. A Virginia number.

I turned it over and looked at it for a long time, while it buzzed. Then I picked it up.

"Hello?"

There was nothing on the line for a moment. Just breathing, and behind it, very faint, a radio playing country music, and a horse blowing out through its nose, a long, soft, rattling breath.

"It was twenty-seven minutes," Claire Whitcombe said.

I looked at the clock on the stove. It said ten fourteen. On a Wednesday morning, in summer.

"I know," I said.

Bookbinder

She wouldn't talk on the phone. I hadn't expected her to.

"Not like this," she said, after the twenty-seven minutes, after a long silence with the radio and the horse in it. "Saturday. Not the barn. Somewhere else." She named a diner on Route 7 outside Leesburg, halfway between us. "Noon."

"Noon," I said.

There was another silence. Then, "You didn't tell him," she said. "My father. You could have. You didn't."

"No."

"Why not?"

I thought about how to say it.

"Because I asked you a question," I said. "Not him."

She hung up without saying goodbye. I sat at the kitchen table with the phone in my hand for a long time. Then I went and woke Freda, which I never do in summer, and told her, and she sat bolt upright in bed with her hair over her face and said, "I'm coming," and I said she wasn't coming into the diner, and she said she'd sit in the car, and I said fine, because I wanted her there, and we both knew it.



The next day was Thursday, so I went up. Freda came. She'd had her learner's permit since March and she drove the first hour, both hands on the wheel, while I sat beside her and tried not to hold the door handle.

I told him on the porch, about the call. *It was twenty-seven minutes.* He listened, and then he sat back and closed his eyes for a moment in the sun.

"Saturday," he said. "Good."

And then he wouldn't do any 1780 at all. "Not this week," he said. "You wouldn't hear a word of it. Neither of you." So I said the date into the recorders anyway, *session forty, Thursday, July twenty-ninth*, and they ran for an hour and ten minutes on the three of us sitting on his porch talking about pie crust, and a hawk over the field, and whether a cat with white feet could be called anything but Socks. Freda typed it on the Sunday and said it was her favorite tape of the whole year, and I've never asked her why, because I know.



It was the kind of diner I'd done half my reporting in, years ago. Chrome and red vinyl, a long counter with stools, pies under plastic domes, a waitress with a coffee pot who called everybody hon. I got there at a quarter to twelve and sat in a booth by the window where I could see the lot. Freda was in the car, at the far end of it, with the windows down and her headphones round her neck, pretending to look at her phone.

At five to twelve a dusty white pickup with a vet's box on the back pulled in and parked, and Claire Whitcombe sat in it with the engine running for a minute, looking at the diner. Then she turned off the engine and got out.

She'd come straight from a call. She was in the same kind of jeans and flannel and boots, with her sleeves rolled, and she came in and looked round once and saw me and came over and sat down across the booth without saying anything. The waitress came. Claire ordered coffee. I ordered coffee. When the waitress had gone, she put both hands flat on the table, the way he does, and looked at them.

"I've been sick about you for six years," she said.



I'm going to tell it the way she told it. As near as I can. I didn't have a recorder. I didn't take a note, the whole time, not one, and I've never done that before in

my life. I wrote it down in the car afterward, for an hour, while Freda sat beside me and didn't say a word.

Her father had called her on the Wednesday morning at seven. She was at home, in Purcellville, getting ready for the day. He'd never called her that early in her life. He said he needed her to drive him into the city, right away, and not to ask him why, and could she please come.

She'd come. Of course she had. He was seventy-three and he didn't drive in the city anymore, and he'd never once asked her for anything like that.

On the way in he told her a little. That a young man who worked for him at Carrow, a man she'd known since she was a teenager, who'd been to their house at Christmas, who'd been her father's apprentice for fifteen years, had done something brave and foolish. That he'd given a newspaper a great deal of Carrow's private paperwork. That the paper had run a story on the Sunday. And that on Tuesday night, very late, someone at Carrow had telephoned her father at home and told him they knew who it was.

"He didn't tell me who called," Claire said. "He's never told me. Somebody high up. Somebody he'd known for thirty years." She turned her coffee cup round on the table. "They told him they knew. They told him they'd be at the apartment with the police by the end of the week, with a warrant, for the papers. Stolen company documents. They said they'd prosecute. They said they'd make sure he never worked with a piece of paper again in his life, and that he'd go to prison if they could manage it. And they said..." She stopped. "They said my father should think very carefully about whose side he was on."

"So he went to get the papers."

"He went to get the papers. Before they could. Because he said the papers were the only proof that your story was true, and if Carrow got them, they'd disappear." She looked up at me for the first time. "That's what he said. I've thought about it for six years. I believe he meant it. I think he also meant that if Carrow got the papers they'd find out what was in them, and some of what was in them was letters he'd been asked to repair, himself, over the years. And had." She looked back down. "Both of those. I don't know which was more."



She told me about the morning. The building over the dry cleaner's, with the steam coming up through the grates. The alley behind it. Her father going in by the back door, which stuck, and which he had to fight. Her father laughing on the stairs, once, too loud, the way he always laughs when he's frightened. She'd heard it from the car. Her sitting in the car with the engine running because she was afraid to turn it off, in case they needed to leave in a hurry, in case somebody came. Every car that passed the end of the alley.

"Twenty-seven minutes," she said. "I watched the clock on the dash the whole time. I've never been so frightened in my life. I've had a horse go down on me in a trailer on the interstate, and I wasn't as frightened as that." She almost smiled. "Nobody's ever asked me how long. You're the only person who's ever asked."

"Somebody told me to."

"Who?"

"A man who knows what it's like to wait in the wrong place for somebody who doesn't come," I said.

She looked at me oddly, but she didn't ask.

They'd brought down two boxes and his computer, she said. And him. He'd come down the stairs white as paper and got into the back seat with the boxes and not said a word all the way out of the city. He thought he was going for a day or two. To the country, to her father's house, until things calmed down. He'd shut his cat in the bedroom, because her father was at the door, and he'd left food, and he'd meant to go back for her that night, or ask a neighbor.

"And that afternoon," Claire said, "at the house, my father told him the rest. About the warrant, and the prosecution, and what they'd said. And he said he couldn't go back. Not that night. Maybe not ever. He said if he went back to that apartment he'd walk straight into them." She closed her eyes. "And he said, *Who'll feed Pearl?* That was the first thing he said. Not his job. Not you. *Who'll feed Pearl?*"

I couldn't say anything.

"My father said he'd see to it. He said he'd call the landlord." She opened her eyes. "He didn't. He forgot. Or he didn't want to call anyone who might ask

where the tenant was. I don't know which. I found out on the Saturday. I've never forgiven him for that, either."



The waitress came back and filled our cups, and asked if we were ready to order, and we both said no, and she went away.

"Why are you telling me this?" I said. "Now."

She was quiet for a long time.

"Because I'm angry," she said. "Because I've been angry for six years and there's nobody I can tell. My father says it was the right thing. He says the papers are safe and the young man's safe and the lawsuit went away and everything worked out. He says you'd be fine. He said that, at the time. *Reporters always land on their feet.*" She looked at me. "And then I read about you. The correction. You losing your job. People on the internet calling you a liar, for years. And I thought, that's us. We did that. We took the one thing that would have shown she was right, and put it in our barn, and let her..."

She stopped.

"Let me hold it," I said. "By myself."

"Yes."

"For six years. While everybody decided I'd made him up."

"Yes," Claire said, and her voice broke, and she put her hand over her mouth.

And I understood that the thing I'd been carrying for six years, she'd been carrying too. From the other end. And that she'd been carrying it with nobody to put it down in front of, because the only other people who knew were the two men she'd driven out of that alley, and one of them thought it had all worked out, and the other one was hiding.

"He's alive," I said. "Isn't he."

She took her hand away from her mouth.

"He wants to see you," she said.



She drove. I want that on the record. Claire Whitcombe drove, and I sat in the passenger seat of her pickup, with her vet's kit rattling in the back, and Freda followed us in our car, two hours west, over the Blue Ridge, into the Shenandoah Valley, to a small town with a courthouse and a college and a main street of old brick buildings with mountains standing up at both ends of it. She drove the way she'd watched that horse: carefully, not fast, all the way.

He lived in a little white frame house on a side street, near the college, with a porch and a big garage behind it with the door rolled up. He was in the garage when we pulled up. I saw him before he saw me.

He was at a workbench, under a lamp, with a book open in front of him. An old book, big and heavy, with the spine coming away. He had a brush in one hand and a little pot of glue at his elbow, and he was laying a strip of cloth along the inside of the spine, very slowly, very carefully, smoothing it with the side of his thumb. He was thinner. His hair had gone gray at the temples. He had glasses on that he hadn't had before. He looked exactly the same.

He'd always worked like that. I'd forgotten. When we met in diners, he used to fold the paper napkin into smaller and smaller squares while he talked, exactly matching the corners, and then unfold it and smooth it out flat with the side of his thumb.

Claire turned off the engine. He looked up.

He saw her first. Then me.

He put the brush down in the glue pot, carefully, so it wouldn't drip. He took off his glasses and folded them and put them in his shirt pocket. And then he stood there behind his workbench, in his garage, with his hands at his sides, and looked at me across six years, and I saw that he was more frightened than I'd ever seen him, more frightened than in any parking lot or diner, more frightened than the first night in the diner, when he slid into the booth across from me with a folder under his arm and asked if I was Iola Barnett.

I got out of the truck.

I'd thought about what I'd say, for six years. On bad nights, when I was furious with him, I'd had whole speeches. On worse nights, I'd thought he was dead, and there'd been nothing to say at all. I stood in his driveway in the sun and every word of every speech went out of my head.

"I kept the receipt," I said. "From the diner. The grilled cheese. You never ate it."

He looked at me for a long moment. And then something happened to his face that I'd never seen happen to it before, in eight months of meetings, and he came round the end of the workbench and across the garage, and I don't remember which of us got there first.



We sat in his kitchen, after. Claire and him and me. Freda had come up the drive and stood in the garage door, uncertain, and he'd looked at her and said, "You're the daughter. You were ten," and she'd said yes, and he'd said, "I'm sorry," and she'd said, "It's okay," in a voice that meant it mostly was, and gone to sit on the porch, where she could hear.

He made grilled cheese. In a black iron pan, on an old gas stove, with tomato soup from a can heated in a little saucepan beside it. He didn't ask if we wanted any. He made four, and put them on four plates, and sent one out to Freda on the porch, and sat down with us at his kitchen table.

And he ate it. All of it. The whole sandwich, and the soup, with a spoon, slowly, while I watched him.

"Six years," he said, when he'd finished. "I couldn't eat in front of you. Every time. I used to go home after and eat two." He looked at the empty plate. "I was so frightened, all those months. All the time. I was frightened walking into that diner and frightened walking out. And you were the only person I'd ever met who didn't think I was mad."

"I didn't think you were mad."

"I know." He looked up. "That's why I chose you."



I asked him about Pearl. He asked me first, really. Before the papers, before the lawsuit, before anything else. The first thing he asked me, sitting at his kitchen table with his hands round his coffee cup, was whether I knew what had happened to his cat.

I told him what I knew. That Petrakis had found her on the Friday, shut in the bedroom, half starved, and taken her to the shelter himself, and complained about the carpet. That I'd never asked, after.

He nodded slowly.

"I called the shelter," he said. "A month later. From a pay phone, in a gas station in Front Royal. I said I was a neighbor. They told me she'd been adopted. A family with two little girls." He was quiet for a moment. "I've thought about those girls a great deal. I hope they let her sleep on the bed."

He had another cat now. A big gray one with white feet, asleep in a basket on top of the refrigerator, that he'd taken from the same kind of shelter in the valley, three years ago. He didn't say why he'd picked that one. He didn't need to.



The boxes were in Gerald Whitcombe's barn, in Middleburg, Claire said, in the loft, under a tarp, where they'd been for six years, with the computer. Her father went up and looked at them once a year, she thought. She'd seen him do it.

"They're yours," Bookbinder said to me. "They always were. I'd have given them to you that week, if..." He stopped. "I want you to have them. All of it. I want it printed. I want it in the paper with your name on it, the way it should have been, and I want..." He stopped again, and took off his glasses, and put them back on. "I want my name on it too. If you'll have it. I've spent six years being nobody in a garage in a valley. I'd like to be somebody again before I'm too old to enjoy it."

"Your name," I said.

"My real one." He told it to me. Across his kitchen table, at last. He'd never needed to before. He'd always just been the man in the booth.

I didn't write it down. I've never written it down, and I'm not going to now. He says I may. He says I should. He says it doesn't matter anymore, and that he'd like it in the paper, and it will be, when the paper's ready, in black and white, under mine.

But in my notebook, and here, he's still what he was the first night I came home from the diner and opened a fresh page and needed something to call

him. A man who mended old books, and kept copies of everything, and folded his napkin into smaller and smaller squares while he talked, and smoothed it flat again with the side of his thumb.

Bookbinder.



Freda drove us home. It was dark by the time we came back over the mountains. She drove carefully, not fast, the whole way, with both hands on the wheel, and I sat beside her with the window down and the night air coming in, and didn't say anything for a long time.

"Mom," Freda said, somewhere east of Front Royal.

"Mm."

"You have to tell Mr. Hale."

"I know."

"He said the dogs had gone quiet," Freda said. "He knew. He knew it was this."

"He didn't know," I said. "He thought it."

"He knew," Freda said, with great certainty, watching the road. "He always knows. He just waits for you to get there, so you'll have had it yourself." She was quiet for a mile. "That's what he does with the eggs, too."

I turned my head and looked at her in the dashboard light.

"Don't say it," I said. "He asked us not to."

"I'm not saying anything," Freda said. "I'm driving."

The Garden Wall

He was at the bottom of the steps when we drove up. Under the maple, with his hands in his pockets, watching the car come up the gravel road.

And I understood, all at once, with my hands on the wheel, what he'd meant. *It's a good thing to see, a car coming up a road. You'll understand later.* He'd been waiting at the bottom of those steps every Thursday since July for a car to come up a road. Not ours. Somebody else's. A dusty white pickup with a vet's box on the back, turning into a side street in a valley town, with a man in a garage looking up from his workbench.

He'd known. Freda was right. He hadn't known the town, or the garage, or the grilled cheese. But he'd known there'd be a car, and a road, and somebody looking up. And he'd stood at the bottom of his own steps for a month so that when it came, I'd remember he'd been waiting for it.

I stopped the car. Freda got out first. She didn't say anything. She went straight across the gravel and stood in front of him, and he took his hands out of his pockets, and she put her arms round him, which she'd never done, and he stood very still for a moment, and then put one hand on the back of her head, the way you do with a child, though she was taller than he was.

"He's alive," she said into his shoulder. "He makes grilled cheese. He's got a cat with white feet."

"Has he," he said. "Has he, now."



I told it all on the porch. Every word, from the diner to the drive home over the mountains in the dark. He didn't interrupt once. Freda sat on the top step against the post and corrected me twice, about the soup, and about the color of the cat. When I got to the receipt, and what I'd said in the driveway, he closed his eyes. When I got to Pearl, and the pay phone in Front Royal, and the family with two little girls, he took off his glasses, which he almost never wore, and cleaned them on his shirt for a long time.

At the end he sat with his hands folded on his knee and looked out at the field.

"You won," he said.

"We won."

"No." He turned his head and looked at me. "You won. I sat on a porch and talked about ice. You drove to a barn with nothing in your hands and asked one question and went away, and waited a month without knowing, and didn't tell anybody, and didn't give up." He looked back at the field. "Six years, Ms. Barnett. You've held it six years by yourself. And you got there."

I didn't trust myself to answer. I said the date into the recorders instead. *Session forty-one. Thursday, August fifth.* My voice wasn't very steady, and I've left it on the tape.

"And now," he said, "since it's a day for it, I'll tell you about the best thing I did that whole year. For the worst man I ever met."



• RECORDING · OCTOBER 1780

General Arnold was in New York, and Washington wanted him back.

Not to forgive. To hang. Washington had been more hurt by Arnold than by anything else in that war, I think. He'd trusted Arnold above almost anybody, and given him West Point, and Arnold had sold it, and run, and left André to hang in his place. Washington couldn't have André back. But he thought he could have Arnold. In a sack, if necessary. Across the river. Alive.

I didn't know any of that, at the time. Nobody in New York did. I learned it afterward, like the rest, from the letters. Washington wrote to one of his

cavalry officers, a young major called Henry Lee, on the twentieth of October, that he agreed to the plan, and that the essential point was that Arnold be *brought to me alive*. He wanted to make a public example of him.

And that same night, a sergeant of Lee's dragoons, a big, steady Virginian called Champe, deserted.



I saw him come in.

I was at Paulus Hook again, by chance, the morning of the twenty-first. There were two British galleys lying off the Jersey shore, and in the gray light we saw a man come pelting down the beach at Bergen with a troop of rebel dragoons galloping behind him, shouting, close enough that we heard them, and he ran straight into the water in his boots and swam for the nearest galley, with a valise strapped on his back, and the sailors pulled him out by his collar just as the dragoons reached the shore and pulled up their horses at the edge of the surf and shook their fists.

Everybody cheered. The sailors, the garrison, me. It was the best desertion anybody had seen all war. A sergeant-major of the famous Lee's Legion, chased to the very water's edge by his own comrades, and saved by a boat's length.

They took him to the city that afternoon. He was questioned by the Adjutant General's office, as every deserter was, and then by Sir Henry Clinton himself, because a sergeant-major of Lee's was worth asking. He answered everything readily and well. He passed all the forms of the garrison. And a few days later he enlisted in the new corps that General Arnold was raising, of Americans who'd come over to the King, and was made a sergeant in it, and went about the town in his new coat.

I watched him do all of it. Because I watched everybody. And because something about that desertion had stayed with me, the way things did, that morning on the beach.

He'd run for his life, by his own account, with his whole regiment behind him, from the middle of his own camp, in the dark.

And he'd found the time to pack a valise. With his orderly book in it.



“He was a spy,” Freda said. “Wasn’t he. The sergeant.”

“He was the bravest man I saw that whole war,” he said. “On either side. He deserted his own army, with his own friends chasing him, who didn’t know, some of them, and would have shot him if they’d caught him. They’d told only the major. He swam the river in October with his valise on his back, and walked into the enemy’s city, and stood in front of the enemy’s commander-in-chief and lied to his face for an hour, and joined the traitor’s own regiment, to get near enough to him to take him.” He shook his head. “If I’d been caught doing half that, they’d have hanged me from the nearest tree. He did all of it, and they made him a sergeant.”

“And you knew.”

“I didn’t know. I wondered.” He held up one finger, the way he does. “That’s not the same, and I’m going to be honest with you about the difference. I wondered, because of the valise. A man can be chased so hard by his own side that he has to swim for it, and get away by a boat’s length, and it’s very lucky. Or it’s very well arranged. I’d arranged things myself, that year. I knew what arranged looked like.”

“Did you tell anybody?”

“No,” he said.



• RECORDING · DECEMBER 1780

Arnold lived on the Broadway that winter, near the bottom, next door to the General’s own headquarters, in a big brick house with a garden behind it that went down toward the river, and an alley along one side of the garden, with a fence of tall wooden palings between the alley and the garden. His wife came to him from Philadelphia in November, with their baby. He kept an orderly, and two servants, and he walked in his garden every night before he went to bed, alone, for a quarter of an hour, with his hands behind his back and his bad leg dragging a little. Everybody knew it. It was a thing people said about

him, the way people said things about Arnold, that he walked in his garden at midnight like a man with something on his conscience.

I knew the alley. It went down to the river between the backs of the houses, and at the bottom of it, among the slips, boats tied up at night: oyster boats, wood boats, small craft from the Jersey side. I'd walked it a hundred times. I'd stood in it holding horses.

And on a gray afternoon in early December, walking down it, I saw that somebody had been at the fence.



I'd never have seen it myself. I want to be honest about that, too. It was Prince who saw it, really. He was with me that afternoon. We'd been hired to carry a load of planks down to a boat at the bottom of the alley, and he was ahead of me with his end, and he stopped so suddenly I nearly walked into him.

"Look at that," he said. "Somebody's drawn those nails."

I looked. It was a stretch of the paling fence along Arnold's garden, five or six boards, just where the alley was darkest, under the overhang of a stable roof. To me it looked like any other stretch of fence. To Prince, who'd built more fences than I'd walked past, it looked like a door. The nails at the top and bottom of each paling had been drawn, and then pushed back into their holes, so the heads showed and the boards stood straight. But they weren't holding anything. You could have taken those palings out with your fingers, one by one, in the dark, without a sound, and stepped through into Arnold's garden, and put them back.

"That's careful work," Prince said, with professional respect. "Somebody knew what they were about."

I stood in the alley and looked at those palings, and then at the bottom of the alley, at the boats tied up among the slips. And I thought of a sergeant who'd swum the river with a packed valise on his back. And of a man who walked in his garden at midnight, alone, every night, for a quarter of an hour. And of February, and five rockets going up out of the dark country to the west, and Beckwith's finger on his map going back and back to Morristown.

I'd planned this. That's what I thought, standing there. I'd sat in a cold office ten months before and planned exactly this, for the other side. Take a general out of his own headquarters at night, in the middle of his own army, and carry him off across the water before anybody knew he was gone.

They'd only done it better.



I went to DeLancey that evening. I didn't tell him about the sergeant. I told him about the fence.

I told him that somebody had drawn the nails in the palings along General Arnold's garden, at the darkest place in the alley, and pushed them back so nobody would see, and that the alley went down to the boats, and that the General walked in that garden alone every night at midnight, and that if I were Washington, and I wanted him alive, that was where I'd take him.

DeLancey looked at me for a long time. He didn't like me. He never did. But he wasn't a fool.

"Who drew the nails?" he said.

"I don't know, sir."

That was true. I didn't. I didn't know it was the sergeant. I'd wondered. That's all. And a man can be hanged on a wonder, in that city, as easily as on a fact. I'd seen it done.

"I'll have the alley watched," DeLancey said.

"If you watch the alley, sir, they'll see you watching, and wait. And try again somewhere else, some other night, and you won't know where." I'd thought it through on the way. "Don't watch the alley. Move the General. Tomorrow. Quietly. To other quarters, without saying why. Have the fence mended. Let whoever drew those nails come to that garden on their night and find it empty, and the fence nailed shut, and the General gone, and nobody waiting for them, and nothing to show that anybody ever knew." I paused. "They'll think it was chance. They'll think the General just moved. And they'll be frightened for the rest of the war that it wasn't."

DeLancey said nothing at all for a moment.

“The Major would have liked that,” he said finally, in a strange voice.
“Yes, sir,” I said. “I think he would.”



General Arnold changed his quarters the next day. Nobody told him why, I believe, or if they did, they told him something else. The fence was mended by a carpenter from the Engineers, who complained about the state of it.

And a night or two later, the story goes, a sergeant of Arnold’s Legion and a man from Newark came down that alley in the dark to the place where the palings were loose, with a boat waiting at the bottom among the slips and a gag and a rope in their coats, and found the fence nailed shut, and the garden dark, and the house empty.

Nobody was waiting for them. Nobody took them. They went away. The sergeant sailed with Arnold’s Legion for Virginia a week or two later, on the twentieth of December, with the rest of the corps, in his British coat. And a long time after that, in Virginia, he walked away one night and found his way back to his own side, and to his major, and was given his discharge, so he’d never be taken and hanged as a deserter. I’ve always been glad of that. I’d like to have shaken his hand.

Arnold lived to be an old man too. In London, rich and despised, with nobody on either side of the ocean who’d sit at a table with him if they could help it. He died in his bed, twenty-one years later. They say he asked to be buried in his old American uniform. I don’t know if that’s true. I’d like it to be. It would be the only thing about him I ever understood.



He stopped. Freda was looking at him from the top step with an expression I couldn’t read.

“Why?” she said. “You hated him. You said he was the worst man you ever met. You could have just... not said anything. Let them take him. Nobody would ever have known.”

He thought about it, honestly, the way he thinks about everything she asks him. He'd always been honest with Freda. More honest, sometimes, than he was with me.

"Because of what Clinton said," he said. "At Paulus Hook. *A deserter was never given up*. I'd stood behind that chair for two hours, Freda, and hated that sentence more than anything I'd ever heard. And then I'd understood it. If they could take Arnold, out of his own garden, in the middle of the King's own city, then they could take anybody who'd come over. Any deserter. Any Loyalist. Any man who'd run from his master on a proclamation." He looked at her. "Arnold was a traitor and a coward and he got a better man killed. I'd have watched them hang him with pleasure. But he'd come in on the same promise I had. If the promise didn't hold for him, it didn't hold for me. Or for Prince. Or for any of us."

"So you saved him for you," Freda said.

"I saved him for all of us," he said. "And for André, I think. Because André would have." He picked up his glass. "And I did it without giving them the sergeant. So nobody hanged. On either side. That's the part I'm proud of." He drank. "The best work I did that whole year, Freda. For the worst man I ever met. That's how it goes, sometimes. You don't get to pick who you're good for."

Freda thought about that for a long time, with her chin on her knees.

"That's really annoying," she said at last.

He laughed so hard he had to hold on to the rail.



When he'd stopped laughing, and wiped his eyes, he looked at the two of us. At me in my chair, with my notebook. At Freda on the step.

"Next week," he said, "is December. The end of the year." He folded his hands on his knee. "The eggs."

Freda went very still.

"I'm going to tell you how I found her," he said. "The way I found her. In the order I found her in. And I'd like you both to be here." He looked out at

the field. “I’ve never told anybody. In all this time. I’d like to tell it to the two of you.”

The Egg Widow

It rained on the Thursday. A steady, gentle, all-day rain, the first in three weeks, the kind farmers stand at windows and watch. He had the stove lit in the kitchen when we came in, though it wasn't cold, and the kettle on, and three cups set out on the table, and in the middle of the table, on a plate, there was a little brown bowl with a dozen eggs in it.

Freda saw them and stopped in the kitchen doorway.

"Sit down," he said. "They're for later. I'll make you an omelet when it's done. I make a very good omelet." He poured the tea. "Session forty-two, Ms. Barnett."

I said it into the recorders. *Session forty-two. Thursday, August twelfth. Raining. Freda's here.* And then, because I couldn't help it, *There are eggs on the table.*

"Twelve," Freda said, from the doorway. She hadn't moved.

"Twelve," he agreed, and smiled at her. "Come and sit down, Freda. Nothing's happening today. It's a dozen."



• RECORDING · DECEMBER 1780

They let the ferryman out of the Provost two days after Christmas.

I was there. I'd asked to be told, and I was told, and I went and stood across the street from the gate in the gray morning and waited. It was cold, not like the winter before, an ordinary December cold with a little snow in the gutters. The gate opened at about nine, and the old man came out alone,

in his own clothes, with my blanket folded over his arm, blinking, and stood in the street for a moment as if he didn't know which way the river was.

Then he turned and walked down toward the East River. Slowly, an old man's walk, in the cold. And I followed him, the way I'd followed a hundred people that year, at a distance, on the other side of the street.

He went straight to the ferry. I'd thought he would. Thirty years on those sweeps. Where else would he go?

He didn't go down the stairs to the boats. He stopped at the top. At the cart.



I'd seen her there a hundred times. Two hundred. Twice a week for a year and a half, with her eggs in their two rows on the white cloth and her butter in its crock and her little iron pot of coals for the cold mornings. I'd bought eggs from her and put them inside my shirt and walked away without ever once looking at her face.

I watched her look up and see him.

She didn't say anything. She didn't make anything of it. She took two eggs out of the basket, without asking, and put them in his hand, and closed his fingers over them with her own. And held his hand closed, round the eggs, for a moment longer than anybody would have needed to. And said something to him, very low. And he nodded, and put the eggs in his coat, and went down the stairs to the boats without looking back.

She didn't charge him. I watched her not charge him.

And she looked up, then, across the street, straight at me.

Just for a moment. Not long. The way you'd look at a man you'd sold eggs to twice a week for a year and a half, standing across the street on a cold morning for no reason. And then she looked away, and straightened the rows of eggs with one finger, and rubbed her hands over her little pot of coals.

I stood there in the snow in the gutter. And something went down my arms, the way it does when a thing goes click, the way your mother's told me it does for her. And I didn't know yet what it was. I knew only that I'd been

looking at the wrong thing for a year and a half, and that I'd just looked at the right one, and that it had looked back.



He stopped. The rain was steady on the roof. Freda had come and sat down, finally, at the table, with her hands round her cup, and she was looking at the bowl of eggs.

"You didn't know," Freda said. "Even then."

"Not then. Not on the street. It took me the whole night." He turned his cup a quarter turn. "I want to tell you how. Because it's the only time in my life that body's eyes did exactly what they were for. And I want you to see it the way I saw it."



• RECORDING · DECEMBER 1780

I went back to the shed by the North River that night, and lay down on my bed with my coat over me, and shut my eyes, and went back.

You've never had eyes like Caesar's. Nobody has. I can't make you understand what it was like. The nearest I can come is this: imagine every day of your life were a book on a shelf, and you could take any one of them down and open it at any page and the page would be there, exactly as his eyes had seen it, every word, every face, the light on it. Only what he saw. Never what he heard. But all of that. And imagine that you'd never once taken down most of the books, because you hadn't known there was anything in them worth reading.

I took them down. All night. One after another.

I took down every morning I'd stood at the top of the ferry stairs, from the summer of '79 to that very morning. Every one. And I didn't look at the people waiting for the boat this time. I didn't look at the carters or the boatmen or the farmers with their baskets. I looked at the corner where the cart stood, and the woman behind it, and the basket on top of it, under its cloth.



I'll give you what I found. In the order I found it.

The first thing was her face. I'd never looked at it, in a year and a half. But Caesar's eyes had, every time, without me. It was there on every one of those mornings, on every page, waiting. A woman of perhaps thirty-five, or a little more, with a broad plain face, weathered, and a strong chin, and gray hair coming out from under a plain cap, and a little white scar through her left eyebrow. Gray cloak. Every morning, the same gray cloak.

The second thing was the eggs. Your mother wrote them down for me, Freda, every time I told her, and so did you, I suppose, when you typed it. In January, on the frozen stairs, with no boat running at all, eleven. They'd found some other way across the ice that week, I suppose. I never learned it. In March, a morning I'd been watching for the carter, eleven. In May, every time I passed, twelve. And on the twentieth of July, at dawn, with the carter going over in the first boat with his face gray and no cart, eleven.

Now I went through them all again. Every morning Caesar's eyes had caught that cart, one after another. Not every morning there was. I was away a great deal, in the Neutral Ground, on the Island, on the ice. But every morning I'd passed. And it was the same. On the days I'd seen the carter come over with a parcel the shape of a quire, or go back in a hurry, or anything at all to do with their road, there were eleven eggs in her two rows when the sun came up. A gap in the front row. One gone, before she'd sold a single one. On every other morning I'd seen, there were twelve. A full dozen. Every morning I'd passed in May, when the road was shut, twelve. Every morning I'd passed since October, when the man in the city stopped writing, twelve.

I'd counted them every time I passed, for a year and a half. I couldn't help it. I counted everything. And I'd never once asked myself why a woman who sold eggs by the dozen started some mornings with one missing.

She'd been standing at the top of the only road out of the city, in plain sight, telling them. One egg gone: there's something to carry today. A full basket: there's nothing; stay home. Every carter and boatman and courier on that road had only to walk past her cart on his way to the boat, and look at

her basket, and he'd know. And nobody had to say a word. Nobody had to carry a scrap of paper. Hill could search them all to the skin.

The cleanest thing I ever saw in that war. From either side.



And the third thing.

I went back. Back past all of it, back into the summer before, the summer I came in, to a morning in late August of '79 at Mr. Hill's new table on the Brooklyn landing. A morning I'd told your mother about, Freda, months ago, because I remember everything and can't leave anything out. A thin anxious farmer of about thirty, in a brown coat, coming off the boat from the city. And his wife on his arm, a little older than him. In a gray cloak and a plain cap. Scolding him the whole way up to the table about what he'd paid in the city for a pound of tea.

I took that page down and looked at her face.

A broad plain face, weathered. A strong chin. A little white scar through her left eyebrow.

She wasn't his wife. She'd walked a frightened man past Hill's table with his letters on him, in the first week Hill was there, when every man was searched, by scolding him so loudly about the price of tea that Hill had been glad to see the back of them both. Everybody in the line had laughed. I'd laughed.

That was her. The first time I ever saw her. And she'd been at the top of the ferry stairs every morning since, with her basket, for a year and a half, and I'd bought eggs from her twice a week, and never once looked up.



Nobody said anything.

The rain went on, soft and steady, on the roof and in the yard. The stove ticked. Freda was holding her cup in both hands and looking at him with her eyes very wide, and I realized I'd stopped writing a while ago, and that my pen was lying across the page on the word *eggs*.

"I said it," Freda said, in a small voice. "I said it was the egg lady. In the car. I said that's what you do with the eggs."

"You did," he said. "And your mother saw it in July. You were both a great deal quicker than I was." He smiled at her, a little. "I had every single piece of it in my head from the first week. Every page. And it took me a year and a half and an old man with one eye to make me open the book."

"Why didn't you see it?" Freda said. "If you saw everything?"

He thought about that for a long time.

"Because I was looking for a man," he said. "A gentleman. A man of business, with good paper and a good coat. That's who I told Beckwith I was looking for, in March, with my finger on his map. And I never once thought to look at a woman selling eggs. Not because I thought she couldn't. Because I didn't think of her at all." He looked down at his hands. "And I'd spent my whole life in that body being the man at the edge of the room nobody thought of at all. I should have known better than anybody alive. That's what I've never forgiven myself for, Freda. Not that I lost her. That I didn't see her, because she was standing exactly where I stood."



● RECORDING · DECEMBER 1780

I didn't sleep. At first light I was at the top of the ferry stairs.

The cart was there. The shallow basket on top, the eggs in their two rows on the white cloth. The butter in its crock. The little iron pot of coals, with the coals just catching.

And a different woman behind it.

Younger. Stout, red-faced, cheerful, with her hands wrapped in rags against the cold, stamping her feet. I'd never seen her in my life. And Caesar's eyes were quite certain of that.

I asked her, as carelessly as I could, as a man who bought eggs there twice a week and was used to another face, where the widow was.

"Gone over to the Island," the young woman said. "Yesterday, on the noon boat. Her sister's poorly, out Setauket way. I'm minding the cart for

her.” She tipped the basket toward me. “Eggs? They’re good. She’d want me to keep her people.”

I looked down into the basket. I didn’t need to count them. I counted them anyway.

Twelve.

“What’s her name?” I said. “The widow.”

The young woman looked at me oddly. A Black man asking a white woman’s name, at the top of the ferry stairs, at dawn.

“Widow Ames,” she said. “Everybody knows Widow Ames.” She nudged an egg back into its row. “You’d know her if you saw her. She’s been here forever.”

I bought two eggs. I don’t know why. I stood at the top of the stairs with them warm in my hand, and watched the first boat of the morning push off for Brooklyn, with half a dozen people in it, none of whom was a woman in a gray cloak. She’d gone over the day before. On the noon boat. A few hours after an old one-eyed ferryman came out of the Provost and walked straight to her cart, and she’d looked up and seen me across the street.

One day.

If I’d seen it on the street, instead of in the night. If I’d gone to the cart, then and there, in the snow in the gutter, instead of home to my bed to take down my books. One day.



He stopped. He got up from the table, slowly, with one hand on its edge, and went to the counter, and took a pan down from the hook over the stove, and put it on the burner, and a lump of butter in it, and stood watching the butter melt.

“Did you go after her?” I said. “To Setauket?”

He didn’t turn round.

“No,” he said.

“Did you tell DeLancey? Her name? What she looked like?”

The butter began to foam. He picked up the brown bowl from the table, and took out four eggs, one at a time, and cracked them, one-handed, into a

bowl, the way people do who've done it ten thousand times.

"Next week," he said. "That's next week. The last one. I'd like to make you both an omelet now."

He beat the eggs with a fork, briskly, and tipped them into the pan, and the kitchen filled with the smell of it, warm and plain and good, with the rain on the roof. And I looked at the bowl on the table.

Eight left. He'd taken four.

Freda was looking at it too. She looked up at me. She didn't say anything. She didn't need to.

He made the omelet, and folded it in the pan, and cut it in three, and put it on three plates, with toast, and sat down with us, and we ate it, the three of us, at the kitchen table, in the rain, and it was the best omelet I have ever had in my life, and nobody said one word about eggs for the rest of the afternoon.

The Story Runs

I called my old editor on the Monday after the valley. The second of August.

Her name is Ruth Okafor. She was the one who'd hired me, and the one who'd stood in the doorway of the conference room six years ago while the lawyers talked, with her arms folded, and said nothing, and the one who'd handed me the box at the end. She was managing editor now. I'd seen her name on the masthead every Sunday for six years and never once called the number underneath it.

She picked up on the second ring.

"Iola," she said. Not surprised. Wary. The way you'd say the name of somebody who'd been dead and was now apparently on the phone.

"He's alive," I said. "Bookbinder. My source. I found him. I've sat in his kitchen. He's got the papers, all of them, the originals he copied, in two boxes, and he wants to go on the record. With his name. Under mine."

There was a long silence on the line. I could hear the newsroom behind her, faintly, the way you hear the sea in a shell. Phones. Somebody laughing.

"Come in," Ruth said. "Today. Bring nothing. We'll talk in my office with the door shut." She paused. "And Iola. Don't tell anybody else. Not one person."

"I've told one person," I said. "He's eighty and he lives in Pennsylvania and he's never going to tell anyone anything."

"Well," Ruth said, after a moment. "That's a start."



It took two weeks. That's very fast, for a story like that. It should have taken two months. It would have, except for one thing Claire found, on the second day.

Carrow House had a fall sale coming. *Autograph Letters, Manuscripts and Historical Documents*, the same heavy cream catalog with the brass doors on the cover. It was already printed. It was on their website. And in it, on page forty-one, there was a letter, signed by a general from the Revolutionary War, estimated at forty to sixty thousand dollars, that was described, word for word, as a letter my source had been asked to repair, eight years ago, with damage that was new. It was in his copies. It was in the boxes.

They were selling it again.

"Then we haven't got two months," Ruth said, when I showed her. "We've got until the sale."



The boxes came out of the barn in Middleburg on the third of August.

Claire went to her father. She went alone, and she told me afterward that she'd sat at his kitchen table, in the stone house, the way he'd sat with her at the kitchen table six years before, and told him that a woman had come to her barn and asked how long she'd waited, and that she'd answered, and that she'd driven the woman over the mountains to the valley, and that it was done.

"What did he say?" I asked her.

"Nothing, for a long time," Claire said. "Then he laughed." She was quiet. "Not the big one. A small one. And then he cried. I've never seen him cry. Not when Mom died. Not ever." She looked at her hands. "And then he got up and went out to the barn and climbed up the ladder to the loft himself. At seventy-nine. I couldn't stop him. He brought the first box down himself, on his shoulder, one rung at a time. He said he'd carried it up, and he'd carry it down."

I met him once. Only once. On the fourth, at the stone house, because he'd asked to see me, and Claire said I didn't have to, and I went anyway.

He was smaller than in the video. He sat in a wing chair by a cold fireplace in a room full of books, in a cardigan, with a rug over his knees in August, and he didn't get up when I came in, and he didn't laugh. He looked at me for a long

time, and then he said the thing I'd known since the porch that he'd say, and that I'd been afraid of, because I didn't know what I'd do with it.

"I told my daughter," he said, "that reporters always land on their feet." He looked at the cold fireplace. "I've been wrong about a great many things in my life, Ms. Barnett. I've been wrong about paper. I've been wrong about people. I was very wrong about that." He looked back at me. "And I repaired some of those letters. Myself. Before he ever did. Over many years. I'd like you to know that from me, and not from a box."

I didn't say anything. I didn't trust myself to.

"Print it," Gerald Whitcombe said. "Print all of it. My name too. I'm seventy-nine. I'd rather it was true than kind."



The paper sent the letters to two independent document examiners, one in New York and one in London, and they came back in eight days, both of them, and said what my source had said seven years before. New damage. Old paper. Modern ink, very cleverly aged, in places that had been made to look like repairs. The lawyers read everything three times. Carrow House was given forty-eight hours to respond, by email and by courier, and didn't, and then, at five minutes to the deadline, sent a statement saying they were reviewing their consignment procedures and had withdrawn three lots from the fall sale *out of an abundance of caution*.

The story ran on Sunday, the fifteenth of August, on the front page, above the fold.

Two bylines. Mine first. His second. His real name, which I'd never written in eight months and six years, in black type on newsprint on every doorstep in the city, under mine.

And on page two, in a box, a short note from the editors. It said that six years before, the paper had published a correction to a story by Iola Barnett about forged documents at Carrow House. It said that the correction had been wrong. It said that the paper regretted it, and apologized to Ms. Barnett and to her source.

It was eleven lines long. The correction, six years ago, had been longer than some of my stories. I counted the lines in the apology twice, at the kitchen table, at six in the morning, in my bathrobe, with the paper spread out in front of me and a cup of coffee going cold at my elbow.

Eleven.

I didn't know whether to laugh or cry, so I did both, for a while, by myself, before Freda woke up.



Freda took a copy to Mrs. Dunleavy. She asked to. She took the bus to Frederick on the Monday, with the paper in a plastic sleeve so it wouldn't get creased, and sat in Kevin Dunleavy's front room while his mother read the whole thing, every word, with a magnifying glass, sitting very upright in her chair.

"She read it twice," Freda reported that night. "Then she said, *I told Petrakis that man upstairs was up to something. He never listened.* Then she made me take a cookie." Freda paused. "Then she asked if Mr. Hale was the one in the story who figured out the car. Because she'd liked him on the tape. I said yes. She said, *Tell him from me, he's got a good ear for stairs.*"

Petrakis called on the Tuesday, from his daughter's house in Silver Spring, with the television on. He said he'd read it. He said he'd always known that tenant was a good tenant, except the rent. He said, "And the cat? The cat is all right?" and I told him about the family with two little girls, and he was quiet for a moment, and then he said, "Good. Good. Stupid cat. Nice cat," and hung up.

I got eleven hundred emails that week. Most of them were kind. Some of them were from people who'd written very unkind things about me six years before, and wanted me to know they'd been wrong, which was more than most people do. Three of them were offers of work. Real work. I didn't answer any of them yet.

Bookbinder called on the Sunday night, from the valley, after it ran. He didn't say anything for a while. Then he said, "They spelled it right," and I said I'd checked, three times, and he laughed, a small, startled laugh, as if he'd forgotten he could.



And on the Monday, the regular money came. The six thousand, for the Thursday before, as it had come every Monday since January.

But this time something was wrong with it.

I wouldn't have noticed, a year ago. I'd have looked at the amount and closed the app. But I'd spent a year with a man who noticed eleven eggs instead of twelve, and I'd learned to look at the edges of things. And at the bottom of the deposit, where the bank shows you who sent it, where for nine months it had said only the name of the law firm, *Aldine, Mercer and Voss*, and once, in May, the name of a bank in another city, there was a longer line than usual. Somebody, somewhere, in some office, had made a mistake, and sent it from the wrong account, and the bank had printed the whole thing.

*ORIG: TRUSTEES OF THE HALLORAN FUND (EST. 1938) /
HARTFORD CT / FBO A M & V CLIENT ACCT.*

I sat and looked at it for a long time.

Then I did what I do. I looked it up. And it was real. The Halloran Fund was a charitable trust, registered in Connecticut, established in 1938. Its purpose, according to the one filing I could find, a single page from the 1950s scanned into the state's archive, was *the support of historical inquiry and the preservation of testimony*. Its trustees were a bank in Hartford. It had no website. It had never, as far as I could find, given a single grant to anybody.

Except me. For ten months.

1938. Eighty-nine years ago. Before the war.

I didn't know what it meant. I still don't. But it was real, and it held up, and it was the first true thing I'd ever learned about the man who sent me the cards, apart from the shaking in his hand. Somebody, eighty-nine years ago, had set up a fund to preserve testimony. And the testimony it had been waiting for, all that time, was being told on a porch in Adams County, Pennsylvania, every Thursday, to me.

I wrote it in my notebook. *Halloran Fund. Est. 1938. Hartford. "Preservation of testimony."* And underneath, because it was the only honest thing I could think of: *Waiting since before the war. For what?*



And one more thing, that week, because I'd promised myself.

On the Wednesday, the eighteenth, I spent the afternoon looking for a line in a box in a library. The way he'd told me to. *Find it.*

The Clinton Papers are at the William L. Clements Library, at the University of Michigan. Hundreds of volumes of them. Every letter, every report, every scrap of paper that crossed Sir Henry Clinton's desk in the whole war, bound into big books and numbered. I couldn't go to Michigan. But the library has a guide, a long, dry, wonderful list, volume by volume, of what's in each one, written by archivists over many years. I read it for four hours. Volume after volume. Spies, deserters, returns of troops, complaints about firewood.

And there, in volume eighty-seven, among the papers for the last days of February and the first days of March 1780, in the plain flat language of an archivist cataloguing a box, there was a line.

British deserter caught and turned in by three African Americans.

That's all. Three of them, no names, in a line in a guide to a box in a library in Michigan. The archivist had used a modern word, the polite word of our own time, for whatever word the officer had written by his lantern at Kingsbridge on a cold night in 1780. But it was there.

He'd told me in June. I'd found it in August. It had taken me four hours, and I'd known exactly what I was looking for, and where.

I turned to the back of my notebook, to the last page. The one I write on only when he tells me something before I find it. And I wrote it down, and dated it, the way I do.

Then I closed the notebook, and sat at the kitchen table in the late afternoon with my hand flat on the cover. And thought about a big good-tempered wagoner called Isaac, who'd bought a hat with his shilling, and worn it till he died.

A Certain Woman

I brought him the paper.

Not a copy off the internet. The real thing, the Sunday paper, the whole heavy fat front section of it, folded under my arm. I'd bought six at the gas station on the Sunday morning, at five, when the bundles came off the truck, and the man behind the counter had looked at me as if I'd lost my mind, and I'd told him I had a story in it, and he'd said, "Well, congratulations," and given me a free coffee.

He was at the bottom of the steps. Of course he was. Freda didn't wait for me. She was out of the car before I'd turned off the engine, with a copy of her own, the one she'd kept back from Mrs. Dunleavy's, and she held it out to him across the gravel with both hands, the way you'd hand somebody a baby.

He took it. He didn't open it. He held it, and looked at the front page, above the fold, at the headline and the two names under it, for a very long time. Then he looked at me.

"They spelled his right?" he said.

"Three times," I said. "I checked."

"Of course you did," he said, and folded the paper carefully under his arm, the way I'd been carrying mine, and went up the steps with it, one hand on the rail.



He read the whole thing on the porch, every word, slowly, with his glasses on, while Freda and I sat and watched him and the recorders sat on the little table,

not running yet. It took him half an hour. When he'd finished he turned to page two, and read the box, the eleven lines, twice. Then he took his glasses off and folded the paper and put it on the bench beside him, on top of the cardi-gan, and laid his hand flat on it.

"Eleven," he said.

"I know."

He looked at me, and then he laughed, and it was the laugh that made him hold the rail. Freda started laughing too, without knowing why, and then I did, and the three of us sat on that porch in the August heat laughing at the number eleven until Freda had to put her head down on her knees.

"Mrs. Dunleavy says you've got a good ear for stairs," Freda said, when she could.

He wiped his eyes.

"Tell her," he said, "that I learned it from her."



I said the date into the recorders. *Session forty-three. Thursday, August nineteenth.* And then, because I'd promised myself, before we started, I told him about the money.

The deposit on the Monday, with the wrong account on it. *Trustees of the Halloran Fund, established 1938, Hartford.* The single scanned page from the 1950s. *The support of historical inquiry and the preservation of testimony.* Eighty-nine years.

He'd been looking at the field while I talked. When I said *1938*, he didn't move. Nothing in his face moved at all. I'd learned what that meant, that year. I'd watched it at the Carpathia card, and at Damon's letter. It's what his face does when it's decided to do nothing.

"1938," he said, after a while. Quietly. To the field.

"Does it mean something?"

"It was a good year to start waiting," he said. "If you knew what was coming." He turned and looked at me, and his face had come back. "Write it down, Ms. Barnett. You were right to. It's true, and it's the first true thing, and he didn't mean you to have it." He picked up his glass of water. "Which means

somebody in a bank in Hartford is having a very bad week. Leave it there for now. It'll keep. It's kept eighty-nine years."

And then he wouldn't say anything else about it. I didn't ask twice. I'd learned that, too.



"And I found it," I said. "The line. The three Black men."

He went very still.

"In the guide to the Clinton Papers," I said. "Volume eighty-seven. The last days of February and the first of March, 1780. *British deserter caught and turned in by three African Americans*. That's how the archivist wrote it. It took me four hours."

I opened my notebook to the last page, the one I keep, the one with nothing crossed out. And I read it to him. All three entries. Ned Hurly in the Point Lookout register, from the winter. Lowell Hatch in the *Tribune*, from the spring. And the new one.

When I'd finished, he didn't say anything for a long time. He was looking at the field, and his hands were folded on his knee, and they weren't quite steady.

"Isaac would be pleased," he said at last. "He'd want to know if they'd spelled him right." He smiled, a little. "Tell him they didn't spell any of us. That's all right. That's how it was. We knew who we were."



"You said next week," I said. "Last week. You said this would be the last one."

"I did."

"Did you tell DeLancey? About her?"

He didn't answer straight away. He looked at Freda, on the top step, and she looked back at him, and something passed between them that I wasn't part of, and didn't mind not being part of.

"I'll tell you exactly what I told him," he said. "And then I'll tell you why. And then you can decide what you think, the way you always do."

He folded his hands.

“Yes,” he said.



• RECORDING · JANUARY 1781

DeLancey sent for me at the beginning of January, as the year turned, the way a man calls in his accounts.

He wanted to know what I’d found. All of it. The whole year. He’d had my reports, in bits, as they came, through Beckwith and Robinson and André, and now André was dead and he wanted it all in one place, laid out on André’s long table, so he could see it. So I gave it to him. The paper, and the ink that answered only to its own key. The carter, without his face. The road along the north shore, fifty-five miles. Setauket. The boat, and the man who came over in it, whose name everybody knew. The officer in Connecticut who took the letters at the other end. The man in the city, a gentleman of business, without his name, because I didn’t know it, and without his shop, because I did.

And then DeLancey asked the question I’d known he’d ask. Because he wasn’t a fool.

“And in Setauket?” he said. “Where does the boat take them up? From whom?”

I’d lain awake three nights over that question, Ms. Barnett. Freda. In the shed by the North River, with my eyes shut and her face on every page.

“At or near a certain woman’s, sir,” I said.

He looked up.

“Which woman?”

“I don’t know, sir,” I said.



“You lied,” Freda said.

“I lied,” he said. “To his face. Across André’s table. The only time in that whole two years I ever lied to any of them about anything that mattered.” He looked at her. “And I’d do it again. I’d do it every time.”

“Why?”

He was quiet for a long time. A long time. The bees went in the clover. Somewhere down the gravel road a car went by, slowly, and the dust drifted across the field, and settled.

“Because I knew what they’d do,” he said finally. “DeLancey would have had her taken on the Island, and brought to the city, and put in the Provost, and asked. And she wouldn’t have told them anything, any more than my ferryman did. And then he’d have had to decide what to do with her. And he’d have done what they did with André.” He turned his cup on the table, a quarter turn. “I’d have put her in a coat that hanged her. I’d promised myself, on the White Plains road, that I’d never do that to anybody again. Not even them. Not even her.”

“That’s not all,” I said.

He looked at me.

“No,” he said. “That’s not all. You’re right.” He looked back at the field. “She’d beaten me, Ms. Barnett. Fairly. Every morning for a year and a half, at the top of the only road, in front of everybody, in plain sight, with a basket of eggs. She’d beaten the best I had, and I’d had the best eyes that ever lived, and she’d done it by standing where I stood. At the edge of the room. Where nobody looks.” He was quiet. “If I’d given them her face, I’d have taught them to look there. At the edge. At the woman with the cart and the man holding the horse and the carpenter mending the fence. They’d never once looked at us, that whole war. That was the only safety any of us had.” He looked at Freda. “If I’d taught them to look at her, the next people they looked at would have been Prince. And Isaac. And me.”

Freda had her arms round her knees again.

“So you let her go,” she said. “For you. Again.”

“For all of us,” he said. “Again.” And then, gently, “And for her. Because she was the best I ever saw. And I didn’t want to be the man who caught her.” He picked up his glass and found it empty and set it down. “I’ve never once been sorry. Not once, in all the years since. I’ve been sorry about nearly everything else.”



“The line,” I said. “In my notebook. From the research I did, for the Facts. There’s a British agent’s letter, from February of 1781, to DeLancey. It says the letters come *by the way of Setauket, where a certain Brewster receives them at, or near, a certain woman’s.*”

He smiled. Slowly.

“That was a man in Connecticut,” he said. “A double agent of sorts, called Heron, who sold the British news and sold the rebels news and was never quite sure himself which side he was on. DeLancey sent him what I’d said, and asked him to find out more, from the other side. And Heron wrote back in February and told him exactly what I’d told him, in my own words, as if he’d found it out himself.” He shook his head. “A certain woman’s. I recognized it the moment DeLancey read it to me. That was the closest the British ever came, in the whole war, to the woman with the eggs. Two words. Mine.”

“And nobody ever found her.”

“Nobody ever found her,” he said. “I looked, myself. Afterward. In every record there is. There’s no Widow Ames. Not in New York, not in Setauket, not anywhere. She was never caught, and never named, and never written down, except once, as a word in a code book.” He looked at me. “Three hundred and fifty-five. Lady. That’s all anybody will ever know about her. That’s all she ever wanted anybody to know.”



He told the rest quickly. He said it was his story, not the war’s, and that the war’s ending was in every book.

The war went on another year. In October of 1781, at Yorktown, in Virginia, Cornwallis surrendered his whole army to Washington and the French, and that was the end, though nobody in New York would believe it for a long time. The British held the city for two more years while the diplomats talked in Paris. And in the treaty they signed, there was a line that said the British would leave without *carrying away any Negroes or other property of the American inhabitants.*

“Property,” he said. “That was us. In the treaty. Between the cattle and the furniture.”

In May of 1783, Washington came to meet the new British commander, Sir Guy Carleton, at a village on the Hudson, to arrange the handing over of the city. And to ask for his property back. Including the people who had run from Mount Vernon, his own household, who were in New York.

“It was Tappan,” he said. “Orangetown, they called it by then. The same village. I’ve always thought that was something. The same village where they hanged André, three years before.” He looked at the field. “Carleton said no. He said the men and women who’d come in on the King’s proclamations were free before the treaty was ever signed, and that handing them back would be, I’ll give you his words, *a dishonourable violation of the public faith*. He said the King’s promise would be kept. And he wrote down all our names in a book, every one of us, with our ages and where we’d come from and who’d owned us, so that if Britain was ever found to be wrong, the owners could be paid for us instead.”

“The Book of Negroes,” I said. I’d read about it, for the Facts.

“Three thousand names,” he said. “Mine’s in it. Not Caesar Freeman. The clerk wrote something else, and I let him, by then. I won’t tell you what. You’d find it in an afternoon, and I’d like one thing in that whole life left that you didn’t.”

And each of them was given a certificate, he said, signed on behalf of the new Commandant of the city, General Birch. The same Birch who’d led the cavalry over the crusted snow toward Morristown, that February, and sent up the five rockets, and turned round. *This is to certify*, the certificates said, *that the Bearer hereof, a Negro, resorted to the British Lines, in consequence of the Proclamations of Sir William Howe, and Sir Henry Clinton*. And that he had permission to go to Nova Scotia, or wherever else he might think proper.

“Any occupation which he shall think proper,” he said. “Wherever else he may think proper. They never could bring themselves to say the word. But they kept the promise.” He rubbed his thumb along the folded edge of the newspaper beside him. “I’ve never decided how I feel about that either.”



“Where did you go?” Freda said.

“Nova Scotia,” he said. “In the summer of ‘83. On a ship full of people with certificates in their pockets. With Prince, and Isaac, and Isaac’s hat.” He smiled. “It was colder than the Hard Winter. The land they gave us was rock and spruce and fog, and they gave it late, and less of it than they’d promised, and some of us never got any at all. We built a town there and named it after Birch, because his name was on our papers. Prince built half of it. He finally got to build something.”

“And then?”

“And then, nine years later, a man called Thomas Peters, who’d been a sergeant in the Black Pioneers, went to London and talked his way into the government and came back with ships. And twelve hundred of us went with him, in fifteen ships, out of Halifax harbor in January, across the whole Atlantic, to Africa. To Sierra Leone. To build a town of our own, where nobody owned anybody.” He looked at the field. “We called it Freetown. Caesar Freeman went to Freetown. I thought that was rather good, at the time.”

“Is that where you...”

“The second year,” he said. “Of fever. A great many of us did. I was forty-three, and free, and I’d built my own house with Prince, with a door that shut.” He looked down at his hands. “And Caesar’s eyes went with him. Everything I saw after that, in every life since, I’ve had to remember the ordinary way. Badly. With the edges worn off.” He looked at Freda, and then at me. “Except the two of you. I’ll remember the two of you the ordinary way. And I find that I don’t mind at all.”



The card came on the Wednesday after. The twenty-fifth.

By courier, at a quarter to nine at night, the same young man in the same reflective jacket. “Evening, Ms. Barnett.” The tablet for my finger. The envelope. “Have a good one.”

Freda was at the kitchen table, with her school supplies spread out in front of her, labeling folders, because school started on the Monday and she’d decided, this year, to be organized, which I didn’t expect to last. She looked up when I came back with the envelope. She put the label maker down.

One card. Heavy cream paper.

I could barely read it. The hand was worse. Much worse. The letters were very large, as if somebody had been holding the pen close to the paper and close to his eyes, and they leaned and wandered and came apart, and in one place the pen had gone right through the card.

It took me a long time.

Please ask him about the war. The second one. All of it.

Freda read it upside down. Then she looked at me.

"All of it," she said.



I read it to him on the porch, on the Thursday. The last Thursday of August. The light was already different, the way it gets at the end of summer, lower and more golden, with the long shadows coming early across the field. I said the date into the recorders before anything else, because I always do. *Session forty-four. Thursday, August twenty-sixth.*

I gave him the card first, before the words, the way I always do now. He held it in the sun for a long time and looked at the hand. He touched the place where the pen had gone through.

"He's very near the end," he said quietly. "He's asking for all of it because he knows there isn't time to ask for it a piece at a time." He looked up at me. "He's right. There isn't."

Then he read the words.

I watched his face. Eleven seconds, the first card. Forty, at the Carpathia. A slow smile, at New York. This time it was none of those. This time his face did something I'd never seen it do before, in a whole year of watching it. It got older. All at once, in the sun, in front of me. As if every one of the years he'd lived had come and sat down on him together.

"All of it," he said.

"Were you there?" I said. "In the war. The second one."

He laughed. It wasn't much of a laugh. It was mostly breath.

"Several times," he said.

I didn't understand. And then I did, and I felt it go down my arms.

“Several...”

“It was a long war, Ms. Barnett. Six years. Seventy million people died in it. Some of them were me.” He set the card down on the bench beside him, face up, very gently, the way he’d set down the New York card in the spring. “And not always on the same side.”

Freda, on the top step, had gone completely still.

He looked out at the field. The swallows were going over it low, in long curves, the way they do at the end of August, feeding before they leave.

“I’d like to ask you for two small things,” he said, still watching them. “And I’d like you not to ask me why. Not today.”

“All right.”

“Don’t ever change your email. Or your telephone number. People do, these days, every few years, for no reason at all. Don’t.”

I almost laughed. It was such an old man’s thing to ask. “I’ve had the same number for eighteen years.”

“Keep it for eighteen more.” He turned his head and looked at me, and he wasn’t smiling. “And the second thing. If you ever get a letter, or one of those emails, from somebody you don’t know, from anywhere, however young they sound, and it starts with the number of a session, read it to the end.”

“Which session?”

“The last one we had,” he said. “Whichever that turns out to be. You’ll know it. You write them all down.”

Freda had turned round on the step and was looking at him. He didn’t look at her. He looked at me until I nodded. Then he looked back out at the field, and the swallows, and the long gold light going across it toward the trees.

“Bring a bigger notebook,” he said.



End of Book Three

Facts

The British took New York in September 1776 and held it for seven years, until November 25, 1783. Days after they marched in, a fire burned something like a quarter of the town, Trinity Church with it. People lived in the cellars of the burned houses under old sails. They called it Canvas Town.

On June 7, 1779, the British commandant of New York, Major General Daniel Jones, ordered that “All Negroes that fly from the Enemy’s Country are Free.” Three weeks later Sir Henry Clinton’s Philipsburg Proclamation promised any runaway from a rebel master “full Security to follow within these Lines, any Occupation which he shall think proper.” It never uses the word free.

The winter of 1779 to 1780 was the hardest anyone on that coast had recorded. New York harbor froze. Men, sleighs, cavalry and, by one account, the heaviest cannon crossed the ice to Staten Island and New Jersey. The city needed about six hundred cords of firewood a week and at times had seventy. The Chief Justice wrote that “We often hear of the Deaths of the Poor, frozen in their Houses.”

On the night of January 14, 1780, some three thousand Americans crossed the ice in sleighs to attack Staten Island. Deserters had warned the British commander, Brigadier Thomas Stirling, and his men were inside their forts. The Americans spent two freezing nights in the open, and about five hundred were frostbitten. On February 10, three hundred British cavalry set out across New Jersey to seize George Washington at Morristown. A crust of frozen sleet cut the horses’ legs, and after five or six miles their commander, Lieutenant Colonel Samuel Birch, sent up five rockets and turned back.

The William L. Clements Library's guide to the Clinton Papers describes an item from the end of February 1780 as a "British deserter caught and turned in by three African Americans." The words are the catalog's. No names are given.

Washington's spies in New York, the Culper Ring, wrote in an invisible "sympathetic stain" made by Dr. James Jay, which showed only when brushed with a second liquid. They hid their letters among blank sheets of writing paper and used a codebook of numbers. 711 was Washington. 727 was New York. 355 was the word "lady." It appears once, in a letter of August 15, 1779, from Abraham Woodhull of Setauket: "by the assistance of a 355 of my acquaintance, shall be able to out wit them all." The day before, the Royal Gazette had announced that John Hill, inspector at the Brooklyn ferry, would examine everyone crossing. The lady in that line has never been conclusively identified. Some historians have suggested Anna Strong, a Setauket neighbor of Woodhull's; others think the evidence too thin to name anyone.

The ring's man in the city was Robert Townsend, a merchant. In April 1780 he refused to keep writing, and on May 19 Washington wrote that "the intercourse may be dropped." It started again in July, when the French landed at Newport. On July 20, 1780, Woodhull, sick in bed, sent the city's news to the boat with a note: "let not an hour pass: for this day must not be lost." It was not the first warning to reach Newport. Townsend's part in the ring was proved only in 1930, when the historian Morton Pennypacker had his handwriting matched to the letters.

Benedict Arnold, commanding West Point, wrote to the British for more than a year in a cipher of page, line and word, and asked twenty thousand pounds for the fort. Major John André, Clinton's adjutant general, went up the Hudson on the sloop Vulture to meet him on the night of September 21, 1780. At dawn American guns drove the Vulture downriver. Arnold sent André back by land, in a civilian coat, with papers in his stockings. On the morning of September 23, near Tarrytown, three militiamen stopped him. He told them he was a British officer.

The last canto of André's comic poem "The Cow-Chace," about General Wayne's failed attack on a Loyalist blockhouse, was printed in New York on September 23, the day he was taken.

On September 30, an American officer at a supper at Paulus Hook hinted that André would be freed if Arnold were given up. Clinton's answer, as it was remembered, was that "a deserter was never given up." André was hanged at Tappan at noon on October 2, 1780. He asked to be shot. He tied the handkerchief over his own eyes and asked those present to bear witness that he met his fate like a brave man. In New York every British officer wore *crêpe*. Two weeks later Townsend wrote: "I never felt more sensibly for the death of a person whom I knew only by sight, and had heard converse, than I did for Major André."

On October 20, 1780, Washington approved a plan to kidnap Arnold from New York and bring him back "alive." Sergeant Major John Champe of Lee's Legion deserted that night, swam to a British galley and enlisted in Arnold's own regiment. The plan, according to his commander's memoir, failed because Arnold changed his quarters the day before. Champe sailed with Arnold for Virginia in December and slipped back to his own side there.

In May 1783, at Orangetown, the village where André was hanged, Washington met Sir Guy Carleton to arrange the British departure. Carleton refused to return the Black men and women who had come in under the proclamations, calling it "a dishonourable violation of the public faith." He recorded about three thousand of them in a ledger now called the Book of Negroes, which also lists people still enslaved to departing Loyalists. A joint board heard claims from American owners, and a few people were handed back. Most of those who had come in under the proclamations were given a certificate "By Order of Brigadier General Birch," the same Birch who had sent up the rockets.

Most of them went to Nova Scotia, where they founded Birchtown. In January 1792 about twelve hundred sailed from Halifax in fifteen ships for Sierra Leone,

led in part by Thomas Peters, once a sergeant in the Black Pioneers, and founded Freetown.

Britain passed the act ending slavery in its empire in 1833. The United States ended it in 1865.

Iola's Notebook

The last page of my notebook. I write on it only when he tells me something before I find it. Nothing on it gets crossed out. If I turn out to be wrong, I write that underneath.

What he knew before I did

1. Session 7. Pvt. E. Hurly, "Ned." Point Lookout register: *Hurly, E. Pvt.*, d. Feb. 6, 1865, chr. diarrhoea. It's on the microfilm. Anyone with an afternoon could find it. BUT he told me the clerks spelled it three ways before I looked, and when I held back the date, he gave it to me. Not proof. Keeping the page anyway.

2. Session 23. Lowell Hatch. *New-York Tribune*, Sat. Apr. 20, 1912, p. 7, bottom of *Incidents of the Rescue Ship's Voyage*. Three lines. Most of a day, reading columns by eye, because the search can't read the small print. I didn't choose the Carpathia. The client did, on a card, in February. He had one week between the card and the first Thursday in March. Possible. Not likely. Brown suit, two fingers, "Good boy." Nobody builds that from three lines. *I don't know that.*

Session 24. Read it to him on the porch. He says he never looked. "I didn't want to see how short it was."

3. Session 33. A deserter, a British corporal with a book of drawings of the posts, caught on the last of the ice at Kingsbridge at the end of February 1780 by three Black men. Caesar, Prince, Isaac. He said there was a line about it somewhere in Clinton's papers, with no names in it. Found it on Aug. 18: the William L. Clements Library's guide to the Henry Clinton Papers, vol. 87, papers of Feb.

27 to Mar. 3, 1780: *British deserter caught and turned in by three African Americans*. Four hours, and I knew what I was looking for and where. The words are the archivist's, not the officer's. I haven't seen the page itself. No names. He said there wouldn't be. Not proof. Anyone could find it, if they knew to look. He knew to look in June.

Session 43. Read it to him on the porch. "Isaac would be pleased." He says to tell them they didn't spell any of them. "We knew who we were."